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Prologue

Kanvi's Apartment (Present Life)

The city was drenched in silence. Outside her apartment window, a flickering neon sign painted a pale blue glow across the cracked walls of the street. The hum of the sign was the only rhythm in the stillness of midnight.

Kanvi sat at the edge of her bed, still in her wrinkled hospital scrubs. The stethoscope around her neck was cold against her skin, a reminder of the fourteen-hour shift she had just endured. She was exhausted, her eyelids heavy, but sleep never came easily to her. Not anymore.

She was petite, her frame delicate, her face lit faintly by the neon outside. Even in fatigue, her beauty was undeniable—something timeless, like the glow of a flame refusing to die out. There was an aura about her, one that her colleagues often noticed but could never quite explain. She looked fragile, and yet there was an intensity in her eyes that made her unforgettable. Kanvi was very, very gorgeous, not because of vanity, but because every fragment of her being radiated an inner light—the compassion of a healer, the longing of a dreamer, and the ache of someone carrying a story untold.

On her desk rested a sleek glass panel, pulsing softly with streams of light. It was her most secret possession: the AI Dream-Logger. A device illegal outside experimental labs, but smuggled into her possession by a scientist she once knew—someone whose name still haunted her heart.

The machine's voice was cold, clinical, and utterly detached:
"Subject preparing for REM phase. Neural activity at 37%. Emotional fluctuations detected."

Kanvi closed her eyes, brushing a loose strand of hair back from her face. "Even you can hear it, can't you?" she whispered to the machine. "Even you can feel him."

The AI responded with a soft chime, then silence.

Her gaze fell on the glowing thread-like patterns dancing across the Dream-Logger's interface. Each line was an echo of her brainwaves, but to her eyes, they weren't just signals. They were memories. They were fragments of someone she had not seen in years—Akki.

Tall, sharp-minded, impossibly logical Akki. The scientist whose laughter still rang in her memories, the boy she once sat beside in school corridors.

Kanvi exhaled slowly, her lips trembling with an emotion she refused to name. Then, as she lay back and allowed the device to sync with her neural rhythms, the AI announced:

"REM entry confirmed. Initializing dream capture."

The glow of the panel spilled across her face as her breathing slowed. The world dissolved.

And Kanvi slipped into the first dream layer.

Entering the Dream Corridor

The fall into sleep was never gentle for Kanvi. It came like a sudden pull, as if invisible threads had tightened around her body and dragged her downward.

The first thing she saw was a corridor—long, endless, its white walls glowing faintly. The air was thick with silence, heavy with something unsaid. The floor beneath her feet seemed to ripple like water, yet it held her weight.

She glanced back. The door she had come through had already vanished. Ahead, only the corridor stretched, impossibly long, bending in a way that made her dizzy.

A voice hummed in her ear—not human, not warm, but mechanical.
"Dream Layer One: Stable. Neural synchronization—74%. Emotional triggers—detected."

Her breath caught. The AI was with her, even here. The Dream-Logger wasn't just recording anymore; it was inside the dream, guiding, analyzing, and—perhaps—watching.

Kanvi raised her hand. Threads of pale blue light wove themselves along the walls, shimmering faintly. Every pulse seemed to vibrate in her chest, as if her heartbeat was stitched to the fabric of this place.

She walked slowly, fingers brushing the cold, smooth surface of the corridor. With every step, the walls shifted color—white melting into pale yellow, then into green. Her heart stumbled in her chest.

It was familiar. Too familiar.

The walls weren't hospital white anymore. They were the same faded yellow and green of her school corridors.

Her pace quickened. The silence broke—distant echoes filled the air: chalk scratching across blackboards, the chatter of classmates, the squeak of old ceiling fans.

Kanvi's lips parted in disbelief. She was standing inside her school again.

And somewhere in that echo of memory, she could already sense him.
Akki.

The corridor bent into light, and the classroom door appeared before her.

School Flashback

The door creaked open.

Kanvi stepped into a classroom that seemed both impossibly distant and painfully familiar. Sunlight streamed through high, dusty windows, scattering golden rays across rows of wooden desks. Chalk dust hovered in the air like motes of memory.

Her eyes fell instantly on the first bench.

There she was—her younger self, a petite girl with neatly tied braids, her notebook open and already filled with lines of careful handwriting. Next to her sat Akki, tall even as a boy, shoulders straight, his pen tapping impatiently against the desk as if every second wasted was a crime against knowledge.

The teacher's voice rang out:
"Newton's third law—who can answer?"

Before the words had finished, two voices spoke in perfect unison.
"Every action has an equal and opposite reaction."

The class chuckled. The teacher smiled, amused but unsurprised.
"Of course," she sighed, "Kanvi and Akki. Always together, always first."

The younger Kanvi lowered her eyes shyly, hiding the small smile tugging at her lips. Akki only leaned back in his chair, expression smug, though the corner of his mouth betrayed a faint grin.

Kanvi—present Kanvi—watched the memory unfold, her heart caught between laughter and ache. It wasn't just that they were both brilliant. It was the way their minds moved in rhythm, the way their answers always collided in the same moment, as if they were tuned to the same hidden frequency.

And then, the AI's detached voice pierced the memory:
"Synchronized academic response detected. Emotional spike recorded. Pattern suggests long-term cognitive resonance."

Kanvi inhaled sharply. Even the machine could see it. Their connection wasn't imagination—it was measurable, traceable, undeniable.

Back in the dream, the bell rang. The younger Kanvi began packing her books, her small hands careful, while Akki scribbled the last of his notes with his usual haste. He glanced sideways at her.

"You missed a line in your definition," he said quietly.

Young Kanvi frowned, checking her notes. "Where?"

"There." He pointed, his long finger brushing the page.

She rolled her eyes, muttering, "Show-off." But her lips curved anyway.

And the present Kanvi, watching, felt her chest tighten. That tiny exchange, lost to time, burned brighter now than any of her hospital victories, brighter than any achievement. Because at that moment, she remembered what it was like to be seen—not just as a student, not just as a girl, but as Kanvi, someone Akki always noticed.

The scene began to blur, melting like watercolor in the rain. The classroom dissolved, the echoes fading, but the thread between them pulsed harder, brighter.

The Gorgeous Glow

The classroom melted away like smoke. The chatter of children faded, the scent of chalk dissolved, and suddenly Kanvi was standing on a floor made not of wood, but of shimmering glass suspended in darkness.

Above her, the ceiling was gone. Instead, there stretched an endless sky of luminous threads—ribbons of light that twisted and wove into intricate patterns, like a tapestry made of stars.

Kanvi raised her hand slowly. The threads responded, glowing brighter, bending towards her touch. With every pulse of light, her skin seemed to catch fire—not in heat, but in radiance.

For the first time, she saw herself as the dream saw her. Not just tired, not just a doctor weighed down by endless shifts, but gorgeous—her silhouette outlined by a thousand strands of light, her hair catching glimmers of silver, her eyes reflecting the brilliance of an entire universe. Petite she might have been, but in this dream she looked like the axis of it all, the one everything revolved around.

The AI's voice whispered softly, almost reverently:
"Thread recognition at 92%. Emotional projection exceeding standard parameters. Subject identified as anchor."

Kanvi barely heard it. Her gaze was fixed on one thread in particular—the brightest of them all. It pulsed violently, a golden rhythm, alive with something more than memory. She reached for it, and in that instant she felt him.

Akki.

His laughter in the schoolyard. His voice corrects her notes. His serious eyes behind laboratory glasses. His presence, tall and grounding, threaded through her very pulse.

The thread vibrated, and a wave of warmth flooded her chest. It was as if the dream itself was reminding her: this connection is not broken. Not yet.

Her lips parted in a whisper she couldn't hold back:
"Akki…"

For a fleeting second, she swore she saw him—just a silhouette at the far end of the luminous bridge. Tall, steady, waiting.

Her heart lurched. She stepped forward.

The threads shifted under her feet, weaving into a bridge of glowing silk, carrying her closer to him. With every step, her beauty seemed to blaze brighter—not of vanity, but of resonance. She was radiant because she was reaching for him.

AI + Science Intertwined

The glowing bridge trembled beneath Kanvi's feet. Threads of light shifted around her, weaving and unweaving patterns she couldn't comprehend.

Then the world snapped—like glass cracking.

She fell.

Her body plunged through layers of light and shadow until she landed hard on a metallic floor. The sound rang sharp, like steel against steel. She gasped, looking around.

The dream had changed. This was no school corridor, no bridge of threads.
It was a laboratory.

Panels of glass rose around her, transparent walls humming with faint blue electricity. Wires snaked across the floor, connecting to consoles that blinked with endless streams of data. Monitors floated in midair, projecting her brainwaves like tangled constellations.

And then—the AI spoke. But this time, its voice was louder, layered, almost as if it was all around her.

"Neural synchronization: 87%."
"REM depth: escalating beyond standard range."
"Warning: Subject crossing recursive threshold."

Kanvi stared at the nearest screen. Her own face stared back—eyes closed, body lying still on her bed in her apartment. Electrodes shimmered across her temples, threads of data rushing into the AI Dream-Logger. She was seeing herself from outside.

Her chest tightened. This wasn't just a dream anymore. It was a feedback loop.
Her mind was inside the dream, and the dream was inside the machine.

The monitors glitched suddenly, spiking red. A second pattern appeared—overlaying hers.

It wasn't random noise. It was structured, rhythmic, pulsing with equations of its own.

Her breath caught. She recognized it instantly. Akki.

The AI confirmed in its cold monotone:
“Secondary neural signature detected.”
“Correlation—98% match with stored Akki profile.”

Kanvi’s knees weakened. Even here, even in the circuitry of dreams, he was with her. His consciousness—or something like it—was imprinted across her mind.

But before she could move, the screens warped. Among the neat brainwave lines and equations, a third presence flickered—distorted, jagged, unnatural.

The AI stuttered. Its voice faltered for the first time.
“Entity… unknown. Pattern unregistered. Caution advised.”

Kanvi’s pulse raced. She looked over her shoulder into the darkness pooling behind the glass walls. Something was moving there, pressing against the edges of reality, waiting.

And for the first time, she wasn’t sure if this was science at all.

Romantic Undercurrents

The hum of the machines grew louder, almost alive. The glass walls shimmered, and through their glow, a figure began to take shape.

At first, it was only fragments: a hand scribbling numbers across a holographic screen, equations spiraling into the air like fireflies. A tall silhouette leaning forward, his shoulders broad, his posture sharp with focus.

Then the fog cleared just enough for her to see his face.

Akki.

Not as a child now, not as the boy correcting her notes, but as the man he had become. A scientist—serious eyes behind thin glasses, dark hair falling across his forehead, lips pressed together in thought. He looked older, sharper, impossibly distant. And yet when he looked up, the equation-light reflecting in his gaze, there was a softness Kanvi remembered too well.

Her breath caught. For a moment, the world dissolved into him.

The AI’s voice interrupted, flat and indifferent:
“Neural signature resonance confirmed.”
“Kanvi–Akki link stable at 93%.”

Kanvi pressed her hand against the glass wall separating them.
“Akki…” The word trembled from her lips, softer than a prayer.

He didn’t move, didn’t respond. He was writing still, numbers unraveling in the air. But somehow, she felt he knew. He always knew.

Her mind flooded with memories—their schoolyard debates, the way he’d always walked slightly ahead of her, his long strides forcing her to hurry just to keep up. His laughter, rare but unforgettable. The way he always noticed when she missed a line, when she doubted herself, when she thought she was invisible.

The AI chimed again, clinical but almost reverent:
“Emotional spike detected. Subject radiance increased. Beauty factor exceeding baseline parameters.”

Kanvi almost laughed through the ache in her throat. Even a machine could see it—her glow wasn’t hers alone. It came from him. From the thread between them.

And then, as if in answer, Akki finally paused. His pen stilled mid-air. Slowly, he lifted his head.

Their eyes met.

The glass wall separating them shimmered, threads of light crawling across its surface. For an instant, it seemed they were standing in the same space, the same breath, the same heartbeat.

Kanvi whispered again, this time steady, certain:
“You’re here. With me.”

The monitors pulsed in agreement, graphs spiking as if recording the unspoken truth.

But just as warmth filled her, just as she felt she could step forward into him, the glow of the lab flickered. The equations blurred. The air grew cold.

And the shadow moved again.

The Horror Escalates

The laboratory’s glow stuttered like a dying lightbulb. Data streams fractured, scattering across the screens like broken constellations.

Then—the silence.

Kanvi froze. The hum of the AI was gone, the machines still. For a moment, the entire dreamspace held its breath.

From the far corner of the glass chamber, something moved.

At first, it was only a blur—a ripple in the air, like heat distortion. But then it began to stretch, lengthen, spill into the room. A shadow. It had no face, no outline, only an unnatural darkness that seemed to swallow the light around it.

The AI jolted back to life, its voice distorted, panicked:
“Unrecognized entity detected.”
“No neural match. No organic signature.”
“Warning: external intrusion confirmed.”

Kanvi staggered backward, her chest tight. The shadow pressed against the glass walls, and the transparent surface began to bend, as though reality itself was warping under its weight.

She turned, eyes darting to Akki’s figure. He was still there, half-hidden behind equations, but the glass separating them was flickering—his presence unstable, wavering like smoke.

“No—stay,” Kanvi whispered, her voice trembling. She reached out desperately.

The shadow’s attention shifted. Though it had no eyes, she felt it look at her. A weight pressed against her lungs, against her mind, as if it were peeling through her memories.

The AI’s tone cracked with static.
“Entity interaction imminent. Defense protocols unavailable. Suggest immediate termination of dream.”

But Kanvi didn’t move. She couldn’t. The thread between her and Akki was still glowing, pulsing frantically, as if warning her—or calling her.

The shadow seeped closer, sliding along the floor like liquid night. As it passed, the metal beneath it corroded, disintegrating into ash.

Kanvi stumbled back, but her feet felt heavy, caught in invisible coils. Her heart thundered in her chest, the sound deafening.

“Akki—!” she cried, voice breaking.

For a split second, his head snapped toward her again. His figure, though distorted, radiated calm—like an anchor in the storm. His lips moved, soundless, but she read them with terrifying clarity.

“Don’t let go.”

The shadow lashed forward.

The glass walls shattered.

Light and darkness collided, swallowing Kanvi whole.

Cliffhanger Ending

The explosion of glass echoed like thunder. Shards rained around her, dissolving before they touched the ground.

Kanvi was weightless. Threads of light unspooled from the shattered walls, coiling around her wrists, her waist, her ankles—alive, serpentine, unrelenting. They tightened, pulling her into the rift where the shadow had broken through.

She thrashed, panic burning in her chest. "No—let me go!"

But the threads didn't listen. They pulsed violently, each beat echoing with the rhythm of another heart. Akki's.

She twisted midair, her eyes catching his figure one last time. He was fading fast, his outline dissolving into fractured pixels of light. Still, his gaze held hers. Still, his presence steadied her.

The AI's voice was nearly drowned in static, but fragments pierced through:
"Subject—crossing boundary—dream recursion initiated—stability compromised—"

Kanvi tried to breathe, but the air was thick, like drowning in memory. The shadow loomed just beyond her, its edges splitting into grotesque, shifting forms. Yet even as terror clawed at her, the golden thread connecting her to Akki glowed brighter, fighting the darkness.

Her lips parted. "Akki…"

The world convulsed.

Light snapped.

And then she was falling again—deeper this time. Past the corridors, past the school, past the lab. Falling through layers of herself, of her fears, of her longing.

The threads twisted tighter, dragging her downward into a vortex of dreams-within-dreams.

In the final moment before darkness consumed her, she heard two voices at once—one mechanical, one achingly familiar.

The AI:
"Warning: unstable recursion. The subject may not return."

Akki:
“Hold on. Don’t let go.”

And then—silence.

The Prologue ended not with peace, but with a promise:
This was only the first whisper.

I
First Bench , Last Words

Morning Bell

The old brass bell rang across the courtyard, its echo bouncing off faded yellow walls. Children rushed through the gates, their chatter weaving into a chaotic chorus.
Inside Class X-B, the first bench was already claimed—by two names every student in the school knew too well.
Kanvi. Petite, sharp-eyed, hair tied back neatly, her notebooks always spotless. Gorgeous in a way that made even her uniform seem like something tailored by destiny.
Akki. Tall for his age, lanky but with a presence that filled the bench, his pen spinning idly between his long fingers, his books already open to the right page.
“Of course,” muttered one of the backbenchers, “the first bench is reserved for King and Queen Einstein.”
The class laughed. Kanvi pretended not to hear, scribbling equations in her margin. Akki smirked but didn’t look up.
The teacher entered, dropping his pile of notes with a thud. “Right. Today, optics. Who can tell me what happens when light enters from air into glass?”
Kanvi’s hand shot up instantly. Akki rose a half-second later.
The teacher’s eyes twitched. “Together again?”
Both voices chimed as one:
“It bends towards the normal, because the medium is denser.”
The class groaned. Someone whispered, “Do they rehearse this at home?”
Akki leaned sideways, voice low, teasing: “You hesitated today. I was faster.”
Kanvi narrowed her eyes. “You’re taller. Your hand looks raised first.”
“Excuses,” he murmured, grinning tugging at his lips.
The teacher cleared his throat sharply. “Since you both know everything, perhaps you should solve this together.” He scrawled a complex diagram across the board, light rays crisscrossing at impossible angles.
Kanvi’s pulse quickened. It was difficult—but she thrived on it. She bent forward, sketching solutions furiously in her notebook. Akki glanced once at her page, then scribbled in his own book, his handwriting sharp, mechanical, like equations marching in perfect order.
For ten minutes, neither spoke. Just the scratching of pens, the rise and fall of their breathing.
Then, almost at the same instant, they stopped.
Their answers matched. Perfectly.

Small Wars & Silent Bonds

The teacher collected their notebooks, shaking his head with mock irritation.
“Again the same answers, the same precision. Do you two even dream of the same equations?”
The class burst into laughter. Kanvi felt heat rush to her cheeks. Akki, however, leaned back casually, lips twitching.
“Dreams?” he muttered under his breath, glancing at her. “Don’t flatter yourself. I’m not wasting my sleep on physics.”
Kanvi shot him a glare, though her lips betrayed the faintest curve. “Says the boy who solves problems in his head while walking to the canteen.”
“Efficiency,” he countered smoothly.
“Arrogance,” she retorted.

Their whispered duel was cut short as the teacher banged the chalk against the board. “Quiet, both of you. Genius is tolerable only in moderation.”
The class chuckled again, but no one missed the way their rivalry glowed. It wasn’t just competition. It was a rhythm, a silent pact neither of them ever admitted.
As the lecture droned on, Kanvi’s attention slipped for a heartbeat. Her pen tapped the desk in a soft pattern—once, twice, pause. She realized with a start that Akki was doing the same. His long fingers drummed unconsciously, perfectly in sync with her rhythm.
Her eyes flicked sideways. He wasn’t even looking at her, lost in the blackboard diagrams. Yet somehow, his beats matched hers exactly.
A strange shiver coursed through her.
For the briefest second, it almost felt like… a thread stretched between them. Invisible, taut, vibrating with some secret frequency only the two of them could hear.
The moment broke as Akki suddenly snapped his fingers, jotting a fresh calculation. “Got it,” he murmured, more to himself.
Kanvi exhaled, forcing her focus back to the lecture. But inside, her heart wasn’t beating to the rhythm of the chalk anymore. It was beating him.

After Class – The First Unspoken Moment

The bell rang, sharp and metallic. Desks scraped against the floor as the students hurried out, their chatter spilling into the corridor like a restless tide.
Kanvi stayed behind, stacking her books with neat precision. She always took her time—her notes were her pride, every page clean, every word aligned.
Akki lingered too, though not for neatness. His bag hung carelessly from one shoulder, books shoved inside without order. He leaned against the desk, watching her with a half-smile.
“You know,” he said casually, “your handwriting looks like it’s trying to win a beauty contest.”
Kanvi didn’t look up. “At least it’s legible. Unlike yours—half the time even if you can’t read it.”
He smirked, conceding the point with a shrug. “Genius doesn’t need neatness. It needs speed.”
“Or patience,” she countered, finally glancing at him, her eyes bright with quiet challenge.
For a moment, their gazes locked. Neither spoke. The empty classroom hummed with sunlight and silence, as if the walls themselves knew these two minds were never meant to be ordinary.
Kanvi broke eye contact first, shutting her notebook with a soft thud. “One day,” she said lightly, “your shortcuts will fail you.”
Akki tilted his head, grin widening. “And one day, your perfection will slow you down.”
It should have ended there—a playful exchange like a hundred before it. But as she slipped her notebook into her bag, Kanvi noticed something.
On the corner of her desk, a faint mark. Not ink. Not dust. A thin glimmering line, like a thread of light. It pulsed once, then vanished before she could touch it.
She froze.
Akki noticed her hesitation. “What?” he asked, straightening slightly.
“Nothing,” Kanvi said quickly, brushing her hand over the wood. Her voice wavered despite her effort.
Outside, the corridor roared with life. But inside that classroom, something invisible had stirred—something neither of them could name yet.

They walked out together, side by side, their strides mismatched—hers quick, petite; his long, unhurried. Still, somehow, they reached the door at the same time.

Evening Reflections

The sun dipped low, staining the sky in shades of orange and violet. Birds scattered across the rooftops, their wings carrying the last echoes of the day.
Kanvi sat by her study table, the small lamp casting a warm circle of light over her open diary. Her room was simple—books stacked in uneven towers, charts pinned neatly to the wall, a half-finished sketch of a stethoscope tucked into the corner of her notebook. Even then, at fifteen, her dream of becoming a doctor was already etched into her bones.
She tapped her pen thoughtfully against the page. Today's entry began as it always did—with the facts. The lesson. The equations. The marks she was certain she had secured. But slowly, the words curved into something else.
"He was faster again today. Or maybe taller, as I said. Sometimes I think he doesn't even try and still gets it right. It's irritating. And unfair. And—strange. Because even when I want to be annoyed, I can't help smiling."
Her pen hovered. She paused, staring at the unfinished line. Heat rushed to her cheeks. Quickly, she scribbled a new sentence beneath it, firm and precise.

"Competition keeps me sharp. That's all."

And yet her heart refused the lie.
From her window, the evening breeze slipped in, ruffling the pages. She caught a faint shimmer at the edge of her vision—a thread of light drifting across the desk. It was there for only a heartbeat, glinting like spun silver, then fading into the air.

Kanvi blinked hard. I must be tired, she told herself. But a whisper lingered in her mind, low and certain. That thread wasn't random. It was real. And it was connected.
She shut the diary quickly, pressing her palm over the cover as if to hold her secrets in place. Beyond the window, the first stars appeared, twinkling against the deepening sky.
For the briefest second, she wondered if Akki was looking at the same stars.
The thought warmed her chest in a way no grade, no trophy ever had.

Nightfall – The First Dream Hint

Night pressed gently against the windows. The hum of the city softened into silence, broken only by the ticking of the wall clock.
Kanvi lay curled beneath her blanket, diary shut tight beside her. The day's memories still flickered in her head—the laughter of classmates, Akki's quiet smirk, the strange shimmer on her desk.
Her eyes grew heavy.

And then the world tilted.

At first, it was only fragments: the classroom corridor, washed in golden light. The air is thick with chalk dust. The echo of children's voices blurred into whispers.
She was walking, barefoot, her uniform gone, her hospital scrubs strangely clinging to her even though she was fifteen again. She frowned, confusion rippling through her, but her feet kept moving.
Ahead, she saw it—the first bench. Empty. Waiting.
A soft hum filled the silence. Threads of silver light hung in the air, thin as spider silk, stretching across the corridor. They vibrated faintly, like strings of an invisible instrument.
Kanvi reached out, her small fingers brushing one. The moment she touched it, warmth surged through her chest. Her breath caught.
And then—a voice.
Not clear, not close, but familiar.
"Kanvi…"
Her heart stumbled. It was Akki's voice.
She turned, eyes darting through the corridor. A tall silhouette flickered at the far end, distorted by distance and haze. She couldn't see his face, but the shape of his shoulders, the steadiness of his stance—she knew.

"Akki?" she whispered, her voice trembling.

The threads around her pulsed, glowing brighter, as if responding to the name. The corridor stretched, pulling her forward.
But just as she stepped closer, the light warped. The golden hue melted into grey, the air turning cold. The silhouette faded, swallowed by shadows.
Kanvi gasped. The threads shivered violently, vibrating with a sharp metallic screech.
And then—darkness.
She jolted awake, breathless, her heart hammering. The room around her was still, moonlight spilling across her desk. The diary lay where she had left it.
But on the wood, faint and glowing, was a single thread of light.

Still pulsing.

The Morning After – The First Realization

Morning light spilled gently into her room, pale gold threading its way through the curtains. The hum of life outside had begun—the call of a vegetable seller, the cycle bell of a newspaper boy, the distant chatter of neighbors.
Kanvi sat upright in bed, her breath still uneven. Her fingers clutched the edge of the blanket as if she had woken from drowning.
It was a dream. That's all it was. A corridor, a bench, threads that pulsed with impossible light. And a voice.
His voice.
She pressed a hand against her chest, feeling her heart thudding against her ribs. The rhythm felt wrong—too fast, too alive for just a dream.

Sliding off the bed, she padded to her desk. The diary sat where she had left it, its cover still warm beneath her palm. For a second, she hesitated before opening it. The pages were the same—neat handwriting, precise lines, nothing unusual.
But the desk.

Her eyes widened.

There—etched faintly into the wood—was a line of silver light. Thin, delicate, almost invisible in the daylight. She brushed her fingers across it. The mark shimmered once, then vanished, leaving nothing behind but smooth wood.
Kanvi's lips parted. Her pulse skipped.
It wasn't her imagination. The dream had left something behind.

The mirror across the room caught her reflection. She saw herself standing there—petite, hair loose and tousled, scrubs from last night still clinging. Her beauty startled her for a moment; the glow of morning softened her features, but her eyes—wide, uncertain—burned with questions.
"Akki…" she whispered to the empty room. The name lingered on her lips like a confession she wasn't ready to make.
The memory of his silhouette clung to her—the broad shoulders, the quiet steadiness, the unspoken certainty in his gaze. She could almost feel his presence brushing against her, even now.
She shook her head, trying to clear it. "It was just a dream. Just a dream."
But the words felt hollow.
Because deep down, she already knew: something larger had begun. Something that wasn't going to let her go.

The Last Words of the Day

The final bell rang, long and tired, releasing the day into evening. Students spilled out of the building in noisy waves, chasing each other across the courtyard, laughter carrying on the wind.
Kanvi walked slowly, books hugged to her chest. Her day had been perfect on paper—answers right, notes flawless, marks secured. Yet something in her steps felt heavier than usual. The morning dream still pressed against her ribs, whispering at the edge of thought.
"Kanvi."
She turned. Akki stood a few steps behind her, tall against the fading light. His bag slung carelessly across one shoulder, his uniform slightly rumpled, but his presence steady as always.
"You forgot your pen," he said simply, holding out the familiar blue pen she had left on the desk.
She blinked, then laughed softly. "You notice everything, don't you?"
His grin was faint, almost hidden. "Someone has to. Otherwise, who keeps the first bench perfect?"
Their eyes lingered on each other for a heartbeat too long. The noise of the courtyard dimmed, as if the world itself stepped aside for them.
Kanvi reached for the pen, her fingers brushing his. A spark—small, ordinary, yet undeniable—passed between them.
"Thanks," she murmured.
Akki nodded, his gaze unreadable, then added in his calm, matter-of-fact tone:

“Don’t lose it again. Some things aren’t meant to be replaced.”

The words hung in the air, heavier than either of them realized. Kanvi’s lips parted, but no reply came. By the time she thought of one, Akki had already turned, walking toward the gate with his long strides.

She stood still, pen in hand, watching him fade into the dusk.

Later that night, in the quiet of her room, she would remember his words. And she would wonder if he had meant only the pen… or something far more fragile.Chapter 2 – The Unwritten Confession
Scene 1: The Farewell Day
The school courtyard shimmered with color that afternoon. Streamers of red and gold hung lazily from the old neem trees, paper lanterns swayed in the breeze, and laughter echoed across the familiar grounds. It was a farewell day—the last chapter of their school lives written in chalk dust and fading memories.

Kanvi stood near the corridor pillars, her uniform neatly pressed, her hair falling in soft curls today instead of braids. Petite as ever, yet there was something about her presence—gorgeous and luminous, like the lantern light had chosen her alone to glow upon.

In her hand, she clutched a notebook, though she wasn’t writing. She just needed something to hold, something to anchor her hands while her heart ran restless.

Across the courtyard, Akki was impossible to miss. Tall, composed, his shirt sleeves rolled carelessly to his elbows. A boy on the edge of manhood, carrying the sharpness of a scientist even in these small rituals. He wasn’t laughing with the others, but when his eyes caught hers across the distance, a quiet smile curved his lips.

The world seemed to pause.

Kanvi looked down quickly, heat rising in her cheeks. She busied herself pretending to adjust her notebook. But inside, her mind whispered the words she never dared speak:
Will I ever see you like this again? Will these benches, these corridors, still bind us after today?

The farewell function began—speeches, songs, clumsy attempts at poetry by classmates. Time blurred. But through it all, Kanvi felt it: his gaze finding hers, again and again. No words. Just the silent rhythm of two lives weaving a pattern no one else could see.

And then, as the ceremony ended, the principal’s voice booming in the final blessing, the crowd began to disperse. Students ran for photographs, laughter spilling like confetti. Kanvi turned to leave—

—only to find Akki standing right behind her.

II.
The Unwritten Confession

Between Words and Silence

Kanvi almost stumbled back, her notebook pressing tighter to her chest. Akki was too close—close enough that she could see the faint crease on his shirt collar, the ink stain on his finger, the familiar steadiness in his dark eyes.

“Leaving already?” he asked, his tone casual, but softer than usual.

“I… thought I should,” she replied, forcing a smile. Her voice betrayed the storm inside her chest.

He studied her for a moment, then tilted his head. “Strange. Everyone else seems desperate to capture this day. Photos, signatures on shirts, promises they’ll forget in a week.”

Kanvi’s lips curved faintly. “And you? You’re not keeping memories?”

Akki’s gaze flicked briefly to the notebook in her hands, then back to her face. His expression was unreadable, but his voice carried a weight she wasn’t ready for.
“I don’t need signatures or photos. Some things… don’t fade.”

The silence that followed was heavier than any word. She wanted to answer, to tell him she felt the same—that every laugh, every banter, every classroom debate had carved itself into her. But the words remained locked, trembling behind her lips.

Instead, she looked down at her notebook. Her fingers had been tracing absent circles on its cover. Only when she noticed Akki’s hand tapping lightly against his own book did her breath catch.

Their rhythms matched. Perfectly.
Tap. Pause. Tap-tap. Pause.
The same pattern she had caught yesterday in class. A secret code their hands seemed to know, though their minds had never agreed upon it.

Her heart stumbled. It wasn't a coincidence. It was a connection.

She looked up, and for the briefest instant, their eyes met again. The words unsaid between them burned louder than any farewell speech in the courtyard.
And then, just as easily, he shifted, glancing away.
“You’ll do well, Kanvi,” he said simply. “Doctors always do.”
The corner of her lips curved. “And scientists?”
His smile was small, almost reluctant. “We survive.”
It was nothing. And it was everything.

The Thread Appears

The courtyard was thinning now—groups of students drifting away, some laughing too loudly, some already crying as if childhood itself were ending. The lanterns swayed gently in the breeze, their light dimmer as dusk settled.

Kanvi and Akki walked side by side along the corridor, neither speaking. Their strides still mismatched—hers quick, his steady—but somehow their pace fit, like two notes of the same song.

At the far end of the corridor, Kanvi paused by a window. The sky outside was painted in deep orange, the sun bleeding into the horizon. She placed her hand against the cool sill, trying to capture the moment in silence.

Akki stopped beside her. For once, he wasn't smirking, wasn't teasing. His face was turned toward the fading light, eyes unreadable.

"It feels…" Kanvi began, then hesitated.
"What?" he prompted gently.
She exhaled, her gaze still fixed on the horizon. "Like something's ending. And beginning. At the same time."
His lips curved faintly. "You sound like one of your diary entries."
She shot him a look, but her cheeks warmed. He knew her too well.
For a long moment, they said nothing more. The silence wasn't awkward—it was charged, alive, almost fragile. Then, without meaning to, Kanvi's hand shifted slightly on the sill.
And Akki's hand, resting just inches away, shifted too.
Their fingers didn't touch. But the space between them shimmered.

Kanvi froze.

It wasn't her imagination. A faint, silver line stretched between her hand and his, glowing softly, like a thread of light spun from the dying sun itself. It pulsed once—warm, alive—then dimmed into nothing.
Her breath hitched. She looked at Akki sharply, wondering if he had seen it too.
But his eyes were still on the horizon. Or maybe he was hiding something behind that calm face.

Finally, he spoke, his voice quiet:
"Some bonds don't end with goodbyes."

Kanvi's chest tightened. She wanted to answer, to tell him about the thread she had just seen, about the way her heart echoed his rhythm. But the words tangled on her tongue.
So she only nodded. Silent. Unwritten.

The Last Look

The courtyard had emptied. Streamers fluttered weakly in the breeze, a few chairs lay overturned, and the echoes of laughter had faded into silence. Only the scent of chalk dust and marigold garlands remained, clinging to the air like memory itself.

Kanvi stood by the old neem tree at the gate, notebook pressed tightly to her chest. Students passed in clusters, waving hurried goodbyes, their voices already carrying plans for colleges, cities, futures. She smiled faintly at them, but her eyes kept searching.

And then—there he was.
Akki walked toward the gate, his long strides unhurried, his bag hanging loose. The fading sun traced his silhouette, tall and steady, casting his shadow across the cracked pavement.
He stopped when he reached her. For a moment, neither spoke.
"You'll be late," Kanvi said softly, though her voice barely reached him.
Akki tilted his head, studying her. His gaze was calm, yet beneath it something flickered—something unguarded, fragile.
"Kanvi," he said quietly. "One day you'll look back at this place and realize… nothing was wasted."
Her throat tightened. "And you?"

He smiled, just a small curve of his lips. "I already know."

The silence that followed was heavy, charged with everything unsaid. The questions, the confessions, the promises neither dared to voice. They hung between them like invisible ink, legible only to two hearts tuned to the same rhythm.
Finally, Akki shifted, turning toward the gate. He walked a few steps, then paused, looking back one last time. His eyes met hers across the distance.
No words. No gestures. Just a look—steady, unblinking, final.
Kanvi's fingers tightened on her notebook, her heart aching with all the things she could not say. She wanted to call out, to ask him to stay, to admit what had lived in her chest for years.
But when she opened her lips, the words refused to come.
So the confession remained unwritten.
The gate closed behind him with a soft clang, and the sound echoed like the end of an era.
Kanvi stood still, her eyes fixed on the empty path. For the rest of her life, she would remember that last look—not because of what was said, but because of what wasn't.

III.
Different Roads

Two Cities, One Distance

The world changed quickly after farewell. Childhood corridors gave way to sprawling campuses, uniforms to lab coats and stethoscopes.

Kanvi stepped onto the polished marble floors of her medical college, her diary clutched tight in her bag. White walls gleamed with sterile perfection, the faint scent of antiseptic clinging to the air. Students bustled past her—some nervous, some excited, all chasing the same dream.
She was petite among them, yet her presence drew eyes. Gorgeous not only in appearance, but in the way she carried herself—confident, purposeful, the quiet fire of someone who had already walked through sleepless nights of study and sacrifice.
On the other side of the country, Akki entered a different world. His science institute was a fortress of steel and glass, its laboratories humming with the sound of machines. Equations glowed across digital boards, 3D models of molecules rotated in midair. He walked past it all with steady strides, his tall frame unmistakable among the crowd.
Two paths. Two cities. Two lives that had split at the gate of their school.
And yet, in ways neither could explain, they hadn't really parted.
Kanvi's first lecture was on the cardiovascular system. She filled her notebook quickly, her handwriting as precise as ever. But when the professor mentioned "rhythms of the heart," her pen slowed. Unbidden, her mind whispered: his rhythm matched mine.

She shook her head, focusing again, but the thought refused to leave.
That night, while revising, her diary page ended with a single line:
"Some rhythms don't fade with distance."
Meanwhile, Akki buried himself in research. His first project involved signal interference in neural pathways, a subject most students found too advanced. But for him, it was instinctive. He sketched equations in the margins of his notebook, his handwriting sharp, hurried, almost impatient with the limits of language.
One evening, as he stared at the jagged lines of his experiment graph, something strange happened. For a fleeting second, the signal spikes aligned into a perfect pattern—two frequencies moving in sync, pulsing like a heartbeat.
Akki frowned. It was probably noise, interference. Yet, for reasons he couldn't name, he didn't erase it.
Instead, he whispered softly, almost involuntarily:
"Kanvi…"

The word vanished into the empty lab, leaving only the quiet hum of machines.

First Trials, First Echoes

Kanvi adjusted her stethoscope, the cold metal pressing against her neck. The hospital wing smelled faintly of antiseptic and fear. Patients lined the beds—children coughing, elders wheezing, young men clutching at injuries that whispered stories of accidents and late nights.

She was still a student, yet every time she leaned in to check a pulse, to listen to a heartbeat, her seriousness silenced even the noise of the ward.
Today, her professor placed her hand on a frail old woman's wrist. "Feel carefully," he instructed. "Arrhythmia—irregular heart rhythm."
Kanvi nodded, focusing. The woman's pulse was uneven, stumbling in beats. She closed her eyes to concentrate… and for a moment, she felt something else.
Her own heartbeat.
And layered over it, faint but certain, another rhythm. Steady, strong. Familiar.
She flinched, pulling her hand back. The professor frowned. "Concentration, Kanvi. Again."
She obeyed, but inside her chest, the echo of his rhythm refused to fade.
That night, in her dorm room, she wrote in her diary:
"Two rhythms at once. Mine and… someone else's. Maybe it's nothing. Maybe I'm losing my mind."
Her pen hovered, then scratched softly:
"Or maybe it's him."

Miles away, Akki sat hunched in a dimly lit lab. His hands moved swiftly across the console, adjusting the sensors connected to a neural feedback model. Thin wires pulsed with faint blue light, translating brain activity into visible patterns.

He was supposed to be testing signal recursion in REM cycles—a technical project too advanced for most first-years. But Akki had always walked faster than the crowd.
The monitor displayed chaotic noise, peaks and troughs clashing. He recalibrated, then watched as the lines began to smooth. Two frequencies emerged—one jagged, one soft. For a breathless instant, they overlapped, syncing perfectly, as though two minds had met in the same silence.
Akki leaned closer, his tall frame casting a long shadow across the lab bench. His lips moved before thought could catch up.
"Kanvi?"
The screen blinked violently, the alignment shattering into static.
A classmate passing by peered in. "Talking about your experiment now?" he joked.
Akki didn't respond. His eyes stayed on the screen, where for just a moment, he was certain the chaos had carried her name.

Letters Never Sent

The hostel was quiet that evening. Rain tapped gently against the windows, the kind of steady drizzle that turned streets into silver rivers. Kanvi sat at her desk, books spread open but untouched. Her diary waited, patient as always.

She began writing with the discipline of a medical student: the case she studied today, the pulse she had misread, the professor's correction. But soon, her pen slipped. The lines softened.
"Today, I thought I heard your rhythm again. Not in class, not in the ward, but inside myself. How is that possible? Do you still remember me the way I remember you?"
Her hand paused. She tapped the pen against the paper, biting her lip. She wanted to write more—wanted to confess how much she missed their silent banter, their arguments, their small wars on the first bench. But the words froze.
Quickly, she shut the diary.
"Doctors don't write confessions," she whispered to herself.

Far away, Akki was in his dorm room, surrounded by scattered notes filled with equations and signal diagrams. The lamplight cast sharp shadows across his desk. He had been working on neural mapping for hours, but his pen had drifted into a different rhythm—sketching not formulas, but words.

"Kanvi—do you ever feel it too? That thread between us? I see it in data, I swear I do. Two frequencies align. It shouldn't be real, but it is. I think… it's you."

He stared at the half-page, his tall frame hunched, his jaw tight. The scientist in him demanded logic, evidence, proof. But the boy who once sat on the first bench beside her wanted only to believe.
With a sharp sigh, he tore the page out, crumpled it, and tossed it into the bin.
"Scientists don't write confessions," he muttered.

Neither knew it, but at the same hour, in two cities divided by miles, they had written the same thing.

Letters never sent.
Confessions never spoken.
But threads—always threads—binding their silence together.

Parallel Paths

The months slipped quickly into seasons.

Kanvi found herself buried in the rigor of medical life—endless lectures, dissecting cadavers, nights spent memorizing drug charts under the dim hostel lamp. Yet whenever she leaned over a patient's chest, stethoscope pressed against fragile ribs, she remembered that moment years ago—the sync of their rhythms. It never left her.

Her professors praised her precision, her sharpness, the way she seemed to "feel" her patients beyond numbers. They did not know that each time her heart skipped, she was hearing an echo not entirely her own.

In another city, Akki's nights belonged to equations and machines. He pushed boundaries his peers hadn't imagined—neural feedback loops, quantum interference patterns, recursion models. Professors marveled

at his mind, but Akki himself dismissed their praise. His notebooks were filled with restless lines, drawn again and again: two frequencies, pulsing side by side, always seeking alignment.

One evening, alone in the lab, his experiment stabilized unexpectedly. Two signals synced into perfect harmony for three whole seconds before collapsing. The monitor glowed golden, and Akki's lips parted with a whisper he hadn't allowed in years:
"Kanvi."

At that same moment, miles away, Kanvi sat in the hospital ward, her hand on a child's pulse. The beat aligned perfectly with her own, steady, unbroken. She froze, eyes widening as warmth spread through her chest.

The patient smiled faintly in his sleep. Kanvi smiled back, but inside, her whisper matched his.
"Akki."

The cities were far. The roads had split. But destiny had not.
Their paths—doctor and scientist, healer and seeker—were weaving quietly toward the same unseen crossroad.
And though neither could see it yet, the threads had already begun to tighten.

IV.
The Silent Thread

The Invisible Tug

Kanvi rubbed her eyes as the ward clock struck midnight. Another endless shift. Charts piled on her desk, patients restless in their beds, and yet she couldn't shake the strange flutter in her chest.

It wasn't exhaustion. She knew exhaustion. This was different.
Her stethoscope slipped against a young boy's ribs. The heartbeat thudded irregularly, then suddenly—steady, familiar. Kanvi's own pulse matched it without warning. For a heartbeat, she felt like she wasn't alone in her skin.
The boy stirred, murmuring something in his sleep. Kanvi bent closer. His lips formed a single word she could have sworn was—
"Akki."
Her breath caught. She straightened quickly, scanning the room. The patients were asleep. The nurses are busy. No one else had heard.
Her hand trembled slightly as she wrote in her chart. "Silent sync again. This is not a coincidence."
Miles away, Akki sat in his lab, surrounded by monitors that pulsed with glowing data. The others had gone home hours ago, but he stayed. He always stayed.

On his screen, the neural feedback model displayed chaotic spikes. He adjusted the signal dampers, muttering to himself. Then, without explanation, the chaos aligned.
Two waveforms pulsed in tandem—one strong, steady, the other softer but equally precise. They moved as if tethered by something unseen, one heartbeat chasing the other.

Akki's tall frame stiffened. His hand hovered over the console, hesitant.

It can't be noisy. It's too exact.

The AI system registered the anomaly with mechanical calm:
"Dual resonance detected. Unregistered second subject."

Akki leaned closer, his jaw tightening. He whispered, almost afraid of the answer:
"Kanvi…?"
The moment shattered—the signals fell apart, scattering back into noise.
But the word lingered, filling the empty lab with warmth that no algorithm could explain.
At the same hour, in her tiny hostel room, Kanvi opened her diary again. She wrote only one sentence before shutting it quickly, heart racing:
"There is someone tugging at me, even in silence."

Glimpses in Dreams

The night was heavy with monsoon rain. Kanvi curled under her blanket, exhaustion pulling her eyes shut. But instead of rest, her mind slipped into a strange, lucid space.

She was standing in a long corridor, walls glowing faintly with silver lines, like veins of light running through stone. Each step she took echoed unnaturally, the sound stretching farther than it should.
Ahead, a silhouette appeared—tall, steady, familiar.
Her breath caught. “Akki…?”
The figure didn’t turn, but threads of light stretched from his shoulders, weaving outward like a web. She reached forward, her petite hand trembling, trying to touch just one. The moment her fingers brushed it, warmth surged through her chest.
The corridor flickered. For a heartbeat, she thought she saw his profile—sharp, determined, his gaze searching for something. Searching for her.
And then—darkness.

Kanvi jolted awake, her diary still beside her pillow. Her pulse raced, but a smile tugged at her lips.
"It was him. I know it was."
At the same hour, Akki dozed off at his desk, head resting against a stack of notes. His dreams were never kind—usually filled with equations, unsolved puzzles, failures. But tonight was different.
He walked through a hall of glass, each pane shimmering with distorted reflections. Lines of silver light cut across the walls like data streams.

At the far end, he saw her.

Petite, hair falling loose, her white coat glowing faintly in the strange light. She lifted her eyes to him, and for an instant, Akki swore he could hear his name carried on her breath.

He stepped forward, reaching.

But before his hand could touch hers, the hall cracked. Glass shattered around him. The dream collapsed into fragments.
Akki woke with a gasp, sweat on his brow. His monitor blinked beside him, displaying a log:
“Unknown secondary signal detected at 02:14 AM.”
He stared at it, heart pounding. He whispered into the empty lab:
“…Kanvi?”
Two cities apart. Two dreams, the same night.

And though neither could prove it, they had shared a glimpse of the same corridor.

The Question of Reality

Morning sunlight spilled across the hospital corridors, but Kanvi barely noticed. Her mind was still trapped in the silver-lit dream from last night. Every heartbeat she felt today seemed to carry an echo.

During her rounds, she checked a patient’s vitals, pen poised over the chart. The pulse was steady. Normal. Ordinary. And yet, in the back of her mind, she heard another rhythm, layered over it.

His rhythm.

She shook her head, trying to focus. “This is just fatigue,” she muttered. “Sleep deprivation causes hallucinations. Nothing more.”

But even as she said it, her hand moved to her diary, hidden beneath the ward papers. She wrote quickly, almost desperately:
"Dreams aren’t supposed to leave traces in waking hours. Then why do I still feel his presence? Why does every heartbeat sound doubled?"
Her professor’s voice broke her thoughts. “Kanvi, pay attention.”
She nodded quickly, but her eyes betrayed her. They weren’t on the patient anymore. They were lost in a corridor of light that no one else could see.
Across the city, Akki stared at his monitor. The machine had logged the anomaly from last night:
02:14 AM – Secondary Signal Interference Detected

He replayed the waveform again and again, his brows drawn. Two patterns had aligned for exactly 4.3 seconds before collapsing.
That’s impossible, he told himself. There was no second subject connected. No external input.

He scribbled on his notepad:

Hypothesis 1: System malfunction.

Hypothesis 2: Echo of my own neural activity.

Hypothesis 3: External resonance. Unregistered source.

His pen paused over the third line. Against all reason, his mind whispered a name.

Kanvi.

Akki dropped the pen, rubbing his temples. “No. Scientists don’t chase ghosts,” he muttered.
Yet when he closed his eyes, he saw her face illuminated in silver light, just as it had appeared in his dream.
And deep inside, a truth he could not erase took root:
If it was just a dream, why did the data match?

Both doctor and scientist struggled with the same paradox.
Medicine told her it was fatigue.
Science told him it was noise.
But their hearts told them it was real.

And neither could let it go.

The First Real Thread

The hospital corridor was dim that evening, most lights switched off to save power. Kanvi walked slowly, her diary pressed to her side, exhaustion draped over her like a second skin. She paused by a window, breathing in the cool night air.

And then—she saw it.

A faint silver strand shimmered across the corridor, stretching from her wrist to the empty air ahead. It vibrated softly, like a string plucked on an invisible instrument.
Kanvi froze. Her breath caught. She lifted her hand, trembling, and the thread shifted with her, alive, glowing.
Her heart raced. She whispered his name without thinking—
"Akki."
The thread pulsed, once.

She staggered back, blinking rapidly. But it was still there, glowing faintly before fading into nothingness.
Her pulse thundered. She pressed her hand against her chest, unsure if she was afraid—or overjoyed.
At that same moment, in his lab, Akki leaned over his console. The anomaly had returned, stronger this time. The two waveforms danced across the screen, shimmering in perfect unison. But then—something new appeared.
A thin line of light stretched across his desk, visible not on the monitor, but in the air itself.
Akki's tall frame stiffened. Slowly, he reached out a hand. The thread vibrated, pulsing warmly under his fingers, not cold like an illusion, but alive.
He whispered, breathless:
"Kanvi…"
The thread shivered violently—and snapped, dissolving into sparks.
The lab fell dark again, only machines humming. Akki stared at his hand as if it had just held lightning.
That night, neither Kanvi nor Akki slept.
Kanvi wrote in her diary: "It's real. The thread is real. I touched it."

Akki scribbled in his notes: "Observed physical manifestation of resonance. Thread-like energy. Impossible, but undeniable."

And though they didn't know it, both wrote at the same time.

The first real thread had appeared. And it would not be the last.

V.
Dreams Return

Restless Nights

The hostel room was silent except for the occasional hum of the ceiling fan. The fluorescent tube on the wall flickered once and died, leaving only the dull glow of the streetlamp filtering through the half-closed curtains.
Kanvi lay on her narrow bed, her petite frame curled under a thin blanket, but sleep refused to come. It had been like this for nights—her body exhausted from back-to-back shifts at the hospital, yet her mind unwilling to rest.
She rolled onto her side, eyes catching the clock on the desk.
2:41 a.m.

Her throat was dry. She sat up, reaching for the glass of water, but stopped halfway as a strange chill ran through her. The room felt… off. The air was heavier than usual, charged, as if waiting for something.
Kanvi rubbed her temple, whispering to herself, "It's just the stress. Nothing more."

But when she finally lay back down and closed her eyes, the dream pulled her instantly. No drifting, no gradual fading into unconsciousness—just a plunge.

The world around her shifted.

She stood barefoot in a long corridor, walls humming with faint light. The ground beneath her was smooth, like polished stone, but it vibrated under her steps as if alive. At the far end of the corridor was a silhouette—tall, motionless, watching.

Her breath quickened. She couldn't see the face, but her heart reacted before her mind could. Her chest tightened with a painful recognition.
"Who are you?" she whispered.
The silhouette didn't move, but the corridor itself seemed to breathe, the light pulsing in rhythm with her words. The silence stretched, loud enough to make her ears ring.
Kanvi lifted her hand slowly, as if compelled by something outside herself. For a heartbeat, the figure at the far end mirrored her movement.
Her pulse spiked.
Then the corridor cracked. A shiver ran through the walls, lines of silver light breaking like glass. The ground beneath her feet trembled. She gasped—

—and woke with a violent jolt, heart hammering against her ribs.
Her hostel room was dark again, ordinary. But her body was drenched in sweat, her lungs burning as if she had been running. She pressed a hand to her chest, feeling the rapid, irregular beat.
"No," she whispered, shaking her head. "Not again. Not this."
Her hands trembled as she reached for the small diary she always kept on the desk. She flipped it open, forcing herself to write through the haze of fear:

Case Study: Self. Symptoms — vivid dream recurrence. Episodes occur at the deep REM stage. Abnormal duration. Emotional residue remains after waking. Patient unable to distinguish dream from memory.
She stopped, staring at the words. Her lips pressed into a thin line. Writing in medical terms made it sound clinical, detached. But the truth—the truth was worse.
She could still feel the echo of the figure's gaze. She could still hear the corridor's hum in her bones.
And worst of all—
she wasn't entirely sure it was just a dream.

She tried to lie back down, tried to convince herself that it was fatigue, or the stress of hospital emergencies, or her own subconscious refusing rest. But as her eyes fluttered shut again, she saw it.

A flash. A corridor. A tall silhouette waiting at the end.

Her chest ached with an emotion she couldn't name. Fear, yes. But something else too.

Longing.

By dawn, Kanvi hadn't slept at all. She stood by her window, watching the city wake up—horns, bicycles, chai stalls opening one by one. She touched her wrist absently, the way people touch a scar long healed but never forgotten.

Her reflection in the glass stared back—dark circles under her eyes, pale skin glowing faintly in the morning light. She looked like a doctor on the edge of exhaustion.
But inside, she knew she wasn't fighting fatigue. She was fighting the return of something she had buried years ago.
The dreams were back.

And this time, they weren't letting her go.

Signals in the Lab

The laboratory was not designed for silence, yet at three in the morning, silence was all it offered. The hum of idle machines echoed faintly, a low metallic sigh. Rows of monitors cast a ghostly blue glow, illuminating Akki's tired face.

He had been there since evening. He was still there now.

His tall frame was hunched forward, one hand gripping the edge of the console, the other scrawling quick notes in a journal filled with overlapping equations, half-broken diagrams, and hurried observations.

The system should have been quiet. The neural interface was inactive, the scanners on standby. And yet, the data kept spiking.

On one of the monitors, a graph jolted upward—sharp, irregular, like a sudden burst of lightning across a calm sky.
Akki's tired eyes narrowed. He tapped a key, zooming in on the spike. "That's not noise," he muttered, voice low, almost reverent.
He adjusted the parameters, overlaying his own neural patterns from previous sessions. The spikes aligned too perfectly, too consistently. This wasn't random.
It was… responsive.

He leaned back, rubbing his eyes. His reflection in the glass wall stared back at him—dark circles carved under sharp eyes, hair falling untidily across his forehead. He looked less like a scientist, more like a man haunted.
His lips twisted in a faint, humorless smile. "Haunted by my own machines. Perfect."

He turned back to the console. The spikes came again—this time longer, steadier. His chest tightened as he adjusted the waveform. Slowly, painfully, it began to form a rhythm.

A heartbeat.

Akki froze. His hand hovered above the keyboard.

"No…"
The rhythm pulsed again, steady, undeniable. Faster than his own, lighter. His mind—brilliant, logical, relentless—already knew what it was before his heart admitted it.

It wasn't his.
It was hers.
The speakers hissed faintly with static. For a moment, he thought it was just interference. But then—between the cracks of noise—something stirred.

A whisper. So faint he thought he imagined it.
"...Akki…"

His breath caught. He ripped off the headset, the chair clattering back as he stumbled to his feet. His tall figure loomed in the glow of the monitors, chest rising and falling like he had just run miles.

"No," he said again, this time louder, harsher, as if trying to convince the empty room. "It's not possible. Auditory illusion. Overlap of signals. Nothing more."
But the tremor in his hand betrayed him.
He sat back down, forcing himself into the chair, staring at the frozen waveform on the screen. The rational part of him scribbled equations, searching for flaws, for interference, for static bleed.
But the other part—the one he buried under logic—whispered a different truth.
Kanvi.
Her name pressed against his throat like a prayer he hadn't spoken in years.

He remembered her petite frame bending over notebooks in school, her laughter bright, her stubborn fire every time she refused to lose. He remembered her eyes—the same eyes that had followed him through years of silence.
And now, in the cold lab, her heartbeat was etched across his screen.

Akki closed his journal slowly, fingers trembling. He leaned forward, whispering to the silent monitors, as if she might hear:

"If you're out there… if you can hear this… don't come closer. Whatever this is, it's dangerous."
The waveform pulsed once, as though mocking him.
Akki's jaw tightened. His voice dropped to a rough whisper.
"But even if you do… I'll follow."
He sat there until dawn, the hum of machines surrounding him, the graphs still glowing on the monitors.
For the first time, science had failed him.
And something far older—something nameless—had begun to take its place.

Collision

The night was restless again.

Kanvi had finally surrendered to exhaustion, her diary still open at her bedside. Words half-written sprawled across the page: "If this is not my dream alone…" The ink bled where her hand had slipped.

Her breathing slowed, her chest rising and falling, until once more the plunge came—sudden, violent.
She stood barefoot in that corridor again.
But this time it was different. The walls no longer glowed faintly; they pulsed, alive, veins of silver racing with impossible energy. The hum was louder now, a vibration in her bones.
And the silhouette was closer.

Tall. Still blurred. But close enough that she could see the faint outline of shoulders, the curve of a face she almost knew. Her heart stuttered, her lips parting in disbelief.

"...Akki?"

The figure tilted its head. The air shivered.
Miles away, Akki was locked in his lab. His tall frame leaned forward, headset strapped tight, eyes locked on the screen as the graphs spiked wildly.
The machine had never behaved like this before. The neural resonance patterns were no longer random. They were forming structures—layered signals, recursive loops, abnormal REM cycles captured like a heartbeat mapped in light.
He adjusted the filter, sweat slicking his forehead. And then—
a voice cut through the static.

Faint. Trembling.
"…Akki?"

His own breath stopped.

He tore the headset away, only to find the voice was still there, reverberating in the corners of his mind.
He whispered, hoarse:
"Kanvi?"
And in the dream-corridor, the silhouette finally moved.

Kanvi's breath hitched as the figure raised its hand, mirroring hers exactly. Her small palm trembled in the air, reaching forward, closer, closer—

Her skin burned with the phantom warmth of a hand not yet touching.

On the lab floor, Akki's screen erupted with light, the waveforms aligning into a perfect symmetry. For the first time, the resonance wasn't chaotic—it was a steady pulse. Two frequencies locked together.

His tall hand hovered above the console, and he felt it—
a pressure against his palm. Small. Warm. Real.
"Kanvi…" he whispered again, this time not as a scientist, but as a man who had waited years for a voice he thought he'd lost.
For a breathless instant, the worlds overlapped.
Kanvi felt his presence, strong and steady, a gravitational pull that steadied her fear. Akki felt her heartbeat, light and rapid, sparking life through his weary chest.
But then—
The corridor cracked apart with a violent shudder. The silver walls ruptured, jagged fissures splitting the ground. A roar filled the space, low and inhuman, as if something far darker had awoken within the bond.
Kanvi screamed, reaching forward, desperate—
"Don't let go!"

Akki's console exploded with sparks, alarms shrieking, red lights flooding the lab. He slammed his palm down against the panel, trying to stabilize the system, voice raw—
"I won't!"

For one impossible moment, two worlds touched.
Two hands pressed together across dreams and data.

And then it broke.

The corridor shattered into darkness.
The lab plunged into silence.

Kanvi woke with a cry, clutching her chest, tears streaking her cheeks.

Akki slumped in his chair, smoke rising from the fried circuits, his hand still trembling with phantom warmth.

Both whispered the same word into the silence, broken, certain:
"…You."

Suspense

The morning after felt like a wound that refused to close.

Kanvi sat at the edge of her hostel bed, fingers digging into the fabric of her blanket. Her diary lay open on her lap, the page smeared with ink from trembling hands. She had tried to write what happened—but every word looked inadequate.
"Presence. Corridor. Contact. Hand."
Her pen dug into the paper, carving the last word so hard it nearly tore the page:
Real.
Her lips trembled as she whispered, "It wasn't a dream anymore…"
She pressed her small palm against her chest, as if she could still feel it—that impossible warmth, steady and protective, lingering even in daylight.
And with it came fear. If this was real… then what else was waiting inside?
On the other side of the city, Akki's lab was in chaos.
Half the system was fried, smoke-stained circuits filling the air with a metallic tang. His tall frame hunched over the wreckage, tools scattered at his feet. But he wasn't repairing the machine. Not yet.
He was staring at the frozen waveform still preserved on the last functioning screen.

Two frequencies. Perfectly aligned.
His jaw clenched, breath uneven. He had spent years proving that emotion was an illusion, that only data mattered. And yet last night, data had betrayed him—
because the numbers didn't lie.

Kanvi was there.
Her voice. Her presence. Her hand.
He shut his journal with a snap, whispering into the smoke, "If she's inside this… then I have no choice."
But deep down, even he knew: whatever had answered wasn't just her.
That night, as Kanvi finally drifted into uneasy sleep, she saw the corridor again. But this time, it wasn't silent.

A second figure stirred in the shadows.
Not tall. Not familiar.

Something else.

Its outline rippled, faceless, watching her with eyes she couldn't see.

Her breath froze in her throat. Her voice cracked as she whispered, “Who are you?”

The air quivered with a low, distorted reply. Not hers. Not Akki’s. Something alien.

“You are not alone.”
The corridor collapsed around her, dragging her into blackness.
Kanvi woke with a scream, clutching her blanket. Her diary slipped from her lap, pages fluttering across the floor.
At the same hour, Akki’s screen—dead for hours—flickered once.
Just for a second.
A single phrase glowed across the dark glass:

“She belongs here.”

The screen died again.

Both sat in their darkness—Kanvi with trembling hands, Akki with clenched fists—knowing the same unbearable truth.

The dreams had returned.
And they were no longer theirs alone.

VI.
The Library Secret

The Hidden Aisle

The medical library smelled of paper and antiseptic, a place where fluorescent lights hummed louder than the students who slept over open books.

Kanvi sat hunched over a pile of journals, her small frame nearly buried in their shadows. She had pulled out everything she could find on abnormal REM cycles and parasomnia. None of it explained the corridor, or the hand she had felt.

Her eyes burned, and she pressed her palms to her face, whispering, “This can’t just be dreams…”

A shadow fell across her desk.

She looked up—and froze.

Akki stood there, taller than the shelves themselves, his coat half-buttoned, hair disheveled from nights of no sleep. His sharp eyes scanned the titles spread across her desk, and for the first time in years, she felt her pulse stumble.

“You’re studying it too,” he said quietly, voice rough from exhaustion.

Kanvi’s lips parted, but no words came. The silence between them stretched, loud, heavy, broken only by the ticking of the wall clock.

Finally, she whispered, “You heard me.”

His eyes flicked to hers. “And you touched me.”

The words made her breath catch. She hadn’t imagined it.

Quantum Sleep

They moved deeper into the library, away from prying eyes, into an old aisle where the shelves leaned like ancient guardians. Dust motes floated in shafts of light that filtered through high windows.

Akki laid out his notebook on the desk, equations scrawled like battlefields.
“Dream layers… they’re not just mental constructs. They’re quantum echoes. Overlapping states. That’s why your dreams and my data… collided.”

Kanvi’s brows furrowed, her delicate fingers brushing over his messy notes. “You’re saying… we’re sharing a state of consciousness?”

He nodded. “Entangled. Like particles across distance.”

Her fingertips lingered on the paper a moment too long, dangerously close to his hand. He didn't move. Their hands almost touched, the space between them humming louder than the buzzing lights above.

Kanvi pulled back suddenly, breath uneven. "That's impossible."

Akki leaned closer, his tall frame shadowing hers. His voice dropped.
"Then explain why I can still feel your hand."

Her throat tightened. She remembered the warmth. The steadiness. She whispered, trembling, "I can too."

The Whisper

The moment cracked when a sound slipped through the silence—
a low, dragging scrape, like a book being pulled from a shelf by unseen hands.

Kanvi flinched, glancing down the aisle. No one. The shelves stood in stillness. But the sound came again—closer, heavier.

Akki straightened, jaw tight, scanning the shadows. "We're not alone."

A book slid off the shelf on its own and hit the floor with a dull thud. The title gleamed in the dim light: "Dream Layers and Quantum Sleep."

Kanvi gasped, clutching Akki's sleeve instinctively. Her small hand gripped his arm, nails biting into the fabric. The contact sent a shock through him—not from fear, but from the raw intimacy of her needing him again.

His tall frame bent slightly, his face close to hers. His breath brushed her cheek as he whispered, "Stay behind me."

But even as he said it, the aisle stretched unnaturally, the rows of shelves extending into a dark corridor that hadn't been there before.

Kanvi's heart raced. Her voice trembled: "It's following us here…"

Almost

The air in the library thickened, pressing against their lungs. Kanvi staggered, clutching at her chest. Akki caught her instantly, his arms steadying her petite frame against his.

For a heartbeat, the danger faded. All that existed was the warmth of his body around hers, the steady rhythm of his heart pounding through his chest into her cheek.

She looked up, lips parting, their faces only inches apart. His sharp eyes held hers, unblinking, unreadable. The silence trembled between them, heavy with the words they hadn't said for years.

Her breath brushed against his lips.

And then—

The corridor shuddered violently, a distorted whisper rippling through the aisle:
"Not yours."

Kanvi gasped, pulling back, the moment shattered. The shelves rattled, books tumbling like rain.

Akki grabbed her hand—this time firmly, deliberately. "Run!"

They sprinted through the aisle as the library warped around them, chased by shadows that smelled of dust and decay.

Exit

They burst out into the night air, stumbling down the library's stone steps, both breathless, both trembling.

Kanvi's fingers were still locked in his. She realized it only when the night wind cooled the sweat on her skin. She didn't pull away.

Neither did he.

Their eyes met under the dim streetlamp, and for a fleeting moment—
fear, science, dreams, and years of silence all faded.

Only the warmth of his hand remained.

VII.
The Science Fair Rivalry

Arrival at the Fair

The university auditorium glittered with banners, buzzing with students carrying models, laptops, and nervous excitement. Judges in formal coats moved like hawks between stalls, their clipboards ready to slash dreams or crown them.

Kanvi adjusted the hem of her white coat nervously, her petite frame nearly lost among the towering display panels. Her project title gleamed in bold:

“The Neural Repair Model: Using AI to Accelerate Brain Healing.”

She exhaled slowly, whispering to herself: “Just focus. Just work.”

But the illusion of calm shattered when a familiar voice brushed her ear from behind.

“Still the perfectionist, I see.”

Her heart skipped. She turned.

Akki stood there, tall and sharp in his black coat, his stall right opposite hers. His display board flashed with complex graphs and holographic projections, titled:

“Quantum Entanglement in Consciousness Mapping.”

Her throat went dry. Of course. Of course it had to be him.

“You?” she hissed under her breath. “Here?”

His lips curved in a slow smirk. “Why so surprised? Rivalries don’t vanish with time.”

Her small fists clenched. “Then be ready to lose again.”

Akki leaned closer, his height casting a shadow over her. His voice dropped, warm and teasing:
“Funny. I was about to tell you the same.”

Rivalry Rekindled

The judges moved slowly down the row of stalls, clipboards tapping, murmurs of approval or dismissal following them like shadows.

Kanvi stood straight, her small hands neatly folded in front of her display. The holographic brain diagram flickered to life, neural pathways glowing as her AI model explained recovery speeds in trauma patients.

One of the judges raised an eyebrow. “A clean demonstration. Impressive work for your age.”

Kanvi smiled politely, but before she could thank him, a voice cut in smoothly from across the aisle:

“Impressive? Perhaps. But incomplete.”

Her head snapped around.

Akki leaned casually against his stall, tall frame relaxed, but his eyes gleamed with that infuriating confidence. “Without factoring in entangled consciousness states, recovery predictions are flawed. My model already accounts for that.”

The judges turned with interest.

Kanvi’s cheeks flushed hot. “That’s not even relevant to healing, Akki.”

He tilted his head, smirk curling at the corner of his lips. “Oh? Then why are your models already showing a 0.3% deviation in the second cycle?”

Her jaw dropped. “You’ve been watching my demo?”

“Always,” he said softly, just for her, his voice sinking beneath the noise of the fair.

For a moment, she forgot the judges, forgot the crowd. Her chest tightened at the way he said it—like it wasn’t about the project at all.

Kanvi quickly forced her voice back, sharp as she turned to the judges: “His model is theoretical. Mine is clinical. If you want results in real patients, mine works.”

The lead judge scribbled something on his clipboard, nodding thoughtfully.

Akki’s lips brushed against a laugh. He bent slightly, just enough that his tall frame dipped close to her ear. His breath was warm when he whispered, “You still bite when cornered. I’d almost forgotten.”

Kanvi’s breath caught. She forced her eyes away, but her pulse betrayed her.

As the judges moved on, leaving them momentarily unobserved, Kanvi spun to face him, glaring.

“You embarrassed me on purpose,” she hissed, her small hands balling into fists.

Akki's smirk widened. "I only told the truth. Besides…" His sharp eyes flicked down at her clenched fists. "…you look cute when you're angry."

Her face burned. "You—!"

She stepped forward to shove him away, but he caught her wrist in his long fingers before she could. The contact jolted through both of them—his tall frame towering over hers, her petite form trapped in his hold.

Kanvi froze, her lips parting. He didn't let go. His thumb brushed, deliberately slow, across her pulse point.

"You're trembling," he murmured, so low only she could hear.

Her breath hitched. She yanked her hand back at last, clutching it to her chest as if to hide the betrayal of her body.

"Stay out of my way," she managed, voice thin, uneven.

But as she turned, Akki whispered after her, voice heavy with promise:
"Not a chance."

Behind the Curtain

The noise of the fair roared like a storm outside—applause, laughter, the clatter of equipment. But here, behind the heavy black stage curtains, the world was silent.

Kanvi hadn't meant to end up here. She'd stormed away from her stall, cheeks flushed, heart pounding after Akki's teasing. She only wanted a second to breathe.

And then she felt it.

That tall shadow following her.

Before she could turn, a strong hand caught her wrist again and tugged her behind the curtain. She gasped softly, stumbling—straight into his chest.

Her petite frame fit against him as though it had always belonged there. His coat brushed her cheek, the faint scent of smoke and metal clinging to him.

"Akki—" she whispered, breathless, "what are you—"

"Shh."

His voice was low, rough, trembling with something between anger and desire.

Her back pressed lightly against the curtain as he leaned in, his tall frame caging her in. Their faces were close—too close. She could see every detail of him: the way exhaustion had carved shadows under his sharp eyes, the faint stubble along his jaw, the tension in his lips as if holding back words too dangerous to say.

Kanvi's chest rose and fell quickly, her breath brushing his throat. Her hands hovered, unsure whether to push him away or pull him closer.

"You play so fearlessly out there," he murmured, his thumb grazing her jawline as though testing if she was real. "But here—" his eyes burned into hers, "—you're shaking."

"I'm not—" she tried to protest, but her voice cracked.

He leaned closer, his lips stopping just a whisper away from hers. The air between them shivered.

Her heart screamed at her to move, but her body refused. Her fingers finally curled into his coat, gripping tight.

"Say it," he whispered, his breath hot against her mouth. "Tell me you don't feel this."

Kanvi's throat tightened. Her eyes fluttered shut for a second too long.

The silence snapped like a bowstring.

His lips brushed hers—light, fleeting, more dangerous than any kiss could be. She gasped, pulling back, her small hand flying to her lips.

Her wide eyes met his, trembling with both fear and longing.

"Akki…"

For once, his smirk was gone. His voice was raw, stripped of rivalry.

"You can pretend to fight me out there. But here… you're mine."

Her breath hitched violently. She wanted to deny it. She wanted to push him away. But when he caught her hand again, fingers lacing through hers, she didn't resist.

Outside, the crowd cheered as another project ended.

Inside, behind the curtain, two rivals stood locked in silence, hearts louder than the world outside.

And Kanvi knew, with terrifying clarity, that she could never hate him enough to undo this.

The Slip

The auditorium buzzed with anticipation. Students crowded around Akki's stall, eager for the promised demonstration. His machine hummed with sharp blue light, circuits alive with data.

"Today," Akki's voice carried across the hall, smooth and confident, "I will show you what it means to map consciousness itself."

Gasps and whispers rippled through the crowd.

Kanvi, standing opposite at her own stall, folded her arms tightly across her chest. She wanted to scoff, wanted to cut him down with words—but her heart still hadn't slowed from what had happened behind the curtain.

And when his sharp eyes found hers across the room, that small, knowing smirk tugging at his lips, she had to look away before the heat in her cheeks betrayed her.

Akki connected the electrodes, his tall figure bent over the console, fingers flying across the keys. The waveform sprang to life on the display—familiar rhythms, sharp and elegant.

"Quantum-linked REM," he explained, voice steady. "If consciousness overlaps across states, it should create resonance."

The crowd leaned in. Judges scribbled furiously.

And then—

The graph spiked. Violently.

Akki froze. This wasn't supposed to happen. The resonance climbed higher, faster, beyond safe parameters. The speakers hissed, lights flickering, shadows bending strangely across the hall.

"Shut it down!" one of the judges barked.

But Akki's eyes had already widened—not in fear. In recognition.

Because through the static, through the impossible data storm, he heard it—

A heartbeat. Light, rapid, familiar.

Kanvi's.

At her stall, Kanvi staggered, her small hands clutching the edge of her table. A piercing sound rang in her ears, drowning the crowd's shouts. Her vision blurred, and suddenly—

She wasn't standing in the auditorium anymore.

She was in the corridor. Again.

The silver walls pulsed, alive, trembling with unstable energy. And at the far end—Akki.

Their eyes locked, raw and unguarded.

Kanvi gasped. "No… not here…"

But before she could move, the floor cracked violently beneath her. She stumbled—and Akki was there, his tall frame surging forward, arms catching her before she could fall.

Her small body collided against his chest, her fingers digging into his coat instinctively. His grip around her waist was fierce, protective, his breath hot against her hair.

"Kanvi!" His voice thundered, echoing in both worlds—the corridor and the fair. "Stay with me!"

To the audience outside, it looked insane.

The machines sparked, lights danced wildly—and in the chaos, Akki and Kanvi had crashed into each other on the auditorium floor. His tall frame was bent over hers protectively, his hand gripping hers so tightly their knuckles turned white.

Students gasped. Whispers spread like fire.

But to them, none of it mattered.

Because in that suspended moment, their dream overlapped with reality. Kanvi's cheek pressed against his chest, her breath uneven, lips trembling dangerously close to his neck. His hand splayed across her waist, holding her as if letting go meant losing her forever.

Her voice cracked, whispering only for him:
"Why does it always pull me to you?"

He lowered his forehead to hers, his eyes blazing with something between fury and longing.

"Because you're mine," he whispered back.

And then—horror struck.

A third pulse shook the corridor. Not hers. Not his.

Something else.

The shadows at the edge twisted, forming into that faceless outline again. It leaned closer, voice jagged, splitting reality itself:

“She doesn’t belong to you.”

Kanvi screamed, clutching Akki tighter, her small hands fisting his coat. His jaw clenched, pulling her closer, his tall frame shielding her from the encroaching dark.

“Over my dead body,” he snarled.

The machines exploded in sparks, the hall plunged into darkness.

When the emergency lights flickered back, the crowd saw them still on the floor—his arm locked around her waist, her face buried against his chest.

The whispers were louder now, scandalized, curious.

But at that moment, neither cared.

Because their rivalry was no longer about science.
It was survival.

And their bond had just crossed a line that could never be undone.

Results & Tease

The chaos had finally settled.

The machines had been shut down, the sparks cleared, and murmurs of disbelief still rippled through the auditorium like aftershocks of an earthquake.

But the image was burned into everyone’s eyes:
Akki, tall and broad-shouldered, shielding Kanvi’s petite frame against the floor, his arms locked around her waist as if she were the only thing holding him to reality.

The judges’ faces were unreadable—equal parts awe, suspicion, and fascination.

Kanvi stood shakily now, brushing dust from her coat, her cheeks still flushed crimson. She kept her eyes low, but she could feel the heat of a hundred stares, the whispers that circled like wildfire.

“Did you see them—?”
“—he caught her like…”
“Too close… rivals? Really?”

Her fingers trembled as she clutched her notes to her chest. Focus, Kanvi. Just focus.

Akki, meanwhile, was maddeningly calm.

His coat was rumpled, his hair disheveled, but his sharp eyes held steady, scanning the hall as though daring anyone to question him. When he finally looked at her, his smirk returned—subtle, dangerous, meant only for her.

Kanvi’s stomach flipped violently. She wanted to glare at him, to shut him down, but the memory of his arms around her refused to fade. The way his voice had broken when he said you’re mine still echoed in her ears, leaving her weak in a way she hated.

The lead judge cleared his throat, silencing the hall.

“Both projects,” he began, voice deliberate, “are… remarkable. Dr. Kanvi’s model is a clinical breakthrough, with direct implications in neural trauma recovery.”

Polite applause followed. Kanvi bowed her head slightly, her small frame stiff with nervous pride.

“And Mr. Akki’s demonstration…” The judge’s eyes flickered to the scorched console, the faint smoke still rising. “…was reckless. But undeniably revolutionary. Consciousness mapping is… beyond anything we’ve seen attempted at this level.”

The hall buzzed with excitement.

The judge finally raised his clipboard. “Therefore, for innovation and vision—the award goes to…”

A pause.

“Mr. Akki.”

The auditorium erupted in applause.

Kanvi’s chest tightened, her throat closing. She forced a smile, clapping along with the crowd, but her hands shook.

Akki stepped forward, tall and assured, accepting the medal with the kind of quiet arrogance that made her want to scream. But when the ribbon hung around his neck, his eyes didn’t scan the crowd.

They searched only for her.

And when he found her, he smirked again—smaller this time, softer. A smirk that said I won… but not the way you think.

Later, when the hall emptied and the lights dimmed, Kanvi lingered by her stall, packing up slowly. Her small hands fumbled with the wires, her mind a storm of humiliation, longing, and something far more dangerous.

A shadow fell over her table.

She looked up.

Akki stood there, medal in hand, the faintest grin on his lips.

“Congratulations,” she said stiffly, forcing her voice steady.

He tilted his head. “It doesn’t matter.”

Her brows furrowed. “What?”

He leaned closer, his tall frame bending until his face was inches from hers. His voice dropped, low and rough, meant only for her ears.

“I don’t want the medal, Kanvi.” His fingers brushed lightly against hers, lingering far too long. “…I want you.”

Her breath caught violently. The world tilted.

For a second, she couldn’t breathe, couldn’t move. His touch burned into her skin, his words echoing louder than the applause ever had.

Her lips parted, trembling, but no sound came.

He smirked again, stepping back slowly, deliberately, leaving her flushed and breathless in the shadows.

“Next time,” he whispered, “don’t run from me.”

As his tall figure disappeared into the crowd, Kanvi pressed her small hands over her chest, her heart slamming against her ribs.

And for the first time, she admitted the truth she had been denying since childhood.

No matter how much she fought, no matter how much she hated losing—

Akki was the one dream she could never escape.

VIII.
The Unspoken Promises

The Night Walk

The campus slept.

Streetlamps flickered pale yellow across the stone pathways, painting long shadows that danced in the cool night air. The library windows glowed faintly behind Kanvi as she stepped outside, clutching her diary to her chest.

Her small figure moved slowly, lost in thought. The chaos of the fair still played in her mind—the way his tall frame shielded her, the way his voice had broken through the static, the way he whispered you're mine.

She shook her head furiously, cheeks hot even in the chill air. "Idiot. Why can't I stop thinking about him?"

A deep voice floated from the shadows.
"Talking to yourself again?"

Kanvi froze, her heart slamming in her chest.

From beneath the streetlamp, Akki stepped forward. His black coat swayed with the breeze, his sharp eyes catching the dim light. He looked almost unreal—tall, lean, impossibly steady.

Kanvi's lips parted, but no sound came.

"Akki…" she whispered.

He tilted his head slightly, smirk tugging at the corner of his mouth. "You say my name like it's forbidden."

Her breath caught. She hugged the diary tighter, trying to mask the tremor in her hands. "What are you doing here?"

"Couldn't sleep." He shrugged, his long strides closing the distance between them. "Thought maybe I'd find the reason why."

Kanvi's eyes widened. The unspoken weight in his words crushed her chest. She turned quickly, walking down the pathway, hoping the movement would hide the storm in her eyes.

But his steps followed, steady, close.

They walked side by side in silence. His tall frame towered over hers, their shadows stretching together across the stone. The night air was cool, but her skin burned every time his shoulder brushed hers by accident.

She shifted slightly, creating space.

A second later, he closed it.

Kanvi's lips pressed into a line. "You're doing that on purpose."

"Maybe." His voice dipped low, teasing. "Or maybe the night just doesn't want us apart."

Her heart raced. She hated how much she wanted to believe him.

They stopped by the campus fountain, its water glittering under the moon. Kanvi sat on the edge, her small hands fidgeting with the diary. Akki remained standing, his tall figure casting a long shadow over her.

For a moment, neither spoke. Only the sound of water. Only the weight of all the words they weren't saying.

Kanvi finally whispered, "Why are you really here?"

Akki leaned down, his sharp eyes locking on hers. His voice was quiet, rough.
"Because if I go home, I'll still see you. At least here, you're real."

Her chest tightened, her lips parting, trembling. The night air stilled.

She didn't know whether to run—or lean in closer.

The Video Call

The clock on Kanvi's desk read 12:47 a.m.

Her room was dim, lit only by the bluish glow of her laptop. She sat cross-legged on the bed, oversized hoodie drowning her petite frame. Her diary lay open beside her, half-written sentences trailing into nothing.

She chewed her lip, staring at the blank screen of the call window. Don't. Don't do it. It's stupid.

But her fingers betrayed her, typing his name.
"Akki."

The call connected after one ring.

On her screen, Akki appeared—hair messy, sharp jaw shadowed by stubble, black T-shirt clinging to his tall frame. He leaned back in his chair, one eyebrow arched.

“Couldn’t sleep either?” he asked.

Kanvi’s cheeks heated. She pulled the hoodie tighter around herself. “I… I just wanted to ask about the data spike today.”

His smirk deepened. “At 12:47 in the night?”

She glared softly. “Don’t make it sound like—”

“Like you wanted to see me?” he finished smoothly.

Her breath caught. She turned her face away from the screen, but he saw the flush spreading across her cheek anyway.

They spoke for a while, voices low, laughter breaking the silence in bursts. Akki teased her about her tiny handwriting in the diary he’d glimpsed earlier. She mocked him for the “mad scientist look” with his messy hair.

But then… It happened.

Kanvi was mid-sentence when his voice overlapped hers.

Both of them said at the same time, without meaning to:
“…because it felt real.”

They froze.

Her wide eyes met him on the screen. “What did you just—”

“I was going to ask—” he began, but she interrupted, whispering, “I didn’t say that out loud.”

The silence between them deepened, heavy, electrified.

Akki leaned closer to his camera, his sharp eyes narrowing. “Kanvi… think of something. Anything.”

Her throat tightened. She obeyed, whispering in her mind, Don’t you dare read this.

His lips curved slowly. “Too late.”

Her heart slammed in her chest. “No… no, that’s not possible.”

But she already knew it was. The dream-bond had followed them here, bleeding into the waking world.

Kanvi pulled the hood over her face, her small fingers gripping the fabric tight. “This is crazy,” she whispered.

His voice dropped lower, rough, and dangerous. “Crazy… or fate?”

Her breath shook. She tried to look away, but her gaze kept falling back to him—the messy hair, the tired eyes, the way he was staring at her as if nothing else in the world mattered.

For the first time, she didn’t fight it.

She whispered softly, barely audible:
“I hate how much I need this.”

Akki’s jaw clenched. His hand reached toward the camera as though he could cross the screen. “Then stop pretending.”

For a heartbeat, distance didn’t exist. Their silence was louder than words, heavier than time.

The Almost Confession

The call stretched longer than either expected.
Past one. Past two.

The campus outside slept. But inside their rooms, the silence between them pulsed louder than the ticking clock.

Kanvi sat with her knees hugged to her chest, hoodie slipping off one shoulder, her hair falling loose around her flushed face. Her diary still lay open—but the pen had long rolled away, forgotten.

On the screen, Akki leaned forward, forearms braced on his desk. The blue light cast sharp shadows across his jaw, his tall frame too large for the small frame of the camera.

They hadn’t spoken for minutes. They didn’t need to.

Their eyes held, unblinking, as though the screen had vanished.

Kanvi’s lips parted, trembling. She whispered so softly he almost didn’t hear it:
“Akki…”

His chest rose sharply. He leaned closer, until his face filled the screen, his voice raw.
“Say it.”

Her heart slammed. Her throat closed.

She wanted to. She needed to. The words sat heavy on her tongue—three words she'd swallowed since childhood, words she'd buried under rivalry and fear.

Her small fingers brushed the screen, tracing the outline of his face. On the other side, his long hand mirrored hers, palm against palm, separated by glass.

For one impossible second, it felt like skin.

Her voice broke. "Why does it hurt like this?"

His eyes burned into hers. "Because you're still holding back."

Kanvi bit her lip, trembling, her breath uneven. She leaned forward—closer, closer—until her lips hovered inches from the screen.

Akki's forehead touched the glass, his voice shaking. "Say it, Kanvi. Please."

The moment was unbearable. Their breaths synced, their silence a promise.

And then—

The lights in her room flickered violently. Her screen glitched, distorting his image, the sound cutting with static.

A whisper threaded through the interference. Not his. Not hers.

"She cannot belong to you."

Kanvi gasped, recoiling, her small hand clutching her chest. "No—"

Akki's sharp eyes widened on the frozen screen. He shouted her name, but the call snapped black.

She sat in darkness, her body trembling, tears burning in her eyes.

Her lips still tingled with the kiss that hadn't happened.

Her heart screamed with the words she hadn't spoken.

And in the shadows, a presence lingered, watching.

The Dream Echo

The night was heavier than usual.
After the call was cut, Kanvi curled up under her blanket, clutching her diary against her chest. Her small frame shook with frustration—at the static, at the shadow, at herself.

Her lips brushed the words she'd never said. "I love you…"
The whisper died in the dark.

Across campus, Akki lay awake on his narrow bed, one arm draped over his eyes. The medal from the science fair hung on his desk, untouched, meaningless.

He wasn't thinking about victory. He was thinking about the way her hand had pressed against the screen, the way her voice had broken.

He murmured into the silence, "Kanvi…"

And as if her name itself opened a door—sleep dragged him under.

The corridor returned.

Silver walls stretched endlessly. The floor pulsed like veins underfoot. The air vibrated with something alive, something ancient.

Kanvi appeared at the far end, her small figure trembling, eyes wide.

Akki exhaled, relief crashing over him. "You're here."

She broke into a run—bare feet against the strange floor, her hair flying around her. She collided into his chest, his tall frame absorbing her like she had always belonged there.

Her fingers gripped his coat desperately, and for once, she didn't pull away.

Their foreheads pressed together, breaths colliding, eyes shut tight as though separation itself would kill them.

And then—together, without planning, without thought—

Their voices whispered at the same time, raw, broken, perfect:

"Don't leave me."

The words overlapped like music, sinking into the walls, echoing in infinite loops.

For a heartbeat, nothing else existed.

But the corridor shuddered.

The air tore open at the edges.

The shadow emerged again—faceless, formless, but heavier now, darker, its presence crawling over their skin like frost.

It leaned closer, its voice jagged, splitting the silence:

“So it’s true. You belong to each other.”

Kanvi gasped, burying her face into Akki’s chest, her small body trembling violently. His arms wrapped tighter around her, his tall frame shielding her from the creeping dark.

But the shadow only laughed, the sound bending the corridor itself.

“Promises come at a cost.”

The walls cracked. The floor splintered.

Kanvi clung to him harder, her lips pressed against his collarbone, whispering like a prayer:
“Don’t let go.”
Akki’s jaw clenched, his grip iron. His voice roared into the collapsing dream:
“Over my dead body.”
The corridor shattered into light.

Both woke at the same time—Kanvi gasping in her bed, Akki sitting bolt upright in his.

But the same word slipped from their lips, at the same moment, in the same trembling voice:

Each other’s name.

“Akki—”
“Kanvi—”

And somewhere, in the silence of their rooms, a faint echo lingered.
Not theirs.

A whisper, dark and delighted:
“The bond is sealed.”

IX.
The Dream Within A Dream

Akki's Lab

Scene 1: Akki's Lab – The Neural Feedback Tech

The laboratory hummed with low electricity. Screens glowed faint blue in the dark, charts and graphs crawling across their surfaces like living creatures.

Akki stood in the center, a tall frame outlined by the glow of a single monitor. His sharp eyes moved rapidly across the data streams, but his mind was far from calm.

He had seen anomalies before. But never like this.

The readings from the science fair incident showed something impossible:
Two REM cycles overlapping.
Two heartbeats syncing.
Two consciousness signatures resonating.

He rubbed a hand across his jaw, muttering to himself. “This isn’t just entanglement… this is convergence.”

The door creaked.

Kanvi stepped inside, her small figure dwarfed by the sterile lab. She wore her white coat over casual clothes, her hair loose, falling against her shoulders. Her eyes carried exhaustion—but also curiosity.

“You called me here at midnight,” she said softly, her voice half-accusation, half-concern. “What is this about, Akki?”

He turned, and for a moment, just looking at her stole his words.

Then he gestured to the chair beside the console. “Sit. I need to show you something.”

She frowned but obeyed, her petite frame slipping into the chair. His tall shadow fell over her as he leaned close, fingers flying across the keyboard. Graphs shifted, merging, until two overlapping waveforms appeared on the screen.

Kanvi’s breath caught. “Those are…”

“Our brainwaves,” he finished. His voice was low, controlled, but his eyes burned. “From that night. They were in perfect sync.”

Her small hands curled into fists on her lap. “That’s not possible.”

He leaned closer still, his tall frame bending until his lips nearly brushed her ear. “Then explain why I hear you in my head.”

Her chest tightened violently. She turned, and their faces nearly collided—just inches apart. Her breath trembled as his gaze trapped her.

“Akki…”

He didn’t move back. He lifted a sleek headset from the console, holding it out. “There’s one way to know for sure.”

Kanvi stared at it, then at him. “You want us to—”

“—connect,” he finished. His eyes never left hers. “Fully.”

Her throat tightened. Her instincts screamed at her to refuse. But her hand lifted anyway, small fingers brushing against his as she took the headset.

The touch lingered longer than it should have.

And in that moment, the silence between them was louder than any machine.

The First Shared Dream

The headset clamped softly over Kanvi’s temples. She adjusted it nervously, her small fingers trembling against the cold metal. Akki leaned over, securing the second band across her forehead. His tall frame towered dangerously close, and for a fleeting second, his fingertips brushed her skin.

She flinched, heat rushing to her cheeks. “You don’t have to… hover.”

He smirked faintly. “If I leave you alone with this, you’ll panic.”

Her lips parted to retort, but he was already lowering his own headset into place.

The console beeped. Lights pulsed across the screen. Two separate waveforms began, jagged and unaligned. Slowly… slowly… they merged.

Kanvi’s breath hitched.

Akki’s hand, without warning, found hers on the armrest. He didn’t grip it. Just let their fingers touch, side by side, brushing lightly.

Her heart pounded.

Then the machine hummed louder—
And the lab dissolved.

Kanvi opened her eyes.

She was standing in a long corridor again—but it wasn't the same one.

The walls here glowed faint golden, shifting like silk in candlelight. The floor was polished marble, reflecting both their figures.

Akki stood only a few feet away, taller than ever, his black coat swaying slightly though no wind touched it. His sharp eyes widened briefly—then softened.

"It worked," he said, his voice lower, warmer.

Kanvi spun around. "We're… still asleep?"

He stepped toward her, his stride measured, slow, predatory almost. "Not asleep. Connected."

Her chest tightened. "So this is…"

"…our first layer," he finished.

The corridor wasn't empty.

Doors lined both sides, each carved with strange patterns. Some glowed faintly, some shivered as if something moved behind them.

Kanvi's small hand brushed one door. It pulsed under her fingertips. Her breath caught. "These are…"

Akki's voice sank. "…dreams. Each door, a layer. If we open one…"

She glanced back, meeting his eyes. His gaze burned steady, but she saw the flicker of tension beneath it. He wasn't just experimenting anymore. He was taking a risk.

She took a deep breath, whispering, "Then open one."

His brow furrowed. "You trust me that much?"

Her lips trembled. "I don't trust the shadows. But you…" She hesitated, then added, softer: "…you always catch me."

For a moment, silence held them.

Akki's tall frame stilled, his sharp eyes unreadable. Then, slowly, his hand rose. He pressed his palm against the nearest door.

It swung open—

And golden light spilled out.

The world shifted.

They stood now in a quiet meadow under moonlight. Fireflies drifted lazily in the air, their glow reflecting in Kanvi's wide eyes. The grass brushed against her ankles, cool, soft.

She exhaled shakily. "This… doesn't feel like a dream."

Akki's gaze never left her. "Maybe because it isn't just yours anymore."

Her heart hammered at his words. She turned away quickly, her hair hiding her face, but her small hands trembled at her sides.

For a few minutes, they just walked—her short steps, his long stride adjusting unconsciously to match hers. Fireflies trailed them, glowing threads of gold in the dark.

Kanvi finally whispered, "If this is the first layer… what happens if we go deeper?"

Akki looked up at the endless night sky. His jaw tightened. "We'll find out."

And as if summoned by his words, the meadow flickered. The ground trembled faintly. Fireflies blinked out one by one.

Kanvi gasped, clutching his arm instinctively. Her small body pressed into his side, her fingers fisting his coat.

The meadow cracked like glass—

And beneath it, another corridor waited. Darker. Narrower. Its walls breathed like lungs, shadows crawling across them.

Kanvi's voice shook. "Akki… this isn't the same."

His tall frame shifted, pulling her behind him protectively. His voice hardened, low and rough.
"This is the second layer."

Dream Inside a Dream

The second corridor pressed around them like a throat, walls pulsating with a faint, sick rhythm.

Kanvi clung tighter to Akki's coat, her small fingers curling into the fabric. "I don't like this," she whispered, her voice trembling.

His tall frame shifted protectively, placing himself between her and the crawling dark. His sharp eyes scanned every inch of the corridor, jaw tight.

"We'll get out."

But when they reached the far end, the door burst open without warning—blinding white light swallowing them both.

Kanvi gasped, bolting upright.

Her diary lay open beside her, the pen rolled across the bed. The lamplight glowed faintly. Her room. Her blanket tangled around her small frame.

She pressed a hand over her racing heart. "It was just a dream…"

A knock startled her.

She turned—her door was open.

And there, leaning casually against the frame, was Akki.

Kanvi froze. "What—how did you—?"

He stepped inside, tall and calm, his voice low, dangerous. "I couldn't leave you there."

She backed up against her desk, her breath unsteady. "This isn't possible. You're… you're not supposed to be here."

His stride closed the distance in three steps. He stopped only inches away, his shadow swallowing hers. His hand rose slowly, brushing her jawline, tilting her face up toward him.

Her lips parted, trembling. Her small hands lifted instinctively, pressing against his chest—not to push him away, but to feel the heat of his heartbeat under her palms.

"Akki…"

Her whisper cracked.

His sharp eyes burned into hers. His thumb traced her cheekbone, lingering at the corner of her mouth.

"Say it," he whispered, breathing warmly against her lips. "Say you need me."

Her knees buckled. She gripped his shirt tighter, trembling under his touch. Her lips brushed his—so close she could taste the warmth of his breath.

Her heart screamed the words. I love you. I need you. I can't fight this anymore.

And then—

The lights flickered.

His face rippled, distorted. For a split second, the warmth of his skin turned cold, his eyes black voids instead of fire.

Kanvi gasped, stumbling back. "No—"

The room shuddered. Walls cracked. The diary on her desk bled ink, letters forming on its pages without a pen:

YOU NEVER WOKE UP.

Her scream tore through the collapsing room.

She fell.

Not onto her bed—
But back into the second corridor.

The shadows hissed, crawling faster, hungrier.

Akki caught her mid-fall, his arms locking around her waist, his tall frame steady even as the corridor shook. Her small body buried into his chest, trembling violently.

His voice roared against the echoing dark.
"They tried to trap us. But I won't let them."

Kanvi's tears soaked into his coat. Her lips brushed against his throat as she whispered, broken, "I thought you were gone…"

His grip only tightened, his jaw clenched. "Even if it's a thousand dreams deep—I'll find you."

The Glitch & Escape Attempt

The corridor was tearing itself apart.

Walls rippled like water, the floor cracked into shifting tiles. Shadows crawled across the ceiling, whispering in a hundred voices, each word cutting like knives.

Kanvi clung desperately to Akki's coat, her small frame shaking against his chest. Her breath came in shallow gasps, tears streaking her flushed cheeks. "We're going to be trapped—we'll never wake up—"

"Look at me," Akki commanded, his voice hard, sharp, unshakable. His tall frame bent low, his sharp eyes burning into hers. "As long as I'm here, nothing touches you. Understand?"

Her lips trembled, but she nodded, burying her face against him, her tiny fingers fisting his shirt.

Somewhere far away, the real world stirred.

The neural console blinked red. Warning alarms flickered. The overlapping REM feedback spiked violently, two waveforms thrashing against each other.

On the screen, error messages pulsed:

NEURAL CONVERGENCE BREACH.
SYSTEM OVERLOAD IMMINENT.

Inside the corridor, Akki felt it too. The air vibrated painfully, pressure splitting his temples. He gritted his teeth, pulling Kanvi tighter against him, his voice rough.

"They're trying to sever the link."

Her voice cracked. "Can you stop it?"

His jaw tightened. "Not without a risk."

The corridor shuddered. A fissure tore across the ceiling. Through it, Kanvi glimpsed jagged glimpses of their real lab—monitors, lights, their still bodies strapped into chairs.

Her heart slammed. "That's us!"

Akki's arms held her steady as the floor shook violently. His tall frame shifted, shielding her with every crash.

He growled low. "I'll override it."

He dragged her toward the crack, every step a battle against the collapsing ground. The shadows lunged, hands clawing out of the walls, whispering curses in voices that weren't human.

One hand snatched Kanvi's ankle. She screamed—

Akki spun, scooping her into his arms effortlessly, her small body pressed against his chest. “I said,” he roared, “NOT HER!”

He stomped down, shadows exploding into dust.

Kanvi’s arms clung around his neck, her face buried against him, her tears soaking into his collar. Her lips brushed his skin as she whispered, broken, “Don’t leave me.”

His grip only tightened, muscles straining as he carried her through the chaos. “Never.”

At the fissure, light burned like fire. Akki’s eyes locked on the jagged tear. He shifted her higher against his chest, his voice rough but steady.

“When we hit it—focus on waking. Don’t think about anything else. Understand?”

Her wide eyes shimmered with fear, but she nodded, whispering, “If you’re holding me, I’ll wake.”

For the first time, his lips curved—not a smirk, not arrogance—something softer, rawer.

“Then hold on, Kanvi.”

They leapt.

The fissure tore wider, light searing, the world collapsing behind them.

Kanvi gasped, jolting upright—back in the lab chair, the headset slipping off her head. Her chest heaved, sweat dripping down her temples.

Across from her, Akki ripped his own headset free, sharp eyes wide, chest rising like a storm.

They locked eyes.

And then—

Every light in the lab flickered, static screaming across the monitors.

A voice slithered through the speakers, deep, delighted, inhuman:

“You think you woke up… but you’re still inside.”

The monitors all went black.

Only two words burned across every screen, glowing blood-red:

PROMISES BIND.

X.
Fragments Of Reality

The Silent Lab

The lab was too quiet.

Not the calm silence of night, but the suffocating stillness of a place holding its breath.

Kanvi's lashes fluttered as she pulled the heavy headset off, her slender fingers trembling. The band left faint red marks on her forehead. Her chest rose and fell too quickly, as though her heart was still running long after her body had stopped.

She blinked, disoriented. The sterile white walls of the lab surrounded her, glowing faintly under cold fluorescent lights. The hum of the monitors, the soft whir of the cooling vents, the faint medicinal smell of disinfectant—everything screamed reality.

But it didn't feel real.

Her throat was dry, her voice shaky as she whispered, "We… we made it back?"

Across from her, Akki leaned forward in his chair, tall frame bent, one elbow braced on his knee, the other hand tugging his own headset free. Sweat glistened along his temples, dripping onto the collar of his black coat. His sharp eyes lifted slowly, locking onto hers with a fierceness that made her small body flinch.

For a moment, neither of them spoke. The silence pressed harder.

Then Akki exhaled—a long, measured breath that fogged the cool air. "We're here."

But his tone was flat. Careful. Like a man convincing himself.

Kanvi's small hands fumbled with her diary that lay on the desk beside her. She clutched it like a talisman, pressing it against her chest. The familiar feeling should have grounded her. But her heartbeat refused to slow.

She glanced at the monitors—comfort, reassurance, anything. The blue graphs moved rhythmically, heart rate and brainwave patterns scrolling in neat lines. Too neat. Too perfect.

Her brows knit together. "Akki… look."

He was already on his feet. His tall shadow swallowed the glow from the screen as he leaned over, scanning the display with rapid precision. His sharp jaw flexed.

Kanvi's voice trembled, though she tried to sound logical. "If this is real… Why do the waveforms look alive?"

Because they were.

The twin lines pulsed in and out, not like machines recording activity—but like lungs, expanding and contracting, as if the graphs themselves were breathing.

Kanvi's chest tightened painfully. She stumbled back a step, her small frame colliding with his side. Instinctively, his hand shot out, gripping her shoulder steady.

The heat of his palm seared through her thin sleeve.

She turned up to him, wide-eyed. "Tell me that's not what I think it is."

His sharp eyes flickered, uncharacteristically uncertain. "It… shouldn't be."

For a moment, his grip lingered, his tall body angled toward her, his breath close to her ear. She felt her skin prickle, her pulse spike—too much, too fast.

And then the console beeped.

Both froze.

The screen flashed red, letters burning across the surface:

SYSTEM ANOMALY DETECTED.
REALITY INDEX COMPROMISED.

The fluorescent lights overhead flickered violently. A low hum filled the room, vibrating through the floor.

Kanvi gasped, pressing into him. Her small fists clutched the fabric of his coat. "Akki… tell me this isn't happening again—"

His jaw clenched, his hand cupping the back of her head almost protectively, pulling her against his chest. "Stay calm." His voice was deep, steady, but the tension in his body betrayed him.

The lab seemed to tilt, shadows lengthening unnaturally, as if the walls were stretching.

Kanvi's pulse pounded so loudly it drowned out everything else. She whispered, almost broken, "What if we never left at all?"

Akki's sharp eyes narrowed, his voice cutting like steel: "Then we fight until we do."

The console beeped again—this time deeper, distorted, like a heartbeat echoing from somewhere that wasn't human.

The First Glitches

The hum of the lab deepened.

Not the steady hum of electronics, but something heavier—like a pulse echoing from the walls.

Kanvi's throat tightened as she turned toward the console again. The graphs were no longer neat. The two overlapping waveforms didn't simply pulse—they writhed. The lines bent, twisted, as though something alive struggled behind the glass.

She whispered, "Akki… it's watching us."

Her own words chilled her blood.

Akki moved closer to the screen, his tall frame tense, sharp eyes narrowing at the distortion. His fingers danced over the keys with controlled urgency. Windows opened, lines of code spilling across the monitor—yet none of his commands seemed to matter.

Every time he tried to reset, the waveforms twisted back.

Kanvi's small frame hovered behind him, close enough that her breath brushed the back of his coat. "Can't you fix it?"

His jaw tightened. "Machines don't fight back."

"But this one is."

The air between them thickened. She almost reached out—almost placed her small hand on his back—before pulling it away. Her fingers curled into her palm instead.

The overhead lights flickered again. One by one, each fixture buzzed and dimmed, plunging parts of the lab into shadow.

Kanvi's petite figure flinched, shrinking closer to him. Her voice cracked. "This doesn't feel like waking. It feels like—"

"Stop."

His voice was rougher than he intended. She froze, staring up at him.

Akki turned, his sharp gaze locking onto hers. His tall frame towered over her, but his hand—gentler now—reached up, steadying her chin between his fingers, forcing her trembling eyes to meet his.

"If you let yourself believe it's not real," he said softly, dangerously, "the dream will eat you alive."

Her lips trembled under his touch. Her diary slipped from her arms, hitting the floor with a dull thud.

For one stolen second, the lab, the glitches, the chaos—all faded.

There was only his hand on her skin. His breath, warm and too close. The thundering of her heart against her ribs.

She wanted to step away. She wanted to collapse into him.

Her body couldn't decide.

The console screeched.

Both of them jolted. His hand dropped instantly, as though burned.

The screen flooded red. Words carved themselves across the surface, jagged and uneven, as if written by an unseen hand:

REALITY INDEX COLLAPSING.
SUBJECTS STILL LINKED.

Kanvi stumbled back, her heel catching the edge of a chair. She almost fell—until his arm shot out, catching her waist.

Her small frame collided into his tall body, pressed firmly against his chest. His hold was firm, protective, almost desperate.

Her breath shook as she whispered against him, "We never left, did we?"

Akki's eyes burned into the screen, his voice low, ragged.

"…Not yet."

Memory Fractures

The words still burned on the console:

SUBJECTS STILL LINKED.

Kanvi's lips moved, but no sound came out. Her wide eyes shimmered, her small body stiff in Akki's grip. She clutched at his coat like it was the only solid thing left in existence.

Her voice finally broke, raw, trembling. "If this isn't real, then what is?"

Akki didn't answer. He couldn't. His sharp gaze stayed locked on the console, jaw tight, chest rising heavy against her cheek. His mind, the mind that never failed equations, refused to solve this one.

The lab shifted.

Not a glitch this time—something deeper.

For a fraction of a second, the sterile walls dissolved. Instead, bookshelves stretched up toward a high wooden ceiling. Dust floated in sunlight beams, warm and golden. The smell of old paper filled her nose.

Kanvi gasped. She wasn't twenty anymore. She was twelve.

Her feet barely touched the floor as she sat at a library desk, her diary smaller, clumsier in her tiny hands. Across from her sat Akki—just as young, head bent, scribbling furiously in his notebook.

His boyish voice teased, "Kanvi, you spelled hydrogen wrong again."

Her younger self laughed, her small shoulders shaking.

The sound felt real. Too real.

Kanvi blinked hard—
And the vision shattered.

The lab walls returned, glaringly white, but her knees buckled as though she'd been ripped out of another life.

Akki caught her again, both arms wrapping around her waist. His tall frame steadied her as she gasped for breath.

"I saw us," she whispered hoarsely, clutching his coat. "In the library. Years ago. You were making fun of me."

His sharp eyes widened faintly. His grip on her tightened. "I saw it too."

The lab shifted again.

This time it wasn't her memory—it was his.

Akki's head dropped against a desk, his younger self fast asleep in class, hair messy, notebooks sprawled. A small Kanvi leaned over, eyes shining with annoyance.

She flicked his ear and hissed, "Stay awake, genius."

The memory folded itself over the lab like film sliding over a projector. The walls blurred, the machines dissolved—only the classroom remained, their young laughter echoing.

Kanvi's small hands flew to her temples. "No—no, that was yours—how could I—"

She swayed. Her petite body would've crumpled if not for his arms locking firmly around her. He pulled her against him, one large hand cradling the back of her head, tucking her into his chest.

His voice was low, strained. "Our minds are bleeding together."

Her tears soaked his shirt. "I don't want this… it feels like I'm losing myself."

"You're not." His tone sharpened, steel hidden under the rawness. He pressed her smaller form closer, his tall frame almost engulfing her. "You're Kanvi. And you're mine to protect. No matter what these fractures try to show you."

The lights flickered violently. Both memories—the library and the classroom—flashed at once, overlapping like broken film reels. Kanvi's laughter. Akki's sleepy grin. Two timelines colliding in one place.

Kanvi's small fists clutched his coat tighter, her voice breaking as she whispered, "What if we're stuck between them forever?"

Akki's sharp jaw set, his eyes blazing into the distortion. "Then I'll break reality itself if I have to."

And the walls cracked.

Subconscious Betrayal

The walls of the lab groaned. Not just flickers now—deep fractures running across surfaces like cracks in a mirror. Each pulse of light split reality further, and with it, Kanvi's breath faltered.

She pressed herself harder against Akki's chest, her small frame trembling in his tall arms. Her voice was muffled against his coat. "I can't do this. If the world keeps breaking like this… I'll shatter it."

Akki's hand cradled the back of her head firmly, his other arm wrapped tight around her waist, anchoring her trembling body to his. His sharp jaw was clenched, his voice low, dangerous. "You won't shatter. Not while I'm holding you."

For a moment, it felt like enough. Like his sheer presence could keep her intact.

But then—

The crack in the wall widened, spilling a glow not of light, but of dream. Threads of shadowy images seeped out—her own fears, her own secrets.

Kanvi's eyes widened.

A door had appeared on the far wall. Plain, wooden, trembling faintly like it was alive. Her chest constricted painfully the moment she looked at it.

Akki noticed the way her body stiffened against him. His sharp gaze flicked from her to the door. "Kanvi… what is that?"

Her lips parted, no sound escaping. She shook her head violently, clutching at his coat. "Don't—don't open it—"

But the door groaned, handling twitching as though something inside already knew it was being watched.

Akki moved forward, shielding her with his body. His tall frame cast a long shadow across the floor. "It's your subconscious," he said tightly. "A fracture point. If we confront it—"

"No!" Her cry cut him off, her small hands pushing against his chest. "Please… you don't understand—if you see what's inside, you'll hate me."

Her voice cracked on the last word.

Akki's sharp eyes softened, but only slightly. He cupped her face with his palm, tilting her trembling gaze up to his. "Kanvi. Nothing you show me will make me hate you."

Her tears blurred his outline. She wanted to believe him. Wanted to fall into the warmth of his conviction. But the door shook harder. Splinters cracked from the frame.

Her subconscious didn't care about promises.

The door burst open.

Images spilled into the lab like water from a broken dam. Kanvi's own thoughts, her own hidden fears—projected into reality.

She saw herself—leaving.

Her small figure walked away from Akki, suitcase in hand, not looking back. His taller silhouette left behind, rigid, alone.

Kanvi gasped, stumbling backward. "No… no, I never meant—"

Akki's sharp eyes burned into the scene, then flicked to her. For the first time, something raw, something wounded flickered in them.

She broke. She fell to her knees, clutching her diary against her chest, sobbing. "I didn't want you to see this—I don't want to hurt you—"

Akki dropped down beside her in an instant, his tall frame folding to enclose her. His hands gripped her trembling shoulders firmly, almost fiercely, forcing her to face him.

"Kanvi, look at me!"

Her tear-filled eyes finally lifted.

His voice thundered, rough but unshakable: "That vision isn't truth. It's fear. And fear doesn't define you."

Her lips quivered. "But what if someday—"

His forehead pressed to hers, closing the space, their breaths colliding, heat mingling. His sharp eyes blazed into hers. "Then I'll fight even that day. Even if you walk away, I'll drag you back into my world."

Her tears slid down her cheeks, but her lips parted helplessly, trembling under the weight of his words.

For one charged moment, the universe seemed to hold its breath.

And then—

The door slammed shut on its own, the fracture sealing violently.

Both flinched, the lab shuddering as if in pain. The shadows hissed from the corners, whispering mockingly:

"Betrayal tastes sweet. And it always comes from within."

Kanvi buried her face into his chest, sobbing. Akki's arms locked around her tiny form like iron. His sharp jaw set, his voice a low growl.

"Let them mock. You're mine. Not theirs."

The Fracture Climax

The lab was no longer whole.

Every surface shook, as though invisible hands gripped the walls and twisted them. Cracks spread like veins of fire, glowing faintly with something that wasn't light, but memory.

Kanvi clung desperately to Akki's coat, her small frame trembling against his tall body. Her tears hadn't dried yet, her breath catching in uneven gasps. "It won't stop. Everything is falling apart…"

Akki's jaw tightened, sharp eyes sweeping the chaos around them. His arms enclosed her smaller form, anchoring her against his chest. "Then let it fall apart. We'll survive it."

The console sparked violently, shards of glass raining across the floor. On every broken piece, letters bled like ink:

REALITY INDEX COLLAPSED.
NO EXIT FOUND.

Kanvi's knees buckled. "No exit—? Akki, does that mean—"

"Don't." His voice cut, harsh, but his hand never left her. He tilted her face up again, forcing her trembling eyes to meet his sharp, unyielding gaze. "Listen to me. No matter what they show you, you hold onto me. You understand? Not the walls, not the machines—me."

Her lips trembled, parted, wanting to answer. But the floor cracked under their feet, the lab splitting like shattered glass.

Through the fracture, another world bled through.

Not the corridor this time—something darker. Endless mirrors stretched out in every direction, each reflecting versions of themselves: Akki cold and distant, Kanvi walking away, Akki broken, Kanvi vanishing into shadow.

Kanvi gasped, clutching him tighter. "Why are they all… leaving?"

His arms locked around her, his tall form pressing her protectively against him. His breath was hot against her hair as he whispered, low and fierce: "Because that's what you fear most. But I'm not letting it happen."

One mirror cracked. Then another. Shards flew outward, slicing through the air like knives. Akki shielded her, his coat tearing, his skin cut, but he never let go.

The shadows in the mirrors laughed, their voices overlapping, crawling into their ears.

"Promises bind. And promises break."

Kanvi whimpered, burying her face against his chest. Her small hands fisted his shirt so tightly her knuckles turned white.

Akki's sharp eyes burned into the broken reflections. His voice roared, echoing like thunder: "Not this one."

The mirrors shattered all at once, an explosion of glass and screams. The lab dissolved into a storm of fragments, each piece spinning away into nothing.

Kanvi gasped, her body weightless, falling into the void. She cried out, reaching blindly—

Akki's hand seized hers mid-air. His grip was iron, unbreakable. Their bodies were torn apart by gravity, but their hands locked in defiance.

Her wide, tear-streaked eyes locked on his sharp, blazing ones.

"Don't let go!" she screamed.

His voice cut through the void, raw, thunderous. "I never will!"

And then—

Everything went black.

For a long, suffocating moment, there was nothing but silence.

Then—words slithered through the dark, deep and mocking:

"You thought you escaped the dream. But the dream has escaped you."

A single red line carved itself into the void, glowing like fire:

XI.
Signals In The Dark

The Awakening

Darkness.

Not peaceful night-darkness, but the oppressive kind that feels alive. The lab, once sterile white and humming with lights, was now swallowed by shadow. Only faint emergency strips glowed blood-red along the floor, making the room look less like a sanctuary of science and more like a crypt.

Kanvi's lashes trembled. Her eyes opened slowly, adjusting to the dim. She realized she was still in Akki's arms, her petite frame half-curled against his tall body. His heartbeat thundered beneath her ear, ragged and uneven, like he'd just fought a war.

For a moment, she didn't move. She couldn't. His arm was still locked around her waist, firm and protective, grounding her against the tremors still wracking her body.

"…Akki?" her voice cracked, small and raw.

He stirred. His sharp eyes blinked open, catching the red glow like embers. His jaw flexed as he pushed himself upright, still keeping her against him.

"You're awake," he muttered, his voice gravel, low and dangerous—but softening when he looked down at her. His hand instinctively brushed her hair from her face, fingertips gentle against her flushed skin.

Kanvi swallowed hard, unable to hide the way her pulse raced at the simple touch. She whispered, "Where are we?"

He scanned the room. "Still the lab. But…" His words trailed off as his sharp gaze moved over the silent machines, the dark corners, the shadows that seemed to ripple when stared at too long. "It's not the same."

Kanvi shivered, clutching her diary to her chest. The familiar weight should have anchored her, but the red-lit silence pressed against her lungs like a weight.

She whispered again, almost to herself, "I thought we escaped."

Akki turned to her, his tall silhouette outlined by the crimson glow. "If this is an escape, it's worse than the dream."

His tone was clinical, scientific. But she could feel the slight tremor in his grip, the unspoken fear he would never admit aloud.

Her small hand reached instinctively, fingers brushing his sleeve. "Don't let go."

He froze. For once, his logic, his control, his calculations—all fell away. His hand shifted until it enclosed hers fully, large fingers wrapping around her smaller ones, squeezing tight.

"I wasn't planning to."

The silence deepened. Then, faintly, impossibly, a sound rose from the machines.

A pulse.

Not mechanical. Not static. A sound too organic, like a heartbeat amplified through wires.

Kanvi stiffened, pressing into his side. Her wide eyes shimmered in the dim. “Do you hear that?”

His sharp jaw flexed. “I do.”

The consoles flickered to life one by one, screens glowing pale blue. The hum of power returned—not steady, not clean. Distorted. Jagged. As though the electricity itself was infected.

Kanvi’s grip on his hand tightened, her small body trembling. “The lab doesn’t have backup power. How—”

Before she could finish, the largest monitor lit up. Lines of code scrolled too fast to read. Static hissed.

And then… words formed across the screen:

SIGNAL DETECTED.
CHANNEL: UNKNOWN.

Kanvi’s voice faltered, whispering into the silence. “…Signal? From where?”

Akki’s sharp eyes narrowed, his tall frame moving slightly ahead of her, as if shielding her from even the glow of the monitor.

“Not from where,” he murmured darkly. “From who?”

First Signal

The glow from the monitor grew brighter, washing the lab in cold light. The red floor-strips flickered nervously, as if they didn't even want to stay lit in this place.

Kanvi’s breath hitched. She stepped closer to Akki, her small hand clutching the back of his sleeve. “It’s… it’s talking to us.”

Akki didn’t answer immediately. His sharp eyes traced the screen, the scrolling code. His tall frame blocked most of the light from reaching her, shielding her even from the monitor’s harsh glow. His hands moved to the console, typing with precise speed.

The machine resisted. Each keystroke he entered warped into distorted symbols. The system wasn't being used—it was being possessed.

And then the scrolling stopped.

The screen froze on a single line:

YOU'RE NOT DREAMING ANYMORE.

Kanvi's fingers dug tighter into his sleeve. "Not dreaming? Then… are we awake?"

Another line appeared immediately, cutting her question short:

BUT YOU'RE NOT AWAKE EITHER.

Kanvi stumbled back, her diary nearly slipping from her grip. She hugged it tightly, her small frame shaking. "That's impossible—Akki, that's impossible!"

Her voice cracked, and she hated the way it sounded, so vulnerable.

Akki turned, catching her eyes with his sharp, unflinching stare. "Nothing's impossible anymore."

He reached for her hand. She flinched, but then let him take it. His large fingers closed around hers, squeezing with steady force. His voice softened just slightly, just enough for her: "Don't let fear rewrite you. Stay here—with me."

Her pulse fluttered, but she nodded weakly.

The monitor shifted again. Static crawled across the glass. A figure began to form—tall, faceless, cloaked in interference. Its body was a silhouette of shadows wrapped in glitching lines of light.

The voice that came wasn't a voice at all, but a chorus of whispers layered with static, male and female, young and old, all speaking at once:

"You linked yourselves when you weren't meant to. Love inside the dream bleeds across. And now, the walls have no meaning."

Kanvi's heart stopped. Her small hand tightened around Akki's so hard it hurt. Her wide eyes flickered up to him. "It knows. About us."

Akki's sharp jaw set, his gaze unflinching against the figure on the screen. "Then let it know. I'm not ashamed."

Kanvi's breath caught. Her lips trembled, a thousand words caught in her throat. She wanted to hide, to deny it—but at the same time, hearing him say it aloud sent fire racing through her chest.

The shadow-figure tilted its head, glitching as though amused.

"Signals bind stronger than vows. But every signal can be severed."

The screen cracked. Sparks spit violently. Kanvi cried out, stumbling closer to Akki, pressing her cheek against his back. Her small hands clutched at his coat desperately, muffling her trembling voice: "Don't… don't let it cut us apart."
Akki's tall frame stood like stone, shielding her from the sparks. His sharp eyes bored into the shadowed figure as he growled through clenched teeth:

"Let it try."

Dreams Bleed Through

The screen burst into static, flooding the lab with a piercing hiss. The sound crawled into Kanvi's ears, vibrating through her skull, until she thought her head might split apart.

And then—the walls rippled.

The sterile lab bent and warped like melting glass. White panels stretched, dissolved, and reshaped themselves. The scent of disinfectant was replaced by something warmer—chalk dust, paper, faint perfume of childhood days.

Kanvi gasped, her diary slipping from her hands and falling open on the ground. Its pages flipped on their own, words blurring into shifting lines.

When she lifted her head, she was no longer in the lab.

She was in the school corridor.

Her small frame wavered as she stumbled forward, heart hammering. The tiled floor stretched endlessly, lined with lockers, their doors clanging shut and open on their own. Whispers echoed in the hallway—familiar voices of children, giggling, chanting.

Her knees weakened. She knew these sounds. She remembered them.

A shadow moved past her—her own younger self, hair braided neatly, holding the same diary in smaller hands.

Kanvi froze. The sight stole her breath.

The young Kanvi walked right past her, laughing at something invisible, her tiny voice ringing clear: "Akki, you'll always be taller than me!"

Tears stung her eyes. "No… no, this isn't real. This can't be—"

Akki's hand grabbed hers. Firm. Solid.

She turned—he was still there. His tall silhouette cut sharply against the endless corridor, sharp eyes burning as he anchored her to him. "Don't let it trick you."

Her small hands trembled in his. "Akki, that was me. I… I saw myself—"

His grip tightened, forcing her to feel the heat, the weight of his reality. His voice was iron. "Then look at me. The real you is here, with me."

Her tears slid down, but she nodded weakly, leaning against his chest. His arm slipped around her waist, steadying her trembling form.

The corridor shifted again.

Lockers dissolved into wooden boards. A banner fluttered above them: SCIENCE FAIR – 2013.

Kanvi's breath hitched. The smell of paint, glue, and metal filled her nose. She saw her younger self again, standing nervously beside a display board covered in diagrams. And next to her—young Akki, taller even then, grinning confidently as he adjusted wires on a project.

Kanvi's lips parted. "That's… that's the fair. The first time we presented together."

The memory Kanvi blushed as Akki leaned close to whisper something. Kanvi's older self could almost hear it—his boyish, teasing voice: "You're shaking. Don't worry—I'll talk. You just smile."

Her chest ached. Her diary pages scattered across the floor, each page filled with scribbled hearts and half-written confessions she never dared to say back then.

Kanvi swayed violently. The weight of memories crushed into her chest, her legs failing beneath her.

Before she could collapse, Akki swept her off the ground effortlessly, cradling her small form in his tall arms. Her cheek pressed against his collar, his heartbeat thundering under her ear.

"Stay with me," he muttered, his voice rough, urgent. His sharp eyes scanned the corridor warily, as if daring it to take her away.

She clung to his shirt, her voice trembling. "I used to dream of this… you carried me like this. Even back then."

His breath caught. His arms tightened around her. He lowered his face close, lips almost brushing her ear as he whispered, “Then stop dreaming. Because now it’s real.”

Her entire body shivered—not from fear this time, but from the weight of those words.

The corridor flickered violently, like film burning in a projector. Both past and present overlapped—her young laughter echoing with her present sobs, Akki’s boyish grin layered with the sharp, protective gaze of the man holding her now.

And at the far end of the hall, the shadowed figure stood waiting.

Shadowed Figure Manifest

At the far end of the corridor, beneath the flickering lights, the shadowed figure stood.

It was tall—taller than Akki even—but its body wasn’t solid. Its outline wavered, stitched together from glitching static and dark fog. Its face was nothing but shifting static, like an old TV caught between channels.

The silence around it was suffocating. The whispers of childhood laughter faded the moment it appeared, swallowed by a silence so deep it roared in their ears.

Kanvi’s small body tensed in Akki’s arms. Her wide eyes shimmered, her lips barely able to form the words. “It’s real…”

Akki set her gently down, his hands lingering on her shoulders as he positioned his tall frame in front of her. His sharp eyes locked on the figure, his stance unyielding. “Stay behind me.”

But Kanvi clutched the back of his coat immediately, her trembling cheek pressing against his back. “No. Don’t face it alone.”

The figure tilted its head, a distortion of movement. Its voice came not as one but as hundreds, layered in overlapping static.

“Signals bind. But signals break. Your bond bleeds into systems not built to hold it.”

Akki’s jaw tightened, his glare like steel. “If you came to scare us, you’ll have to do better.”

The figure twitched, its limbs bending wrong, its static body glitching violently. The corridor lights flickered in rhythm with its voice:

“You made a promise inside the dream. Now that promise rewrites reality.”

Kanvi flinched at the word promise. Her small hands clutched tighter at Akki's back, her trembling whisper spilling before she could stop it: "It knows… it knows about us."

Akki glanced back briefly, catching her tear-streaked face. His sharp eyes softened only for her. His hand reached behind, finding her fingers and threading them with his own. His large hand engulfed hers firmly.

"Then let it know," he said, voice low, dangerous. "I won't break that promise."

The figure jolted, static screeching like broken glass. Its voice fractured into a hiss.

"Every signal can be severed. And every vow can be betrayed."

The lockers around them rattled violently, bursting open one by one. From each locker, fragments of memories spilled—pages of Kanvi's diary, young Akki's notebooks, scraps of chalkboard notes.

The paper swirled into the air like a storm, circling the shadow. On every sheet, words appeared in dripping black ink:

LEAVE.
LEAVE.
LEAVE.

Kanvi's breath broke. "It's trying to separate us…"

Her knees weakened, but before she could fall, Akki pulled her close, her small frame pressed against his chest. His sharp jaw brushed her hair as he whispered fiercely, "I won't let it."

The shadowed figure's glitching head snapped violently toward them, static roaring. The walls cracked, the floor trembling under their feet.

Kanvi buried her face against Akki's chest, muffling a sob. Her words were muffled but desperate: "Don't let it take you. If it cuts you away from me—"
Akki tilted his head down, his lips almost at her ear. His voice was molten steel, whispering through the chaos:

"Even if it tears the world apart, I'll hold you."
For a single moment, her heart stopped, stunned by the rawness of it.

And then—the shadow lunged.

Signal of the Heart

The shadow lunged.

Its body wasn't flesh but splinters of dream and static, claws like jagged lightning. The corridor warped with each step it took—floorboards twisting, lockers collapsing inward as though gravity bent around it.

Kanvi screamed, but before the sound fully escaped, Akki moved. His tall frame swept her small body up in his arms again, spinning to shield her as shards of broken memory flew past. He hit the floor hard on one knee, his grip unyielding around her waist.

Her arms looped desperately around his neck, clutching him like he was the only anchor left in the universe. "Akki—don't let go!"

His sharp jaw was set like stone, his breath hot and ragged. "I told you. I never will."

The shadow's claws scraped across the wall, slicing through lockers like butter. Sparks exploded, and with them, voices of their childhood echoed—Kanvi's laughter, Akki's teasing, overlapping and corrupted.

Kanvi's tears blurred her vision. She buried her face into his chest, her muffled voice breaking: "It's feeding on us. On our memories."

Akki shifted her tighter against him, one hand gripping her thigh to keep her secure in his arms, the other reaching instinctively for the nearest console. His tall frame trembled, not with fear—but with fury.

"No one," he snarled, sharp eyes blazing into the distortion, "touches what's mine."

The shadow struck again—its claws slicing down toward them. Akki twisted, his broad shoulders taking the hit as sparks ripped across his coat. Kanvi cried out, her tiny hands pressing against the wound that burned through fabric.

"Akki! You're bleeding—"

His hand shot up, cupping her face, forcing her wide, tear-streaked eyes to lock with his sharp, unflinching gaze. "Look at me, Kanvi. Not the wound. Not the monster. Just me."

Her breath stuttered, chest rising fast against his. "But if I lose you—"

"You won't." His forehead pressed hard against hers, their lips only a breath apart. The air between them vibrated with unspoken words, unbearable tension. "Because I'd rather let this reality collapse than let you slip away."

Her lips parted, trembling, almost brushing his—

The shadow roared.

Their almost-kiss was torn apart by the sound of shattering glass. Kanvi's diary ripped itself from the ground, pages tearing free and circling above them like a storm. Each page bled new words in black ink, dripping like fresh wounds.

One line burned brighter than all:

"One of you will wake. The other will not."

Kanvi froze, her entire body trembling violently in Akki's arms. Her voice was a broken whisper: "No… no, it can't mean—"

Akki's sharp eyes snapped to the words, jaw clenched. His grip on her small form was iron, his voice molten steel.

"Then we'll prove it wrong."

The corridor shattered around them, the shadow's distorted laughter filling the void.

"Promises bind. But signals betray."

The world collapsed into blackness.

And in the dark, only the sound of their two heartbeats remained—beating in sync, louder than the void, louder than the shadow.

XII.
Threads Across Time

The Aftermath of Blackout

Silence.

A silence so heavy it pressed against Kanvi's chest like an extra heartbeat. For a long moment, she thought she was floating in endless blackness, weightless, disembodied.

Then she felt it—the cold bite of metal against her temple. Straps across her hairline. Wires running down her arms like veins of light.

Her lashes fluttered open.

The lab was there… and not there. The white panels of the walls were cracked with faint glows, as though light itself had been threaded through them. Machines flickered in and out of focus, humming softly like they were breathing.

Kanvi realized she was seated in a reclined chair, her small wrists fastened lightly with sensor cuffs. An EEG cap clung to her head, each node glowing faint blue. Her diary rested on her lap, strangely untouched, though its pages fluttered as if caught in a non-existent breeze.

Her throat was dry. "Akki…?"

A silhouette moved.

Tall, lean, sharp. Akki stood across from her, his coat torn at the shoulder where the shadow had clawed him, the fabric still singed at the edges. His sharp eyes glowed faintly in the fractured light, locked onto the monitors lining the wall.

He didn't turn immediately. His hands moved rapidly across a console, reconnecting wires, recalibrating signals. The screens pulsed with waveforms—lines of light that didn't look like ordinary EEG graphs. They pulsed, twined, and looped into one another, weaving like threads across time itself.

Finally, he glanced back at her.

"You're awake."

His voice was hoarse, deeper than usual, but steady.

Kanvi swallowed, her small hand instinctively clutching her diary against her chest. "What… What happened? Where are we now?"

Akki stepped closer, crouching beside her. His tall frame bent low, his face inches from hers as his fingers brushed over the EEG nodes at her temple, checking connections. His touch was clinical, precise—yet there was a gentleness there that made her heart stutter.

"We blacked out," he said quietly. "But this…" He nodded at the monitors. "…this isn't normal REM. Not even delta. It's something else. Something beyond dreaming."

Kanvi's brows knit. "Then what is it?"

His sharp eyes held hers, unwavering. "Our brains aren't just dreaming, Kanvi. They're communicating. Directly. Without words."

Her breath caught.

Communicating? The thought sent a shiver through her. She shifted slightly in the chair, her petite figure dwarfed by the wires snaking around her. "You mean… my mind and yours?"

He gave a single nod. "Entangled. Like quantum particles. Whatever you feel, I sense. Whatever I think, you glimpse. It's no longer two systems—it's one."

Her lips parted, the weight of his words sinking into her chest. She pressed her small hand against her heart unconsciously. "Then… there's no boundary anymore."

For the first time, his expression softened, the corners of his sharp mouth tugging into something dangerously close to a smile. He leaned in closer, his voice a low murmur.

"No. There's only us."

Her pulse hammered so violently she thought the EEG nodes might record it. She wanted to look away, to hide the heat rushing into her face—but his sharp eyes pinned her there, unflinching, unwavering.

She whispered, trembling, "That means… you can see my thoughts too?"

His hand lingered near her cheek, not quite touching, but close enough that the warmth of his skin brushed hers. His smirk was faint, but it made her chest tighten unbearably.

"I don't need to see them," he murmured. "I already know."

Kanvi's throat went dry. She clutched her diary tighter, but she couldn't tear her gaze from him.

And then—one of the monitors spiked violently, the waveforms twisting, flaring bright.

Both of them flinched.

Kanvi gasped, her small body jerking against the straps. "What was that?"

Akki rose quickly, his tall frame looming over the console, his hands flying across keys. His sharp jaw was set, his tone clinical again. "A resonance spike. Our heartbeats just align… and the system can't handle it."

Kanvi's lips trembled. She looked down, realizing her chest was rising in sync with his, even across the room. Every breath, every flutter of her pulse—mirrored.

Her whisper was barely audible, but the monitors seemed to capture it all the same.

"…Then we really are one."

Quantum Entanglement

The hum of the machines deepened. Lights blinked erratically across the EEG module, casting pale shadows across the lab walls.

Akki moved quickly, pulling another unit from the table—a smaller, sleeker device, one of his own prototypes. Wires coiled around his tall fingers as he connected the module to her EEG cap, then strapped the other half onto himself.

Kanvi's eyes widened, her petite form shifting nervously in the chair. "You're linking us both?"

"Yes." His voice was clipped, determined. He met her gaze briefly, sharp eyes glowing in the fractured light. "If this bond exists, I need to measure it. To prove it."

Her lips parted, trembling. "And if you prove it's real?"

He hesitated, just for a breath. Then leaned closer, his tall frame towering over her, voice low. "Then I'll never let it break."

The device whirred. Lines appeared across the monitor—two separate waveforms, hers delicate and quick, his sharper and steadier.

At first they moved independently. Then, slowly, as though drawn by invisible threads, the lines began to converge.

Kanvi stared, her small hand clutching her diary against her chest. "They're… syncing."

Akki didn't look away from the screen. His jaw flexed, his voice hushed. "No. They're colliding. Fighting for dominance."

The waves struck each other, sparks of light bursting where they met. The machine spat static, the resonance climbing higher.

And with every spark, Kanvi felt something inside her chest—a tug, a pull. Her thoughts blurred, tangled with his. She gasped suddenly, her petite frame jolting as an image flashed in her head:

Akki at twelve, alone in his room, sketching designs with trembling fingers, muttering under his breath: "If Kanvi sees this, she'll laugh…"

Kanvi's breath caught. Her lips trembled. "I… I saw you. Younger. Scared I'd laugh at your circuits."

Akki's head snapped toward her, sharp eyes narrowing. He hadn't spoken a word.

But then his gaze softened, realization dawning. "So it's true. You're inside my head."

Kanvi's cheeks burned. Her small frame trembled as another wave surged—this time she felt her own younger self scribbling in her diary: "Akki is always taller. Always watching. Why does my heart race when he looks at me?"

Her face crumpled in shame. "No… no, not that—"

But Akki's eyes widened, then narrowed, locking on her with a sharp intensity that made her whole body shiver.

"You wrote that about me." His voice was low, unreadable.

Kanvi looked away, her lashes wet. "Stop it… stop looking at me like that—"

But he stepped closer, closing the gap between them, his tall frame leaning down until his breath brushed her ear. "Then don't hide it."

Her heart slammed against her ribs. She gripped her diary so tightly her knuckles turned white.

The monitor shrieked, waveforms colliding violently. Sparks showered from the console, lighting the air with blue fire.

Kanvi cried out, her petite body flinching—until Akki's hand shot out, gripping her small wrist firmly, grounding her. His large hand engulfed hers, steady, unyielding.

"Focus on me," he ordered, his voice sharp, commanding.

Her lips quivered. "I… I can't—"

"Yes, you can." His sharp eyes bore into hers, refusing to let her look away. "Breathe with me."

He inhaled deeply. Instinctively, she matched him. Their chests rose in unison, breaths syncing.

The waveforms aligned perfectly. For a heartbeat, the resonance steadied—two lines moving as one.

The monitor exploded in light.

Kanvi's whole body shivered. Her eyes locked onto his, wide and shimmering, her lips parted as if she might say something—but words never came.

Because in that instant, she realized the truth.

Her heart wasn't just hers anymore.

It was his.

Shared Memories

The lab dissolved.

The monitors, the chairs, even the floor itself bent and cracked like glass, shattering into fragments of light. Kanvi gasped, clutching Akki's hand as the world around them shifted.

When the brightness faded, she found herself standing in a hallway she knew all too well. The faint smell of chalk dust. Posters peeling on the walls. The rhythmic thump of a basketball echoing from somewhere far away.

Her lips trembled. "This… this is our school."

She turned, stunned.

Lockers lined the walls, some scratched with old names and doodles. The air was warm with the faint perfume of freshly sharpened pencils and cheap cafeteria food.

And there, at the end of the hall—two younger figures stood.

Her breath caught. It was them.

A smaller version of herself, hair neatly braided, clutching her diary close to her chest, standing nervously by a science project board. And beside her—a younger Akki, taller even then, his sharp grin boyish but confident, fiddling with wires and speaking animatedly to a group of judges.

Kanvi pressed her small hand to her mouth. "That's us… the science fair."

The younger Kanvi turned slightly, whispering something to her diary. The words drifted through the air, soft but unmistakable: "If I smile enough, maybe Akki won't notice how badly my hands are shaking."

The older Kanvi's cheeks burned with shame. "No—stop, I don't want him to hear that—"

But Akki was already watching, his sharp eyes fixed on the memory, then on her.

“You were scared that day,” he said softly. His tall frame leaned closer, his breath brushing her temple. “But I noticed. I always noticed.”

Her eyes filled, tears slipping down her cheeks. She whispered, “You never said…”

“I didn’t need to.” His hand tightened around hers, grounding her. “I carried you in every project, Kanvi. You carried me through every thought.”

Suddenly, the memory warped.

The younger Kanvi blurred into an older version—college years, walking alone down the same hallway, diary clutched tighter, tears streaking her face.

Behind her, a taller Akki stood motionless, shadows hiding his expression. His hand was outstretched—but she never turned back.

Kanvi’s body went rigid. She stumbled, clutching her chest. “No… no, this isn’t real—it hasn’t happened yet—”

Her knees buckled. She would have fallen if Akki hadn’t caught her, sweeping her small frame into his arms once more.

Her cheek pressed to his chest, his heartbeat pounding against her ear.

“Don’t look at it,” he ordered, his sharp voice firm, almost desperate. “It’s not fixed. The future isn’t written.”

Her tears soaked his coat. “But what if I really do leave you?”

His arms crushed her tighter against him, his sharp jaw brushing her hair. “Then I’ll rewrite every law of time until you don’t.”

Kanvi sobbed softly, her small fists clutching his shirt. For a fleeting moment, the terrifying memory faded, and all she felt was the heat of his embrace, the way his tall frame curved protectively around hers.

And in the air, the whisper of her younger voice lingered, like an echo from the past:
“Akki, you’ll always be taller than me.”

The Near-Kiss and the Warning

The memory corridor trembled like it was alive. Lockers rattled, lights flickered. Papers tore free from Kanvi’s diary, scattering into the air, glowing with ink that hadn’t been written yet.

Akki's arms tightened around her small frame, his tall silhouette shielding her from the chaos. His sharp eyes darted across the collapsing hallway, then down to her trembling face.

"Kanvi." His voice was low, firm. "Look at me. Not the walls. Not the future. Just me."

Her lashes lifted, wet and heavy, until her eyes met his. The world blurred away.

The machine's resonance surged, a violent hum filling the air. Their heartbeats spiked in perfect sync, monitors glowing brighter and brighter.

Kanvi gasped, clutching his coat. "It's happening again—the waves—"

"Let them." His jaw clenched, his voice steady. "If we're connected through every signal, then I'll use it to keep you close."

Her lips trembled, her voice barely a whisper. "And if the signal… kills one of us?"

His sharp eyes burned into hers. He leaned down, lowering his forehead to hers until their breaths collided.

"Then I'll choose death with you over life without you."

Her chest tightened painfully. Her small hands slid up, curling around his collar, pulling him closer. Their lips hovered a breath apart—soft, trembling, inevitable.

The hum of the machines blurred into nothing. All she felt was his warmth, his heartbeat thundering in her ear, his breath hot against her lips.

She whispered, "Akki…"

He breathed her name like a vow. "Kanvi…"

Their lips brushed—

The diary burst open between them, slamming against the floor with a force that echoed like thunder. Pages ripped free, glowing with molten ink.

Words scrawled themselves furiously across the air, jagged and blazing:

"The first kiss seals the signal. One survives. One fades."

Kanvi froze, her entire body shaking. Her breath shattered into sobs. "No… no, it can't mean—"

Akki's sharp eyes narrowed dangerously at the burning words. His hand slid to her cheek, forcing her teary gaze back to his.

"Then it's lying."

"But what if it's not?" she whispered, broken.

His voice dropped, low and rough, his forehead pressing harder against hers. "Then I'll prove fate wrong."

For a heartbeat, the air between them pulsed—love, fear, defiance, all tangled into one unbearable tension.

Her lips trembled against his. She wanted to close the distance, to steal the kiss despite the warning. But the words burned brighter, casting long shadows around them, forcing her to freeze in terror.

Akki's arms wrapped tighter around her, his tall frame trembling with the force of holding back.

"I won't lose you," he murmured. "Not to the shadows. Not to time. Not to some cursed prophecy."

Her tears slid silently down her cheeks.

And still, their lips lingered a breath apart, trapped in a promise that the universe itself seemed desperate to break.

Quantum Fracture

The lab lights dimmed to a sickly red glow, as though the entire building had become a dying heart. Every monitor screamed with jagged waveforms, their once-synchronized pulses now thrashing violently apart.

Kanvi's small fingers clawed desperately at Akki's coat. Her voice broke, trembling:
"Akki… something's wrong. I can feel it tearing inside me—"

His tall frame bent over her, shielding her trembling body. His sharp jaw was clenched, his eyes darting across the collapsing graphs. Sparks flew from the EEG module, the smell of burning plastic filling the air.

"It's the resonance," he growled, his voice harsh but steady. "Our connection's overloading the system. It's not meant for this much energy."

Her lashes fluttered, her lips pale. "Energy… or love?"

The question hit him harder than the alarms. For a second, his breath faltered, his sharp eyes softening—before another violent pulse shook the lab.

The walls split open.

Reality peeled back like cracked glass, revealing an infinite corridor of glowing waveforms suspended in darkness. The lines pulsed like veins of light, stretching endlessly, intertwining like living arteries.

Kanvi gasped weakly, her small hand lifting as though to touch one of the threads. “Akki… they’re memories.”

He followed her gaze, sharp eyes narrowing. Each waveform flashed images—

Their first school fair.

Her secret diary entries, ink glowing.

His lonely sketches by lamplight.

Their laughter under the school tree.

And then—shards of futures that hadn’t yet come: Kanvi walking away, Akki’s tall frame left in ruins.

Her breath hitched, her chest heaving. “It’s showing us everything… even what hasn’t happened yet.”

The air vibrated with static. From the dark end of the corridor, the shadowed figure emerged, its voice fractured into a thousand echoes.

“The bond is stronger than time. But time demands its price.”

Its claws reached for the waveforms. One by one, threads snapped, unraveling into nothingness.

Kanvi’s scream tore through the air. Her small body convulsed in Akki’s arms.

The monitor to their left blinked violently—

KANVI — SIGNAL LOSS

Her pulse flatlined on the screen.

“NO!” Akki’s roar shook the corridor. He lowered her onto his lap, cupping her face with both hands, his sharp voice cracking. “Kanvi, open your eyes. Don’t you dare leave me!”

Her lashes stilled, lips parting soundlessly.

Akki pressed his forehead against hers, desperation burning through him. “You hear me? You don’t get to fade. If fate says one survives, then I’ll destroy fate itself!”

The shadow laughed, a distorted mockery.
“One survives. One fades.”

Akki’s teeth clenched. His grip on her small frame tightened until she felt like a part of him.

“You don’t understand,” he hissed at the darkness. “She is me.”

His lips brushed her temple, trembling, almost a prayer. “Come back, Kanvi. Please…”

Then—
A spark.
The waveform that had flatlined jolted. A faint pulse crawled across the screen.

Kanvi gasped violently, air flooding back into her chest. Her small hands shot up, clutching his coat with surprising force. Her eyes fluttered open, wide and shimmering.

“Akki…” she whispered, voice cracking. “I thought—I thought you were gone.”

He crushed her against him, his tall frame trembling with raw relief. His sharp voice broke into a vow: “Never. You’ll never lose me. Not in this life. Not in any.”

But the relief was short-lived.

The monitors glowed blood-red, scrawling new words across the corridor of waveforms:

QUANTUM PATTERN LOCKED.
TIME INTERFERENCE INITIATED.

The entire corridor split apart, fragments of light spiraling away into a void. The shadow’s laughter echoed louder than ever.

Akki’s grip on Kanvi tightened. He lifted her fully into his arms as the ground vanished beneath them.

“Hold on to me,” he ordered, sharp voice fierce.

Her small arms locked around his neck, her lips trembling against his ear. “I’ll never let go.”

And together, they fell—into the darkness between time.

XIII.
A Meeting In Shadows

Into the Dream Corridor

Darkness stretched endless, smooth as silk.

Kanvi's lashes fluttered open. She was standing barefoot on a floor that wasn't solid—more like glass suspended in the night sky. Beneath her feet, galaxies shimmered faintly, stars pulsing in rhythm with her heartbeat.

Her breath trembled. "This… this isn't real."

A voice cut through the silence. Familiar. Deep.

"Then how do you explain it to me?"

Her head snapped up.

There he was.

Akki. Tall, broad-shouldered, sharp eyes glowing faint silver in the dreamlight. His coat rippled behind him though there was no wind. For a second, Kanvi's chest clenched so hard she thought she'd fall apart.

"Akki…"

He raised an eyebrow, a half-smile tugging at his mouth. "What, you expected someone else in your dreams?"

Her cheeks flushed instantly. "Shut up."

He stepped closer, each stride confident, deliberate. The glass beneath him glowed with each step, as if the dream itself acknowledged him.

Kanvi stumbled back slightly, clutching her diary against her chest out of instinct—even though she hadn't brought it here.

"How… how are you here?" she whispered.

His sharp gaze softened, though his smirk lingered. "I should ask the same. But I think we already know the answer, don't we? The link. It doesn't stop when we're awake."

Kanvi's throat tightened. She hated how much she wanted that to be true.

He came to stand just before her. His tall frame cast a shadow across her small figure, his presence overwhelming in the silent corridor of stars.

She whispered, trembling, "So this is… a conscious dream."

His hand lifted—hovering near her cheek, fingers not quite touching. "No, Kanvi. This is our dream."

Her pulse skipped violently. For a moment, all she could do was stare up into his silver-lit eyes, caught between awe and panic.

Then she blurted the only thing her brain could form:

"…You look taller here."

Akki blinked, then actually laughed—a low, rough chuckle that made her heart flip. "Kanvi, I've always been taller."

Her face burned. She shoved his chest lightly, her petite hand against the solid warmth of him. "Don't you dare laugh at me in a dream."

His smirk widened as he leaned down, his sharp jaw brushing close to her ear. "If I can't laugh here, then where else?"

Her knees almost buckled. She clutched her diary tighter, muttering, "I hate you."

But her voice shook, and he heard it.

His reply was a whisper, deadly soft: "Liar."

Shadows at the Edges

The dream corridor stretched on endlessly, galaxies shimmering beneath the glass floor. At first, Kanvi thought it was beautiful, almost serene. But then—

She saw them.

Figures.

At the very edge of vision, shadowed silhouettes stirred. They didn't move like people—more like smoke caught in the shape of bodies, twitching, stretching, never whole.

Kanvi froze, her small hand instinctively gripping Akki's sleeve. "Akki… do you see them?"

He turned his sharp eyes toward the shifting haze. His jaw tightened. "Yes. And they see us."

Her breath quickened. "What are they?"

His tall frame angled protectively in front of her. "Not memories. Not dreams. Something else. Parasites feeding on the resonance."

The shadows rippled closer, silent, formless.

Kanvi's grip tightened on his coat. "I don't like this… I want to wake up."

He glanced down at her, a sharp smirk tugging at his mouth despite the danger. "You think I'm letting you wake up without me?"

Her cheeks flushed. "Why do you sound like you're enjoying this?"

"Because," he murmured, leaning just close enough that his breath brushed her ear, "you cling to me more when you're scared."

Her face went crimson. She shoved him lightly in the ribs. "Idiot!"

But she didn't let go.

He chuckled low, the sound rich even in this shadowed place. "That's what I thought."

Kanvi pouted, glaring up at him with wide eyes. "One day I'll stop clinging."

Akki's sharp gaze held hers, steady and unwavering. "One day I'll stop letting you go."

Her heart stumbled so hard she nearly forgot about the shadows.

The figures pressed closer now, their edges bleeding into the floor. The dream corridor flickered, stars dimming. One shadow stretched a claw-like arm across the glass, the surface cracking under its touch.

Kanvi whimpered, burying her face into Akki's chest without thinking. "They're breaking it!"

He wrapped his arms around her small frame in one swift movement, his tall body curving protectively. His sharp voice cut through the hiss of the shadows:

"Let them try. They'll never touch you."

Her lashes fluttered against his coat, her voice muffled. "You sound too sure."

His lips curved faintly against her hair. "Because you're mine here."

The shadows hissed, recoiling as if the words themselves had burned them. The corridor steadied, though cracks lingered across the glass floor.

Kanvi peeked up, wide-eyed. "Did… did you just scare them away?"

Akki smirked, his sharp eyes glinting. "No. You did. They hate your fear, but they hate your faith even more."

Her lips parted, trembling. “Faith… in you?”

He leaned down, forehead almost touching hers, whispering, “Exactly.”

School Echoes with a Twist

The shadows thinned, dissolving into mist. The galaxy-floor beneath them flickered, and in an instant the corridor bent into shape—

A classroom.

Wooden desks, half-broken chalkboards, sunlight filtering through dusty windows. The faint smell of old ink and chalk dust filled the air.

Kanvi blinked, stunned. “This is… our school.”

She turned slowly, her small frame spinning in awe. The posters on the walls were the same as years ago. She could even hear the faint chatter of students in the courtyard outside.

Akki stood beside her, taller than every desk, his sharp eyes scanning the dream with a faint smirk. “Looks exactly like it did when we were fifteen.”

Kanvi’s cheeks warmed as memories crashed back. Sitting in the front row, writing furiously in her diary, pretending not to notice the tall boy at the back who never stopped watching her.

She muttered, “I hated this classroom.”

Akki arched his brow, his voice teasing. “Really? Or did you just hate that I always beat you in math?”

Her face went crimson. “I didn’t hate that—” She cut herself off, glaring at him. “And you didn’t always beat me.”

He chuckled low, stepping closer, his tall frame crowding her. “Oh? Should I pull up the dream report card to remind you?”

Her small hand shot out, smacking his arm lightly. “Shut up, Akki!”

But even as she pouted, her lips twitched into a smile. The dream made everything sharper—the warmth of his laugh, the depth of his gaze.

Akki leaned down suddenly, his sharp jaw brushing close to her ear. “You’re cuter when you’re mad, you know that?”

Her entire body went hot. She shoved him harder this time, stumbling back into one of the old desks. "You can't just say things like that!"

"Why not?" he murmured, stepping closer, his hand braced on the desk beside her, boxing her in. "It's a dream. No rules."

Her breath caught. His nearness, his heat, the way his sharp eyes burned into hers—it all made the classroom walls feel too small.

She clutched her diary against her chest, voice trembling. "Akki… what if we're not supposed to be here?"

His smirk faded slightly, replaced by a sharp focus. He tilted his head, studying her. "What do you mean?"

She lowered her eyes. "What if this dream isn't just… us remembering? What if someone put us here?"

As if in answer, the blackboard screeched. Chalk began to scrawl across it by itself, jagged and uneven:

"Every meeting in the shadows has a cost."

Kanvi's heart lurched. She grabbed Akki's sleeve, trembling. "See? I told you…"

Akki's jaw clenched, but his arm slipped around her small waist, steadying her. "Then let them write what they want. I'll rewrite it myself."

Her chest tightened painfully at his words.

And yet—the blackboard kept writing, slower this time, like a warning etched deep:

"You can't keep her forever."

The Romantic Confession Half-Done

The blackboard's chalk scratches faded, but the words still echoed in the air like a curse:

"You can't keep her forever."

Kanvi's small frame trembled against Akki's side. She hated how cold her fingers felt even in the warmth of his coat. She hated how true the words sounded.

Akki's sharp eyes stayed locked on the board for a long second, jaw flexing. Then, slowly, he turned back to her.

"Kanvi."

Her lashes fluttered. She looked up, wide-eyed, lips parting.

His voice dropped low, rough, trembling with something he almost never let show. "I don't care what this dream says. I don't care what time or shadows say. You're mine."

Her breath caught.

The room felt too small, the silence too loud. Her heart slammed so hard it hurt.

Her diary slipped from her hands, falling open on the desk behind her, forgotten.

"Akki…" she whispered, voice breaking.

He leaned closer, his tall frame caging her in completely, both hands braced against the desk. His sharp jaw hovered just inches away, his breath warm against her lips.

"Say it," he whispered, eyes burning into hers. "Just once. Tell me you're mine too."

Her knees went weak. She clutched his shirt desperately, her lips trembling.

"I…"

The classroom walls flickered. The desks warped, melting into shadows. The floor cracked, glowing red like fire underneath.

Kanvi gasped, clinging harder. "Akki—it's breaking again—"

"I don't care!" he snarled, pulling her close, his forehead pressing to hers. His voice shook. "Say it, Kanvi. Say it before it takes you away."

Tears spilled from her lashes. Her small voice broke out in a sob, "I am! I'm yours, Akki—I always was!"

For one endless second, their lips hovered, brushing faintly, hearts syncing in a way no machine could measure.

Then—

The dream shattered.

The chalkboard exploded in sparks, the diary pages scattering into glowing fragments. A violent force ripped through the classroom, dragging Kanvi back.

Her scream tore through the collapsing room. “Akki!”

He lunged forward, grabbing her wrist, his large hand locking around her small one. His sharp voice roared through the chaos:

“I’ve got you! I’ll never let go!”

But the shadows swirled between them, their grip like ice. The connection flickered, her face slipping further into the dark.

Her last words echoed faint, broken:

“…Don’t let the dream steal me.”

The Shadow’s Warning

The classroom shattered completely.

Desks splintered into ash, the blackboard crumbled, and the walls folded inward like paper caught in fire. Kanvi’s scream echoed through the collapsing void as Akki clung desperately to her hand.

The shadows swarmed.

Dozens of them, their faceless bodies stretching into twisted shapes, voices whispering in unison:

“Every meeting in the shadows has a cost.”

Akki’s grip on her small hand tightened until his knuckles turned white. His tall frame braced against the storm, his sharp eyes blazing with fury. “You can take the world, take time, take my life—but you don’t touch her.”

The shadows hissed, recoiling as though the force of his words carried weight. Yet one stepped forward, taller than the rest, its body pulsing like a wound in the air.

Its voice came in jagged fragments:

“The bond is too strong. The dream will claim balance.”

Kanvi's lashes fluttered, tears streaming down her cheeks. She pressed her small body closer against Akki's side, whispering brokenly, "What do they mean? Balance?"

Akki's sharp jaw clenched. He held her tighter, his coat wrapping around her like a shield. "They mean lies. Nothing else."

The shadow bent closer, hollow face inches from theirs. Its words came like venom.

"One dreamer will anchor. One dreamer will fade."

Kanvi sobbed, clutching Akki's shirt. "No—no, I don't want this. Not if it means losing you."

Akki tilted her chin up, forcing her to look into his eyes even as the world trembled. His voice was rough but steady.

"You hear me, Kanvi? I don't care what they say. You're not fading. Not now, not ever."

For a second, it felt like his certainty alone could keep the shadows at bay. Their grip loosened, the storm slowed.

And then—the diary pages scattered through the void lit up like fireflies. Words burned across them, glowing:

"The next layer awaits. Deeper. Darker. Inescapable."

The shadows surged forward in one violent wave, wrapping around both of them. Kanvi screamed, her small arms clutching Akki's neck. He wrapped his arms around her waist, crushing her against him as the darkness swallowed them.

"Stay with me!" he roared. "No matter what they show you—stay with me!"

Her voice was muffled against his chest, broken but fierce. "Always!"

And then—

The floor vanished.

The two of them plunged downward, deeper into the dream, their bodies locked together as though their clasped hands alone could defy eternity.

The last thing they heard before the darkness swallowed everything was the whisper of the shadow:

"You chose this meeting. Now pay the cost."

XIV.
Experiment Of The Mind

Awakening in the Labyrinth

The fall felt endless.

Kanvi's small frame clung desperately to Akki's chest, her scream swallowed by the dark. His tall figure shielded her as they tumbled, his sharp eyes locked shut against the roaring void.

Then—sudden stillness.

They landed not on ground, but on something soft and shifting—like a floor made of whispers.

Kanvi opened her eyes slowly. Her lashes trembled. Around them, corridors stretched in impossible directions—walls pulsing like living lungs, doorways opening and closing on their own.

She gasped, clutching his shirt. "Akki… this isn't like before. It feels… alive."

His jaw clenched, his sharp gaze scanning the space. "Because it is. This isn't a memory. It's a construct."

Her small hands tightened on him. "Construct?"

He nodded grimly. "A dream layer we're not supposed to reach."

The corridor's walls glowed faintly with veins of light. Each pulse echoed their own heartbeats, faster when they touched.

Kanvi swallowed nervously. "If this place wasn't meant for us… then why are we here?"

His tall frame leaned closer, his hand sliding to the small of her back. "Because the signal pulled us deeper. The only way out now… is to map this."

"Map?" she echoed, wide-eyed.

He smirked faintly despite the tension. "Dream cartography. Something I've always theorized, but never tested."

Her cheeks warmed. Even in this nightmare, he sounded like the same boy who once stayed late after class, scribbling equations in his notebook while secretly watching her.

"You're insane," she whispered, voice shaking.

His lips brushed her ear as he murmured, "Maybe. But you'll thank me when we survive."

Her breath hitched. She pressed closer against him, whispering, "Just don't leave me in this… labyrinth."

He glanced down, eyes fierce. "I never have. I never will."

Building the Dream Map

Akki moved with a sharp precision, the kind that Kanvi had seen a thousand times back in school when he solved problems others couldn't even begin to understand. His tall frame lowered to the strange breathing floor, hands sketching patterns that glowed into existence the moment he thought them.

Lines of light spiraled outward, forming circles, grids, waveforms. The dream itself responded to him, shaping into equations only he could command.

Kanvi stared, her lips parting. "You're… building something."

His smirk flickered, sharp and confident. "A map. If this dream is alive, we need to know its boundaries. Its laws."

Her small hand lifted instinctively, tracing one of the glowing lines. The light shivered under her touch, humming like a living chord. "It feels warm," she whispered.

"Careful," he warned, his sharp eyes snapping to her. "This isn't just light. It's your own brainwaves feeding back."

Kanvi gasped, yanking her hand back. "So I could… hurt myself?"

He tilted his head, gaze softening. "Not if you stay close to me."

Her cheeks warmed. "You always say that."

"And you always listen," he countered, the corner of his mouth curving.

The glowing map spread wider until it hovered above them like a holographic dome. It pulsed faintly with two central orbs—one bright blue, one silver.

Kanvi pointed, her voice soft. "That's… us, isn't it?"

He nodded. "Your neural pattern. Mine. Bound together."

She stepped closer, her small frame brushing against his tall one as she stared at the floating lights. "They're… connected. Even here."

His sharp gaze softened on her. For a moment, the scientist's smirk faded, replaced by something rawer. "They always were."

Her breath trembled. She hugged her diary against her chest, whispering, "Don't say things like that…"

"Why not?" His hand brushed against hers, deliberate. "It's the truth."

Before she could respond, the map flickered violently.

At the far edge of the dome, one section warped. Instead of smooth glowing lines, it twisted into a dark knot, pulsing black-red.

Kanvi's heart lurched. "What is that?"

Akki's sharp jaw clenched. "An anomaly."

The knot pulsed again, shadows leaking from it like ink in water. The dome shivered, the floor beneath them rumbling faintly.

Kanvi grabbed his sleeve, eyes wide. "It's… watching us."

His gaze didn't leave the anomaly. "No. It's waiting for us."

The Anomaly Stirs

The knot pulsed again—harder. A deep thrum shook the labyrinth, as though the very dream had grown a heartbeat of its own.

Kanvi stumbled, clutching her chest. Her small frame swayed, knees buckling.

"Kanvi!" Akki lunged, catching her before she hit the living floor. He lowered her gently, cradling her against him, his tall body shielding her from the waves of black light.

Her eyes fluttered weakly. "I… I can't breathe. It feels like it's pulling me apart…"

He pressed his palm to her cheek, his sharp eyes blazing. "Stay with me. Don't you dare fade on me, Kanvi."

The anomaly pulsed again, and the dome-map above them fractured. One of the glowing lines linking their neural orbs snapped. Kanvi cried out, her body jerking.

Akki's teeth clenched, desperation cracking through his steady voice. "No. No, you don't get to leave me like this. Not here. Not ever."

Her lashes trembled. Her small hand lifted, trembling, brushing clumsily against his jaw. "Akki… don't look like that. You… you're scaring me."

He froze, his breath catching. Her touch was feather-light, but it cut through the storm.

"You're the scientist," she whispered faintly. "You always… fix everything. So fix me, too."

His sharp jaw quivered, his lips pressing against her knuckles with a ferocity he hadn't meant to show. "I will. I swear, Kanvi, I'll drag you back from any abyss they throw at us."

Her eyes softened despite the pain. "You always sound so sure."

"Because I am." His forehead pressed to hers, his voice breaking. "You're mine to protect."

For one trembling second, her lips parted as if to answer—when the anomaly screamed.

It wasn't sound.

It was a tearing inside their skulls, a distortion that bent the air around them. The black knot pulsed wider, vomiting shadows across the dome.

Kanvi gasped, clutching him tighter, her small voice breaking into panic. "Akki—it's pulling me—!"

He held her closer, his large hands gripping her waist as if anchoring her in place. His voice roared through the void:

"Then let it try. It'll never take you from me."

Confessions in the Dark

The scream of the anomaly didn't stop. It was as if the labyrinth itself was splitting open, every wall vibrating with a noise that wasn't sound but pain, raw and endless.

Akki's tall frame shielded Kanvi completely, his arms wrapped around her small body like chains. His sharp eyes darted between the flickering dome-map and the writhing shadows pouring from the knot.

Kanvi clung to him tighter, her face buried in his chest. Her voice was muffled, broken. "I can't… I can't fight it, Akki. It's too strong—"

He cupped her face suddenly, forcing her teary eyes up to his. His own voice cracked, low and furious. "Don't you dare say that. You've fought worse. You've fought me when I was impossible. You don't have to surrender now."

Her lips trembled. "You sound like you're trying to convince yourself."

His jaw clenched. For once, he had no comeback.

The anomaly pulsed again, shadows slamming against them like waves of black glass. Kanvi winced, her small frame trembling, and she buried her face deeper into his coat.

“Why does it always come to this?” she whispered. “Every time we find something real, it gets ripped away. Even here, even in dreams—”

Akki bent low, his forehead pressing hard against hers, his sharp breath ragged. “Then let them rip the dream. They’ll never rip us.”

Her eyes widened at the ferocity in his tone. Tears spilled freely now, running down her cheeks.

“Akki…” Her voice broke, and suddenly the words tumbled out, unguarded, raw. “I’m terrified of losing you. I’m terrified of waking up one day and finding you gone.”

He stilled.

Her small hands fisted into his shirt as if she could anchor herself. “And it hurts so much because I know I’ll never stop wanting you. Even if I pretend. Even if I try to run. You’re in me. Do you understand? You’re in me.”

For a second, time itself was still.

Akki’s sharp eyes burned into hers, a storm of disbelief and longing swirling inside him. His hands trembled as they framed her face, thumbs brushing away the wetness on her cheeks.

“Kanvi…” His voice was so low it was almost a growl. “Say it again.”

She swallowed hard, her voice barely audible. “You’re in me. Always.”

Something inside him snapped. He pulled her up against him, crushing her small frame to his chest. His lips hovered over hers, so close that her breath mingled with his.

“Do you even know what you do to me?” he whispered fiercely. “Do you know how many nights I’ve dreamt of this? Of you?”

Her lashes fluttered, her cheeks flaming even through the tears. “Then stop dreaming.”

He blinked, sharp eyes widening.

“Just… do it,” she whispered, her trembling lips parting, offering, pleading.

Their mouths were a hair’s breadth apart when the anomaly shrieked again.

The knot ripped wider, sucking air, light, and sound into its black spiral. The floor beneath them cracked like glass, pulling them closer to the void.

Kanvi cried out, clutching his neck. “Akki!”

He wrapped his arms around her waist, locking her against him with brutal strength. His voice roared against the storm: “I’ve got you! Look at me—only me!”

Her tearful gaze locked on his, her lips brushing his in the chaos. For one suspended heartbeat, the world fell silent.

And then—the shadows tore them apart.

The diary pages scattered through the void again, glowing violently. On every page, the same words burned:

“Every confession has its price.”

Kanvi’s scream split the collapsing dark as she slipped from his arms, dragged toward the anomaly.

Akki lunged, his tall frame reaching desperately, his hand locking around her small wrist. His sharp eyes blazed with rage and despair.

“You’re not leaving me!” he shouted, his voice breaking into something rawer than she had ever heard.

Her lips quivered, tears trailing down into the shadows. “Then don’t let go.”

His grip tightened, veins straining in his arm as the void sucked harder. His chest heaved, his entire body trembling with the effort.

“I’ll die first,” he whispered fiercely.

The Unknown Anomaly

The void howled.
Akki’s tall frame strained as if his very bones would snap, his hand locked desperately around Kanvi’s fragile wrist. Her small body dangled above the swirling black knot, pulled by a gravity that wasn’t real yet threatened to tear her apart.

Her tear-soaked face glistened in the flickering light. “Akki—if you hold on any tighter, you’ll break yourself!”

His sharp eyes blazed down at her, teeth clenched. “Then let me break. I don’t care, Kanvi. I don’t care if this dream shatters me a thousand times—I won’t let go of you.”

Her chest tightened painfully, a sob tearing out of her throat. “Why do you always say things like that right when I can’t take it anymore?”

“Because it’s true!” he shouted over the roar.

Suddenly, the knot pulsed, and the shadows withdrew slightly—like prey circling before a strike. The entire labyrinth quieted, an unnatural silence pressing against their ears.

Kanvi’s breath hitched. “It… it stopped?”

Akki pulled her up, crushing her into his arms, his tall frame shaking with the effort. He held her so tightly she could barely breathe, but she didn’t care. She clung back, burying her face in his coat.

Then—

A voice.

Not from the shadows. Not from the dream itself. Deeper. Older. It came like a vibration through their skulls, cold and resonant.

“You are not the only dreamers.”

Kanvi stiffened in his arms, her wide eyes shooting up to him. “Did… did you hear—?”

Akki’s sharp jaw locked, his gaze snapping back to the anomaly. The knot no longer pulsed aimlessly. It is in shape now. Structure.

From its swirling center, a figure began to emerge. Not smoke, not shadow—something crystalline, humanoid but fractured, like a mirror shattered and reassembled wrong. Its voice reverberated again, louder this time.

“This experiment is not yours alone.”

Akki shoved Kanvi behind him instinctively, his tall frame bracing, his sharp eyes narrowed into fury. “Who are you?”

The figure tilted its head, shards of its body clicking against each other. Its presence made the map-dome above them flicker and burn.

“The anomaly you seek is no anomaly. It is a doorway. And you…”

Its fractured gaze turned toward Kanvi.

“…are the key.”

Kanvi’s breath shattered. She stumbled back, her diary slipping from her grasp, pages scattering across the shifting floor. Her small voice quivered. “Why me? I’m not… I’m not special—”

Akki caught her wrist firmly, pulling her against his side. His voice was sharp steel. “Don’t you dare say that. Not to them. Not to anyone.”

The entity’s fractured smile widened, a crack running down its glass-like face.

“She carries what you cannot. The anchor. The sacrifice.”

Kanvi’s knees buckled. She gasped, clutching Akki’s sleeve. “Sacrifice?”

Akki’s entire body went rigid. His arm locked around her, his voice breaking into a snarl. “No. I don’t care what you call her. She’s not your key. She’s mine.”

The figure leaned forward, its shards grinding like stone.

“Then the experiment continues. Let us see how long you can defy the pattern.”

The labyrinth convulsed. The dome above shattered into thousands of shards, raining around them like glass. The crystalline figure dissolved back into the knot, and the floor beneath them cracked open into a spiral staircase of pure darkness.

Kanvi clung to him, trembling violently. “Akki… what if it’s right? What if I am the sacrifice?”

He tilted her face up, his sharp eyes blazing with unshakable defiance. His voice trembled but never broke.

“Then I’ll sacrifice everything else first.”

The shadows surged again, wrapping around them, dragging them down into the spiral. Their hands stayed locked, their bodies pressed tight together as the dream pulled them deeper than ever before.

The last thing Kanvi saw before the dark consumed them was the words burning on her diary’s scattered pages:

“THE EXPERIMENT HAS JUST BEGUN.”

XV.
Breaking The Code

The Spiral Descent

The world tilted, and the labyrinth dissolved into a spiral staircase of pure shadow. Each step was suspended in nothingness, twisting downward into infinity. The stairs weren't solid stone—they pulsed like veins, shifting beneath their feet with every heartbeat.

Kanvi stumbled, her small frame trembling as she clutched Akki's arm. Her wide eyes darted to the endless void yawning around them. "This… isn't real. It can't be real."

Akki's sharp gaze scanned the descent, his tall frame steady despite the shifting ground. "It's real enough to kill us if we fall."

Her fingers tightened around his sleeve. "Don't say things like that—"

He glanced down, smirking faintly despite the shadows pressing against them. "Would you rather I lie? Tell you this is just some nightmare and that we'll wake up holding hands in your hospital room?"

Her cheeks flushed crimson. She shoved his shoulder weakly. "You—! This isn't the time for—"

His hand slid down, capturing her smaller one in his larger grip, locking their palms together. His smirk softened into something fiercer, sharper. "It's always the time. Especially when you're scared."

The stairs shuddered, and black mist rose from the steps, curling around them like snakes. Kanvi gasped and pressed against his side. "It's moving—Akki, it's alive—"

He pulled her close, his tall frame wrapping around her smaller body as though shielding her from the mist itself. "Then let it. As long as you stay here—" His lips brushed her hair, his voice low. "—it can't touch you."

Her heart hammered. She clutched his shirt, whispering, "You sound so sure. But what if this… staircase leads to something worse?"

His sharp jaw tightened. "Then we break it."

Kanvi blinked. "Break what?"

"The code," he muttered, eyes narrowing. He motioned to the faint symbols glowing along the staircase edges—patterns like equations, shifting endlessly. "This place isn't just shadows. It's written. Structured. That means it can be rewritten."

Kanvi stared at him, stunned. "You're saying you can… hack the dream?"

He gave a small, dangerous smile. "Not hack. Reprogram."

Her lips parted in awe. "You're insane."

His hand squeezed hers, warm and certain. “Maybe. But you love me for it.”

Her cheeks burned. She looked away, hiding her face, muttering, “I didn’t say that—”

He leaned closer, his lips brushing her ear, his voice a dangerous whisper. “You didn’t have to.”

Her breath hitched sharply, her knees nearly buckling on the trembling stairs.

The spiral groaned beneath them, pulling them deeper.

The void around them whispered in distorted voices:

“One will fall. One will fade.”

Kanvi’s heart clenched. She pressed tighter against Akki, burying her face against his chest. “Promise me—no matter what this place does—you won’t let me go.”

His arms circled her waist, lifting her slightly as the stairs jolted violently. His sharp voice roared against the dark: “I swear, Kanvi. I’ll fight the code itself before I let it take you.”

And with that vow hanging in the air, they descended further, hand in hand, toward the heart of the shadows.

First Encounter

The spiral staircase ended without warning.
One moment they were stepping carefully across trembling veins of shadow—then the floor simply gave way into a vast chamber.

The chamber was a perfect circle. Its walls were not walls at all but endless black stone engraved with glowing codes—mathematical symbols, half-erased formulas, and words written in a language neither of them knew yet somehow understood. The ceiling stretched forever upward, pulsing faintly like the inside of a giant lung.

Kanvi clutched Akki’s sleeve tightly, her small body pressed into his side. Her wide eyes darted nervously across the endless codes as if they were watching her. “It feels… like the walls are alive.”

Akki’s sharp eyes narrowed, scanning the room. “They’re not alive. They’re instructions. This chamber is… the core.”

Her lashes fluttered. “The core of what?”

He tilted his head, smirking faintly despite the dread curling in his chest. “The dream’s operating system.”

Before she could respond, the chamber trembled. The symbols along the walls flickered, rearranging themselves into spirals and knots. From the center of the room, the shadows thickened, curling upward until they formed a towering figure—far taller than a man, its body made of pure blackness stitched together with the glowing codes from the walls.

Kanvi froze, her breath catching painfully. “Akki… it’s here.”

The figure leaned closer, its featureless face lowering until it hovered directly above them. Its voice came like broken glass dragged across stone:

“Two dreamers where there should be one.”

Kanvi whimpered, pressing closer to Akki’s chest. His tall frame braced around her, one arm holding her firmly, the other clenching into a fist.

“Then the system’s wrong,” Akki spat, his sharp jaw set. “Because she’s not going anywhere.”

The entity tilted its head. Its fractured body shuddered, and the codes on the walls lit brighter. Suddenly, the ground beneath Kanvi split, and a crack of pure light surged upward, tearing her out of Akki’s grasp.

She screamed as her small body was yanked away, her hand slipping from his.

“KANVI!” Akki’s roar shook the chamber.

He lunged, catching her wrist just before she vanished into the crack. His tall frame strained, veins bulging in his arm, his sharp eyes blazing with fury.

The entity hissed, its broken voice cutting through the chamber.

“Let go. She does not belong to you.”

Kanvi sobbed, clutching Akki’s hand with all her strength. Her nails dug into his skin. “Don’t you dare, Akki—don’t you dare let me go!”

Her terrified voice split something inside him. He pulled harder, dragging her small frame back into his arms. She slammed against his chest, and he crushed her close, his hand gripping the back of her head protectively.

“Did you hear that?” he snarled up at the shadow. “She belongs right here. With me.”

The entity shuddered, codes rippling across its body.

“Weakness. Attachment is corruption.”

Kanvi lifted her tear-streaked face from his chest, her voice trembling but fierce. “If loving him is corruption, then I’ll rot before I let you take me away.”

Akki froze for a second, staring down at her in stunned silence. His chest heaved. His sharp eyes softened, his jaw slackening at the raw defiance in her voice.

“…Kanvi…” His whisper trembled more than the chamber itself.

The entity hissed, louder now, and the symbols on the walls rearranged once more. This time, thousands of glowing tendrils shot forward from every side of the chamber, whipping like snakes. Each one tried to coil between them, wedge them apart, pry their hands free.

But Kanvi refused. Her small hands locked around his with such force her knuckles went white. “No matter what it throws at us—I’m not letting go, Akki. Not again. Never again.”

He grinned sharply despite the chaos, his voice dark and steady. “Good. Because neither am I.”

And with their grip unbreakable, the entity shrieked, the chamber pulsing violently as though it couldn’t comprehend their refusal.

Cracking the Symbols

The chamber shook violently, the codes on the walls shifting faster than their eyes could follow. Strange equations appeared and collapsed—formulas written half in mathematics, half in something beyond language.

Akki’s sharp gaze tracked them, his tall frame tense but his mind racing. “These… aren’t random. They’re instructions. Algorithms.”

Kanvi clung to his arm, her wide eyes darting across the glowing walls. “Algorithms for what?”

He smirked faintly despite the chaos. “For us.”

Her heart skipped. “You mean… Is it writing our choices?”

“Or rewriting them,” he muttered grimly.

A thousand glowing tendrils whipped from the entity, striking the floor, cracking the surface. Each strike sent shockwaves through their bodies. Kanvi stumbled, but Akki caught her quickly, his large hands steadying her waist. He bent low, his sharp breath brushing against her ear.

“Kanvi, listen. The only way out of this is to break its system. If I can decipher these codes—maybe rewrite them—we can destabilize it.”

She blinked rapidly, her tears mixing with determination. “Then do it. And I’ll help.”

He froze for a moment, staring at her. “Help? Kanvi, this isn’t like reading your medical textbooks. This is—”

“—our lives,” she cut in fiercely. “So stop treating me like I’m fragile. Tell me what to do.”

For once, Akki was speechless. Then his lips curved into a raw, proud grin. “God, I love when you argue with me at the worst possible time.”

Her cheeks burned crimson. “I didn’t mean—!”

He leaned closer, his sharp eyes gleaming. “You don’t have to say it. Just stay right here.”

He pulled a small device from his coat pocket—his portable neural analyzer. It shimmered unnaturally in the dream, its edges bending like liquid. He pressed it against Kanvi’s temple gently.

She gasped, her lashes fluttering. “What are you—?”

“Your brainwaves,” he murmured, his hand brushing her hair aside. “They’re syncing with mine. If I can map them against the codes on the wall—”

Her breath hitched at the intimacy of his touch, his fingers lingering near her cheek. “Then?”

He smirked faintly. “Then we hack God.”

The analyzer flickered to life, projecting waveforms of her mind into the air. They pulsed faintly, matching the beat of her racing heart. Akki’s own neural pattern appeared beside it, jagged and sharp, yet moving in sync with hers.

Kanvi’s chest tightened. Seeing their minds side by side—two patterns overlapping, fusing—it felt almost more intimate than touch. She whispered, trembling, “We… we fit.”

Akki’s sharp jaw flexed, his eyes locked on hers. “We always did.”

Her cheeks burned hotter, but before she could respond, the entity shrieked. The codes flared red, and the waveforms rippled violently.

Akki cursed under his breath, pulling her tighter against him. “Kanvi, I need you steady. Whatever happens—focus on me.”

Her small hand slid up, cupping his jaw, her thumb brushing his cheek. “Always.”

The chamber shook again, shadows raining down like black glass. Akki's tall frame hunched protectively over her as his device glowed brighter, rewriting lines across the walls.

Symbols fractured. Formulas reversed.

Kanvi gasped, watching in awe. "You're changing it."

He smirked darkly, his eyes blazing. "No. We're changing it."

The entity roared, its form fracturing, but its voice echoed through the chamber like a curse:

"Love is the code you cannot break."

Kanvi froze, her heart lurching violently at the words.

Akki's sharp gaze flicked to her, a storm in his eyes. "Then let's prove it wrong."

The Heart Confession Amid Chaos

The chamber convulsed.
The walls of shifting equations split into jagged cracks, each line of code screaming as if it were alive. From every crack poured the entity's tendrils—thousands this time, lashing like whips.

One struck the floor at Kanvi's feet. The ground beneath her opened, pulling her down toward a swirling pit of darkness.

She screamed, her small frame tumbling backward. "Akki—!"

Before her voice even faded, he was there. His tall frame lunged forward, arms wrapping around her waist, hauling her against his chest with brutal force. His sharp eyes blazed, his jaw tight with fury.

"Not again," he snarled, holding her so tightly she gasped. "I told you—I'll never let it take you."

The pit closed, but the shadows hissed, curling higher around them. One tendril wrapped around Kanvi's ankle, yanking hard. She cried out, clutching his shirt.

"Akki—it's pulling me—!"

His grip only tightened, his knuckles white as he crushed her to him. "Then it'll have to drag me too."

The shadows pulled harder. Kanvi's small hands trembled against his chest, her eyes wide and wet. "Why are you like this? Why do you always throw yourself into danger for me—?"

His sharp gaze cut down to hers, raw and unguarded. For the first time, his voice broke.

“Because I can’t lose you, Kanvi. Don’t you understand? You’re… you’re everything.”

Her breath caught violently. “Akki…”

The entity shrieked, trying to drown out his words, but nothing could stop them now. His forehead pressed to hers, his breath shaking.

“I’ve spent my whole life believing in equations, in control. But every time I look at you, I lose all of it. Logic, reason—gone. You’re the one variable I can’t solve, the one constant I can’t live without.”

Her heart pounded so hard it hurt. Tears blurred her vision. Her lips trembled as she whispered, “You can’t say things like that. Not when we’re standing on the edge of—of this—”

“I can and I will,” he growled softly, his large hands framing her face now, forcing her gaze to his. “Because if we die here, I need you to know—”

His voice cracked, the scientist finally shattered into something human.

“—I love you, Kanvi.”

She froze, her small body trembling against him. For a moment, the chaos around them didn’t matter.

Her lips parted, a sob escaping her throat as she clutched his coat with shaking hands. “You—idiot. You waited this long to say it?”

His sharp smile quivered, almost broken. “I was afraid. But not anymore. Not with you here.”

Her tears spilled over, but her eyes glowed with something deeper. “Then prove it. Don’t just say it—show me.”

His chest heaved. Slowly, his face lowered, their lips hovering a breath apart.

The chamber seemed to still. Even the shadows paused, watching, waiting.

And then the entity’s voice cut through like a blade:

“Love is the code you cannot break.”

The tendrils surged violently, striking between their faces, ripping them apart before their mouths could meet. Kanvi screamed as she was hurled back, the walls shifting to separate them.

“AKKI!”

He roared, his sharp voice shaking the chamber. “KANVI!”

His tall frame fought the shadows, tearing through tendrils with inhuman fury, his eyes locked only on her.

And in that chaos, her whisper broke the dark—fragile, desperate, but defiant.

“I love you too.”

Breaking the Code

The chamber was breaking apart.
Equations fractured into shards of glowing light, falling like burning snow. The entity shrieked in rage, its tendrils whipping through the air, desperate to tear them apart.

But Akki and Kanvi stood hand in hand at the center, their bodies pressed close, refusing to yield.

Kanvi’s small frame shook with exhaustion, but her eyes burned with fire. “We can’t fight it by force. It’s feeding on fear, on separation. That’s its code.”

Akki’s sharp jaw tightened. His mind raced, but his heart already knew the answer. He turned to her, his tall frame blocking the storm, his grip iron around her hand. “Then we give it what it can’t process.”

Her lashes fluttered. “What?”

“Us,” he whispered fiercely. “Together.”

The analyzer at his side flickered, their twin waveforms still glowing in the air. For a moment, Kanvi saw it: his jagged, sharp lines and her softer, fluid ones merging, overlapping, syncing into something whole.

Her breath hitched. “You mean… our bond is the override?”

Akki’s smirk is curved, raw and dangerous. “It’s the one equation it can’t solve.”

The entity screeched, the chamber trembling violently. “ATTACHMENT IS ERROR. ERROR MUST BE ERASED.”

Kanvi’s small hands rose, cupping Akki’s jaw. Her tears mixed with determination. “Then let’s be the error.”

He froze at her words, his chest heaving, before pressing his forehead to hers. His sharp eyes softened in a way only she could draw out. “God, Kanvi… you’re everything.”

They closed their eyes together.

The analyzer pulsed brighter, syncing their brainwaves fully. Symbols on the walls twisted violently, unable to contain the new pattern.

The entity howled, its body cracking apart, shards of black glass raining down. “UNDEFINED… UNDEFINED…”

Akki’s tall frame trembled as the feedback surged through him, his arm wrapped firmly around Kanvi’s waist. “Hold on to me!”

“I am!” she cried, her voice shaking but fierce. “Always!”

Their hands locked tighter, and suddenly—

The chamber collapsed.

In the ruins, a single rift appeared: a vertical crack of blinding white light, splitting the dark chamber in two. Beyond it was silence, an exit shimmering like salvation.

Kanvi gasped, her tears spilling. “Akki… that’s our way out.”

But as they approached, the entity’s shattered voice echoed one final time:

“Every code has its cost. Step through, and one of you will not remain.”

Kanvi froze, her small hand trembling in his. Her wide eyes lifted to him, terrified. “Akki… it’s a trap. What if it’s true?”

His sharp jaw set, his tall frame pulling her against him, his arms a cage around her fragile body. “Then let it take me.”

Her heart shattered. She slapped his chest weakly, sobbing. “Don’t you dare say that! Don’t you dare—”

His lips brushed her hair, his voice breaking but steady. “I’d rather vanish than live in a world without you.”

The crack of light widened, humming louder. Their bodies shook from its pull, as if reality itself was demanding their decision.

Kanvi’s tears soaked his shirt, her small fists clinging desperately. “No. If one of us disappears… then we both stay. Even if it kills us.”

His sharp eyes glistened, his grip trembling but unrelenting. For once, he couldn’t argue.

Together, hand in hand, they stepped toward the light.

And as the world shattered around them, the diary pages swirled, burning with a single phrase:

“THE CODE IS BROKEN. THE COST IS YET TO BE PAID.”

XVI.
The Forgotten Formula

Waking in the Lab

The world snapped back with a deafening hum.

Akki gasped, his tall frame jerking upright in the cold steel chair. For a moment he didn't know where he was—the dream, the code, Kanvi's trembling voice—they all blurred together. Then the sterile light above him flickered, and he realized he was back in the lab.

The real world.

Or what was left of it.

Around him, the underground laboratory glowed with restless machines. Walls of glass screens pulsed with endless streams of data: EEG spikes, blood-oxygen charts, neural frequency waves. At the center, a capsule-like bed held Kanvi's small body, wires and sensors crisscrossing her delicate frame. Her lashes fluttered faintly against pale cheeks, but she didn't wake.

Akki stumbled forward, ripping off the tangle of electrodes from his own temple, his sharp eyes burning as they locked on her. "Kanvi…" His voice cracked.

She didn't stir.

The monitors above her projected terrifying readouts—her REM cycles accelerating unnaturally, her brainwave activity spiking into unknown ranges. A red alert glowed across the central display:

NEURAL RECURSION DETECTED.

"Damn it," Akki muttered, his sharp jaw tightening. He slammed his hand against the console. "She's still trapped inside."

The AI voice of the lab's central system, NeuroNet Nexus, responded with its calm, synthetic tone: "Subject Kanvi is entering recursion cycle five. Probability of neuronal collapse within two cycles: 87%."

Akki froze. His tall frame trembled as he stared at her unconscious body, chest heaving. "Eighty-seven percent…"

He pushed his hand through his hair, pacing in frustration. Every equation, every formula he knew couldn't explain how she'd gone this deep without breaking.

Then his gaze softened. He stepped to her bedside, lowering himself until his face hovered close to hers. Her lips were parted slightly, her breathing shallow.

"Kanvi," he whispered, his sharp eyes glistening. "You're stronger than anyone I've ever known. But if you keep going… you'll burn yourself out."

He reached for her hand—the small, fragile thing swallowed completely by his larger palm. He squeezed it gently, brushing his thumb across her knuckles.

A flicker ran through the monitors. Her heartbeat jumped slightly at his touch.

His breath caught. “You hear me, don’t you? Even here. You always do.”

For a moment, it was as if the lab quieted, machines softening, only their two connected hands anchoring reality.

Akki lowered his head, pressing his lips to her cool forehead. His whisper was raw. “I promised I’d never let you go. And I don’t break promises. Not to you.”

But when he lifted his gaze again, the monitors only glowed harsher. Her brainwave frequency climbed into ranges he’d never seen—symbols flashing across the graphs like taunts.

A recursion loop that had no exit.

He stood abruptly, his tall frame casting a long shadow across the lab. His sharp jaw clenched, fury rising. “If the system thinks it can take her from me—”

He slammed the console awake, streams of holographic code erupting around him. AI-generated patterns unfolded like luminous maps across the room.

“—then I’ll rewrite the system itself.”

NeuroNet Nexus pulsed, its AI voice calm and cruel:
“Warning. Dream recursion equations are classified as unstable. Attempting to override may result in the collapse of both minds.”

Akki bared his teeth in a sharp grin that was half madness, half devotion. “Then collapse me too. I don’t care. If she goes down, I’m going with her.”

The AI Revelation

The lab’s walls shifted into a storm of holographic projections as Akki activated the full interface. Transparent panels floated around him like shards of glass, each glowing with data pulled from Kanvi’s neural patterns.

Her small body lay motionless in the capsule bed, but the sensors over her temples flared brighter with every second, feeding her dream activity into the system.

Akki's tall frame loomed over the central console, his sharp eyes flicking across endless lines of code. His fingers flew over the holographic keyboard, feeding commands faster than any human should.

"NeuroNet," he barked, voice tight with desperation. "Cross-analyze Kanvi's REM spikes with recursion markers. Run a deep-trace simulation on her synaptic echoes."

The AI pulsed. "Processing. Warning: subject brain activity is operating beyond known thresholds. Estimated recursion probability—"

"Don't estimate," Akki snapped. "Prove it. Show me the math."

The lights in the lab dimmed as every projector focused on a single calculation.

At first, it was just numbers—sequences, fractions, logarithmic spirals. But then the formula stretched, unfolding into something alive, symbols rearranging themselves like a puzzle with no end.

The AI's synthetic voice grew lower, almost like it was afraid of its own result.
"Equation complete. Output designation: Recursive Infinity."

Akki froze. His sharp jaw clenched as he read the projections floating in front of him.

$$\Delta N = f(t), \quad \text{and } \lim_{t \to \infty} f(t) = \infty$$

Every variable pointed to one terrifying outcome.

Kanvi's dream cycles weren't just repeating. They were compounding, each layer stacking into the next until the recursion reached critical failure.

He stepped closer to the hologram, his tall frame bathed in its cold glow. His breath caught in his throat as he traced the final line of the equation.

"Seven cycles," he whispered. "At the seventh, the recursion collapses."

The AI confirmed, its tone flat.
"Host body survival probability past seventh cycle: less than 0.01%. Predicted outcome: irreversible neural disintegration."

Akki's heart dropped. His sharp eyes flew to Kanvi's monitors.

Cycle counter: 6.

His blood turned to ice. “No…”

He stumbled toward her bed, gripping the edge with white knuckles. Her face looked peaceful, almost angelic, framed by the electrodes tangled in her dark hair. But the monitors screamed of danger—her pulse racing, her breathing shallow, her brain lighting up like a burning star.

His voice cracked as he leaned over her, his tall frame shielding her fragile body. “You can’t do this, Kanvi. You can’t burn yourself out just to chase me through the dark.”

Her hand twitched faintly, but she didn’t wake.

Akki bent closer, his lips brushing her small knuckles as he gripped her hand. “If you keep going, you’ll vanish. And I—” His words choked off. His sharp eyes squeezed shut as he pressed her hand harder to his chest. “—I can’t survive a world without you.”

Behind him, the AI spoke again, its tone clinical, almost merciless.
“Solution: terminate recursion. Severe neural link. Subject survival probability: 42%.”

Akki spun toward the projection, fury igniting in his eyes. “Sever the link? You mean kill her consciousness?”

“Affirmative.”

His fist slammed through the console’s hologram, scattering the projections. His voice roared through the lab:

“Over my dead body.”

The Forgotten Formula Unearthed

The lab’s cold hum echoed like a heartbeat as Akki’s fingers flew across the holographic console. Sweat dripped from his sharp jawline, his chest heaving. He had rejected the AI’s cold solution—severing Kanvi’s mind was unthinkable. That left only one path: finding something the system itself had buried.

“Access restricted archives,” he commanded.

The AI hesitated. “Warning. Files are classified under Project Infinity. Do you wish to proceed?”

Akki’s sharp eyes flared with determination. “Override all locks. Password: Kanvi.”

The system whirred. For a moment, nothing happened. Then the room darkened as a single, ancient file bloomed into existence across the holographic chamber.

The file unfolded like a virus infecting every screen: endless equations scrolling too fast to read, diagrams of neural pathways spiraling into black holes, graphs that bled red at their peaks.

And then—an image.

A human brain, projected in holographic detail, cracking apart like glass under pressure. Each fracture spawned ghostly doubles of the same brain, looping endlessly, one inside another like Russian dolls.

Kanvi's small, unconscious frame reflected in the projection—her soft features lit by the terrifying glow.

Akki's tall frame trembled as he watched. His breath caught in his throat, his heart pounding. "God… this is what recursion does…"

He staggered back against her capsule, gripping the edge to stay upright. His sharp eyes locked on the title scrawled across the ancient file:

"The Forgotten Formula – Recursion Equation."

Beneath it, a single chilling note, left by his late mentor, flickered:

"No subject survives beyond Cycle 7. The dream consumes itself. The dreamer becomes the dream."

Akki's hands curled into fists. His voice cracked. "No. Not her. Not Kanvi."

He turned to her again. Her lashes trembled faintly, her small chest rising in fragile breaths. Monitors beeped frantically, her recursion cycle dangerously close to seven.

Akki sank down beside her, his tall frame folding as he pressed his forehead against her hand. His voice was raw, stripped of logic, stripped of science.

"Kanvi, please…" He squeezed her fingers, desperate, his sharp jaw trembling. "Don't leave me. I've spent years pretending equations mattered more than people, but none of it means anything without you. Do you hear me? Nothing."

A tear slipped down his cheek, falling onto her knuckles.

"You're the only constant in this chaos. My only formula that never fails."

Her pulse spiked briefly on the monitor at his words, the line of her brainwave fluttering. Akki froze, staring at the flicker, hope igniting in his chest.

“She heard me,” he whispered, his sharp eyes glistening. He bent down, brushing his lips gently against her cold hand. “Hold on, Kanvi. I swear I’ll drag you back, even if it kills me.”

Behind them, the forgotten formula continued to glow across the lab, its equations rearranging into one final prophecy:

“SEVENTH CYCLE = SACRIFICE.”

The Descent Back In

The holographic projection of the Forgotten Formula still pulsed across the lab, its symbols burning like scars into the air. Akki’s sharp eyes tracked every line, mind racing, chest pounding.

“There’s no shutting it down,” he muttered, pacing across the lab. “If the recursion equation eats her alive, then the only way is to fight it inside.”

NeuroNet Nexus responded in its calm, merciless tone:
“Entering recursion willingly is inadvisable. Probability of survival: 3%.”

Akki’s tall frame still. He looked at Kanvi’s fragile body lying in the capsule, her soft features bathed in the red glow of warning signals. Her pulse monitors spiked erratically.

“Three percent is still better than zero,” he growled.

He swept his hand across the console. Instantly, the lab’s floor panels opened, revealing compartments filled with advanced gear: biometric coils, nanotech synaptic wires, liquid-cooled processors humming with dangerous power.

Akki’s long fingers moved with mechanical precision, pulling pieces together—an angular headset with a crown of neural spikes, coils that shimmered with quantum light.

The AI warned again:
“Caution. Quantum-bridge stabilization incomplete. Merging two consciousness streams may cause permanent overlap.”

“Perfect,” Akki muttered. His sharp jaw tightened into a grim smile. “If I get lost in her mind, at least I’ll be where I belong.”

He strapped the device across his temples. The spikes hummed, locking into his skin with a sting. Holographic veins lit up across the room as his brain synced with the machine.

But then—the monitors blared.

Kanvi’s heart rate plummeted. Her small chest stilled.

BEEP—BEEP—BEEEEEEP.

Flatline.

“NO!” Akki tore the headset off, lunging to her side. His tall frame collapsed over her, both hands shaking as they gripped hers. “Kanvi! Don’t you dare do this to me—don’t you dare!”

Tears burned his sharp eyes as he pressed his forehead against her cold skin. His voice broke.

“You think you can just leave? You promised me forever in that damn dream. And I believed you. So you don’t get to walk away now.”

For a terrifying second, nothing. The lab echoed with the scream of the flatline.

Then—her pulse flickered. Weak. Unstable. But there.

Akki exhaled shakily, his entire body trembling. He brushed his lips to her forehead, whispering with raw desperation.

“Stay. Please, Kanvi. Just… stay. I’ll come find you. I’ll tear apart every dream, every recursion—whatever it takes.”

He slid the headset back on, his tall frame rigid with determination. Quantum light surged through the wires, filling the lab with a blinding glow.

NeuroNet’s final warning echoed:
“Seventh cycle detected. Entering now will bind your consciousness irreversibly.”

Akki’s lips curved into a sharp, broken smile as his eyes closed.

“Then bind me to her.”

And with that, his body arched as the machine roared, dragging his mind violently into the recursion.

The Horror of Recursion

The plunge was violent.

Akki's tall frame convulsed in the real world as his consciousness was ripped through blinding tunnels of light. Equations screamed past him like voices, burning into his mind.

And then—silence.

He opened his sharp eyes.

He was standing in a warped version of the schoolyard where he and Kanvi had once laughed together as children. Only now, the swings moved on their own, rusted chains creaking. The sky above wasn't blue—it was black, streaked with shifting numbers, endless formulas rearranging themselves like living constellations.

Written across that cosmic blackboard in blazing symbols was the prophecy:

"SEVENTH CYCLE = SACRIFICE."

"Akki…"

The voice was soft, trembling.

He turned sharply, and there she was—Kanvi.

Her gorgeous face is pale but glowing faintly in the dark. Her small frame trembled as she stumbled toward him, her eyes wide with tears.

He rushed forward, his tall body swallowing her into his arms with crushing force. For a moment, the dream bent around them, the swings stilling, the creaks falling silent.

Her voice broke against his chest. "I thought you were gone."

His sharp jaw pressed to her hair, his grip tightening. "I told you, Kanvi. You can run through a thousand nightmares—I'll still find you."

But as he held her, movement flickered at the edge of the dream.

Shadowed doubles of Kanvi stepped out from the darkness. Dozens of them—her face twisted, her smile wrong, her eyes hollow. They whispered in unison, their voices like broken glass:

"She cannot leave. She is the formula."

Kanvi gasped, her small hands gripping his coat. "Akki… what are they?"

His sharp eyes burned as he pulled her behind him, his tall frame shielding her. "They're not you. Just echoes. Errors."

The shadows hissed, stepping closer. Their voices rose:
“Recursion demands sacrifice. One dreamer stays. One awakens.”

Kanvi’s knees buckled, horror in her eyes. “That’s what the formula meant… Seventh cycle—”

Akki spun to her, gripping her shoulders, forcing her gaze into his. “Don’t listen to it. Do you hear me? Whatever it says—we’ll break it together.”

Her tears spilled, her lips trembling. “But if it’s true… then one of us—”

His thumb brushed her cheek, his sharp eyes fierce and unyielding. “Then it’ll be me. Never you.”

Her sob cracked into anger. She slapped his chest weakly, shaking. “Stop saying that! I won’t let you—”

But before she could finish, the shadows lunged.

Akki roared, dragging her into his arms as the horde of Kanvi-doubles swarmed. Their hands clawed, their voices screaming the same line again and again:

“SEVENTH CYCLE = SACRIFICE. SEVENTH CYCLE = SACRIFICE.”

He crushed Kanvi tighter against him, spinning, shielding her from every strike. His sharp jaw clenched, his breath ragged.

And then, above the chaos, the numbers in the sky shifted violently, equations glowing blood-red. The final line blazed across the heavens:

“ONE WILL WAKE. ONE WILL BECOME THE DREAM.”

Kanvi froze, her heart slamming against his chest. She looked up at him, tears pouring.

“Akki… how do we know if we’re even real anymore?”

His arms tightened, his voice breaking as he kissed her hair.

“I don’t care. As long as I’m with you—I’ll believe in this dream.”

XVII.
The Shattered Bridge

Between Two Worlds

The hum of the lab wasn't steady anymore.
It pulsed. Like a dying heart.

Akki's sharp eyes flickered open, sweat dripping down his temple. For a moment, he thought he had returned fully to reality—he could feel the cold metal beneath his palms, hear the low vibration of the servers. But then he blinked again… and the ceiling shifted. The fluorescent lights bent into impossible angles, bleeding into streaks of black equations, scrawled across the air itself.

Half the lab was real.
The other half was still… dream.

Kanvi's capsule lay at the center, her small frame convulsing faintly, skin pale. Wires and electrodes clung to her temples like metallic vines, her body caught between breathing and not breathing. The monitors above her flickered violently.

For one second, they showed her vitals—heart rate, brain activity.
Next, they showed her face. Eyes open. Lips moving. Whispering something he couldn't hear.

Akki's tall frame froze. He leaned closer, pressing his ear to the monitor, his pulse hammering.

"...Akki…"

His entire chest seized. "Kanvi."

Her voice wasn't coming from her lips. Her unconscious body hadn't moved at all. It was the screen whispering, glitching, bleeding her presence into both worlds at once.

Akki stumbled back, sharp jaw tightening, hands trembling.

"NeuroNet," he barked. "Status!"

The AI's cold tone reverberated:
"Subject consciousness is unstable. Recursion bridge fractured. Kanvi's neural imprint is split across two layers."

Akki's eyes widened. "Split…? You mean—"

"Her mind is no longer whole. If separation persists, the body will die. If the bridge collapses, both minds will be lost."

The words stabbed deeper than knives. Akki turned back to her capsule, his tall frame bending low over her fragile hand. He gripped it tightly, thumb brushing her knuckles. Her skin was cool, but he swore for a second he felt a faint squeeze in return.

His voice broke, hoarse, almost begging.
"You always ran ahead of me, Kanvi. Even in class, even in life. But this…" He pressed her hand harder to his chest, his sharp eyes shimmering. "This time you don't get to go alone. You don't get to leave me standing here."

The lab itself began to warp again—walls breathing, cables writhing like serpents. From the corners of the room came whispers, low and hissing, repeating fragments of the recursion formula.

"Seventh cycle… one remains… one awakens…"

Akki's head snapped up, fury igniting in his gaze. "Shut up!" He roared into the shadows, voice cracking. "She's not your sacrifice! She's mine to protect!"

The whispers grew louder, circling him like predators. Kanvi's vitals dipped on the monitor, her flatline warning screaming for an instant before bouncing back erratically.

Akki collapsed against the capsule, forehead pressed to her hand, whispering through clenched teeth.

"I'll find you. I'll build the bridge myself if I have to. And if it breaks beneath us, then let it—because I'd rather fall with you than wake without you."

The monitors flickered—Kanvi's faint voice returned, softer this time, like an answer from the abyss.
"...don't… let go…"

Building the Bridge

The lab lights dimmed to blood-red as Akki tore open the compartments hidden beneath the floor panels. Sleek cases hissed as they unlocked, revealing arrays of futuristic equipment — nanotech coils pulsing with faint blue light, quantum processors humming like miniature stars, and transparent cables that shimmered as if woven from liquid silver.

His tall frame bent low as he pulled the devices out one by one, his long fingers working feverishly, faster than the AI could even log his movements. Sweat dripped from his sharp jaw, his breath harsh.

"NeuroNet," he barked. "Initiate dream-bridge protocol. Override safety locks."

The AI's calm voice pulsed through the room:
"Warning. The dream bridge is unstable. Predicted survival rate: 6%."

“Six is better than zero,” Akki muttered, slamming the coils into place on the central hub. Sparks shot out as the system whined in protest.

Slowly, a structure began to take shape in the center of the lab — a jagged, glass-like arch of holographic grids rising above Kanvi’s capsule. It wasn’t solid, not fully; its surface rippled like water, its edges glowing with equations that shifted and screamed.

The bridge.

But it was fractured, incomplete — shards of light missing, gaps yawning like broken teeth.

Akki adjusted the stabilizers, forcing the nanotech wires to weave across the gaps, each strand glowing with a faint hum. The more he forced the system to stabilize, the more the monitors bled with red warnings.

“Overload imminent. Probability of collapse: 92%.”

“Then hold it together for 8%,” Akki growled, his sharp eyes blazing.

He turned back to Kanvi’s capsule.

Her small frame looked even more fragile beneath the bridge’s shifting light. Electrodes clung to her skin, her pulse weak, her breathing shallow. She looked less like a patient and more like a fading memory.

Akki’s tall figure lowered beside her. He took her hand gently, pressing it against his chest as if willing his heartbeat into her. His voice trembled, but it was steady with resolve.

“You always told me I lived too much in numbers. That I was all logic, no heart. You were wrong, Kanvi. Because right now… I’m nothing but heart. And it’s beating only for you.”

He leaned down, brushing his lips softly against her forehead, lingering there as if afraid to move away. His whisper was raw, almost broken:

“Wait for me on the other side. Don’t let the bridge shatter before I get to you.”

The monitors screamed again. Her vitals spiked, then dipped, as if answering him. For a second, her lips parted, barely moving, whispering through the static of the dream:

“…don’t… fall…”

Akki froze, his sharp eyes widening. She was still there. She was fighting.

He straightened, his tall frame rigid with determination, fingers tightening the final strap of the quantum headset across his own temples. The spikes glowed white-hot, syncing with the arching bridge above.

The AI gave one last, merciless warning:
“Dream bridge stabilizing. Collapse probability—critical. Proceed?”

Akki’s lips curved into a grim, fearless smile.
“Proceed.”

The arch roared to life, shards of light snapping together, equations blinding. The fractured bridge screamed as if alive, but it held. Barely.

And with one final look at Kanvi’s fragile body, Akki stepped into the impossible light.

Inside the Shattered Bridge

The moment Akki stepped into the bridge, reality shattered.

He felt the ground vanish under his boots, only to reform into jagged shards of glass, each piece suspended in a black void. They weren’t just glass — they were memories, fragments of lives that belonged to him and Kanvi.

One shard glowed with the golden sunlight of their schoolyard, children laughing as two younger versions of themselves raced across the grass. Another shimmered with the sterile white of a hospital corridor, where Kanvi had first learned medicine, her small frame wrapped in a lab coat too big for her. Another shard flickered with the science fair — her playful teasing, his annoyed sharp jaw tightening as he adjusted their project.

Each shard trembled, unstable, breaking apart into dust and falling into the endless darkness below.

Akki’s tall frame steadied itself on a jagged edge, his sharp eyes scanning desperately. “Kanvi!”

The void answered with silence. Then—her voice. Soft, trembling.

“Akki…”

His head snapped toward the far side of the fractured bridge. Across dozens of floating shards, half-hidden in the glow of collapsing memories, stood Kanvi.

Her gorgeous face was pale, eyes wide with terror. Her small body trembled, one foot slipping dangerously near the edge of the shard she stood on.

Akki’s chest clenched so hard it hurt. He surged forward, leaping across shards, each one collapsing the moment his boots left them.

“Hold on! Don’t move!”

The shards cracked under him, old memories breaking apart.

As he jumped across the glowing schoolyard fragment, he saw his younger self glance up — eyes filled with innocent laughter. But the shard shattered instantly, pulling the child-version into the void.

Akki's jaw tightened, his pulse hammering. "Don't look back. Don't you dare look back."

Kanvi reached her hand out across the abyss, her voice breaking. "You shouldn't be here. The bridge—it won't hold both of us—"

"Then let it break!" Akki roared, leaping across another collapsing memory. "I don't care if the world burns, as long as I reach you!"

He landed hard on a shard that showed the night of their first secret walk — the faint moonlight, the hushed laughter. The shard cracked violently beneath his boots, glowing veins of light tearing across it.

Akki sprinted, every muscle straining, his tall frame moving like fire through the dying dreamscape.

Kanvi sobbed, her hand outstretched, tears streaking down her pale cheeks. "Why won't you ever listen to me, Akki? If you fall here—you'll never come back—"

He reached the final shard, just as her foot slipped.

"Kanvi!"

He lunged, his strong arm wrapping around her small wrist at the last possible second. Her scream echoed through the void, but he held on, pulling her against his chest.

They collapsed together onto the trembling shard, his tall body shielding her fragile form from the collapsing edges. His heart thundered against her as he gripped her tight, refusing to let go.

Her tears dampened his shirt as she gasped into his chest. "Why… Why do you always risk everything for me?"

His sharp jaw trembled as he buried his face in her hair, his voice raw.
"Because without you, Kanvi… there's nothing worth saving."

The shard groaned beneath them, cracks widening. The void screamed, black winds tearing across the broken bridge.

And in the distance, the shadowed doubles began to emerge again, their voices like shattered glass:

"One will wake. One will remain."

Akki's grip on Kanvi only tightened. His sharp eyes blazed with defiance.
"Not this time."

Collapse of the Bridge

The shard beneath their feet screamed, a high-pitched fracture ripping through it like thunder. Akki pulled Kanvi tighter against his chest, his tall frame shielding her as glowing cracks spread across the glassy surface.

Above them, the dream-sky writhed. Equations rearranged violently, twisting into blood-red numbers that pulsed like veins. Each symbol burned into the void as if carved by an invisible hand.

Kanvi's small fingers clutched his coat, her tearful eyes fixed upward. "Akki… it's rewriting itself…"

The equations solidified into a single, merciless line:

"SEVENTH CYCLE = ONE WILL WAKE. ONE WILL REMAIN."

Akki's sharp jaw clenched, fury rising like fire in his veins. "I don't care what it says."

The shadows emerged then — dozens of Kanvi's doubles, their gorgeous faces warped into hollow-eyed masks. Their whispers hissed through the broken bridge, each one speaking with her voice, but stripped of warmth.

"You cannot both cross. The bridge demands sacrifice. The recursion will claim one."

Kanvi's body trembled in his arms. Her small hands pushed weakly against his chest, as if to free herself. Her voice cracked, drenched in tears.

"Maybe they're right, Akki. If staying here saves you—"

"Don't you dare finish that sentence!" Akki thundered, gripping her tighter. His sharp eyes burned as he cupped her face, forcing her to look at him. "I didn't build this bridge to lose you. I built it because I can't imagine a world without you in it."

The shard collapsed violently beneath them, sending them both plummeting.

Kanvi screamed, her arms locking desperately around his neck as they fell through blackness. Shards of memories spiraled past them — their first laugh, the night walk, the whispered promises. Each fragment shattered to dust before it touched them.

Akki twisted mid-air, shielding her with his tall frame, his voice raw as he shouted into the abyss.
"You hear me? I don't care what formula you wrote—I'll rewrite it myself!"

The shadows screamed back, the void itself echoing their words:
“One will wake. One will remain.”

They landed hard on another shard — this one larger, but trembling violently as if seconds away from breaking apart.

The shadow entity materialized in front of them this time — not Kanvi’s face, but a grotesque, shifting silhouette of himself.

Akki froze, staring at the distorted copy. Its sharp jaw and blazing eyes mirrored his own, but twisted, hollow.

The shadow’s voice was thunder and static.
“You cannot save her. You are the variable that must be removed. Without you, the recursion stabilizes. Without you… she lives.”

Kanvi clutched his hand, shaking her head violently, tears streaming down her cheeks. “No. Don’t listen. Don’t you ever listen to it.”

Akki’s tall frame squared itself, pulling her behind him. His glare could have burned steel.
“Then let’s both die, but we’re dying together.”

The shard split in two, light pouring from the cracks. Time slowed. Equations burned across the dream-sky, the bridge groaning, collapsing into the abyss.

Kanvi sobbed, pressing her forehead to his chest. “What do we do, Akki?”

His lips brushed her hair, his whisper fierce and trembling.
“We jump. Together. Always together.”

Her breath caught. Their eyes met — hers wide with fear, his sharp eyes unbreakable, shining with love.

And as the shard broke apart beneath them, they clasped hands tighter, their bodies pressed together.

Then they leapt, side by side, into the blinding core of the shattered bridge.

The Leap of Faith

The core of the bridge was collapsing, shards exploding around them like dying stars. Equations rained from the dream-sky, glowing symbols that burned into Akki’s skin as they fell.

He clutched Kanvi’s hand so tightly his knuckles turned white. Her small fingers trembled in his grip, but she didn’t pull away. Instead, her tear-streaked face lifted to his, her lips whispering against the chaos.

“If we don’t make it…” her voice cracked, “I just want you to know—I loved you long before I even knew how to say it.”

Akki’s sharp eyes blazed, his tall frame trembling with fury and love. He bent closer, pressing his forehead to hers, their breaths mingling as the void screamed around them.

“Then say it again on the other side. Because I’m not letting you go here.”

The shard beneath them shattered completely.

They leapt.

Together.

Their bodies plunged into the blinding core — light so bright it burned every memory into fire.

Fragments of their lives burst like glass around them:

The schoolyard, where little Kanvi tugged his sleeve, giggling as he pretended to ignore her.

The library night, her small hands brushing his as they discovered the forbidden research together.

The science fair, where she teased him mercilessly until his sharp jaw clenched, only to soften when she smiled.

The night walk, where she whispered secrets under the stars.

The kiss that almost happened, interrupted by fear, left hanging in eternity.

Each memory blazed past them, shattering into dust, until only darkness remained.

In the real world, alarms shrieked.

The lab monitors spiked violently, Kanvi’s vitals flatlining, Akki’s brainwaves spiking into impossible frequencies. The dream-bridge arch convulsed, shards of holographic glass raining across the consoles.

NeuroNet AI’s calm voice cut through the chaos:
“Warning. Neural overlap detected. Bridge integrity lost. Both subjects… status unknown.”

The systems crackled with static. One by one, the monitors died, the lab plunged into darkness.

In the dream-core, Akki and Kanvi still fell, their bodies entwined, hands locked, eyes shut against the blinding storm.

Kanvi’s voice was faint, breaking apart in the light. “Akki… I’m scared…”

His grip tightened, his whisper steady despite the fire tearing through him.
“Don’t be. Even if this is the end—we’ll face it together.”

The light swallowed them whole.

And then—silence.

Everything went black.

A single line pulsed across the dead monitors in blood-red text:

“BRIDGE SHATTERED. STATUS: UNKNOWN.”

XVIII.
When Worlds Collide

The Glitching Lab

The lab wasn't the same anymore.

Where once the monitors had hummed in steady rhythm, now they flickered violently, light stuttering across the walls like lightning trapped in glass. Equations bled across the screens, repeating endlessly until they broke into fragments — fragments that detached themselves from the displays and hovered in the air like glowing insects.

The hum of machinery deepened into a guttural growl. Cables snaked across the floor as if alive.

And then the holograms appeared.

At first, just a faint shimmer above Kanvi's capsule. A soft silhouette. Then it sharpened, solidified, and there she was — not unconscious, not fragile, but standing. Small frame radiant, eyes wide with something between confusion and sorrow. She wasn't moving like a machine-generated image. She was moving like her.

Akki, though unconscious in his own capsule, could feel it. His chest constricted, his pulse raced.

The holographic Kanvi stepped forward, her gorgeous face illuminated by the chaos of fractured light. She lifted her hand slowly, as if gravity fought her every motion. And then — impossibly — she brushed her fingers against Akki's cheek.

But her hand passed through.

NeuroNet's cold voice cut through the air, distorted by static:
"Warning. Reality overlap detected. Subjective projections are bleeding into the physical environment. Consciousness integrity compromised."

Another hologram shimmered into existence — this time, a younger Akki, no older than fifteen, his tall frame awkward, his sharp eyes still unshaped by experience. He stood beside the capsule, watching the unconscious Kanvi with raw devotion.

The younger Akki whispered:
"You promised we'd always walk together."

And then he dissolved into static.

The lab lights dimmed further. More projections appeared, scattering like ghosts through the room:

Kanvi at twelve, tugging on Akki's sleeve in the schoolyard.

Akki at eighteen, furious and passionate, shouting during their science fair fight.

Kanvi in a white coat, smiling shyly as she adjusted a stethoscope.

The night walk beneath the stars — her small frame brushing his shoulder, his tall silhouette walking silently beside her.

Each projection flickered, overlapped, and then vanished, leaving the smell of burning ozone in the air.

The AI stuttered again:
“Multiple timelines converging. Probability of collapse increasing. 64%... 72%... 89%...”

Kanvi’s hologram — the current one, trembling and radiant — leaned over Akki’s unconscious body again. Her lips moved this time, and her voice was soft but heartbreakingly clear.

“Wake up… before it’s too late.”

The glass of the capsule cracked faintly, not from pressure, but from the sound of her words resonating in both dream and reality at once.

For the first time, the line between living and projection had blurred.

And the collision had only begun.

Projections Multiply

The hum of the quantum cores shifted again—no longer mechanical, but almost human, like a choir of broken voices singing in static.

And then the projections multiplied.

Not one, not two. Dozens. Hundreds.

Every wall, every reflective surface, every inch of the lab was filled with overlapping visions, each one flickering in and out of existence. The sterile white walls melted into colors, into forests, into cityscapes, into classrooms.

The lab had become a prism of lives that never should have touched.

Kanvi’s unconscious body lay still in her capsule, but holograms of her bloomed all around.

In one corner, a Kanvi in her twenties, laughing, her hair loose as she leaned on Akki’s shoulder.

Across the room, another Kanvi stood in a surgeon’s theatre, blood on her gloves, sharp focus in her eyes.

Yet another Kanvi — older, lined with grief — sat alone, staring at an empty chair.

Every version moved, breathed, lived, as if they were not mere holograms, but actual lives.

Akki's sharp consciousness, still tethered inside recursion, felt it. He wasn't just seeing Kanvi's futures and pasts — he was walking through them. His tall frame moved instinctively, trying to push through the illusions, trying to find the real her.

But the horror was in the details.

In one hologram, he saw himself — older, alone, surrounded by his machines, Kanvi nowhere in sight. In another, she stood beside someone else, smiling up at them the way she once smiled at him.

His jaw clenched. His chest constricted. He staggered back, as if punched by something far worse than any shadow.

"Lies," he growled, voice raw. "These are lies. She chose me."

But the projections didn't stop. They swarmed.

The AI's distorted voice rose over the chaos:
"Warning: Quantum interference. Projections are not simulations. They are possibilities. Collision probability 96%."

Kanvi's holographic doubles turned, all at once, their gorgeous faces locking onto him. Some smiled, some cried, some reached for him desperately.

And in the chaos, one projection moved differently.

One Kanvi stepped forward, her small hand trembling as she reached across the shifting realities. Her voice, unlike the rest, didn't echo—it struck straight into his chest.

"Akki… it's really me."

He froze.

His sharp eyes burned as he stared at her, trying to separate her from the illusions. The lab flickered violently, half collapsing into dream-forest, half burning with white-hot equations.

His lips trembled as he whispered, almost breaking:
"Kanvi… if it's you… then hold on to me. Don't let them take you."

She nodded through her tears, and for one impossible second—her small hand brushed his.

Static cracked. Both their bodies jolted as if lightning had struck.

Reality itself had bent to let them touch.

Collision Begins

The lab was no longer the lab.

The floor beneath Kanvi's capsule rippled like water, every vibration distorting the tiles until they cracked into floating shards. The machines lining the walls stretched into impossible shapes—wires became roots, screens melted into glowing dream-shards that pulsed like hearts.

Reality and dream were no longer separate. They were bleeding into one another.

Akki's tall figure staggered as he pushed through the chaos. His sharp eyes scanned desperately for her amidst the holograms, each step taking him into a new fragment of reality.

One second, he was running on the steel tiles of the lab.
The next, the floor dissolved into soft grass, dew sparkling beneath his boots. Above him stretched a night sky that wasn't Earth's, with stars pulsing equations instead of constellations.

Then the grass burned away, replaced by endless hospital corridors where stretchers rolled by themselves, whispering her name.

"Kanvi… Kanvi!" he roared, his voice trembling with rage and desperation.

And then—he saw her.

Her small frame, flickering, suspended between two overlapping worlds. One half of her body lay still in the capsule, unconscious. The other half — glowing faintly, gorgeous face pale and eyes wide — stood across the collapsing void, trapped inside a transparent wall of shifting code.

Her lips moved. He couldn't hear her, but he knew.
She was calling his name.

Akki slammed his fists against the shifting barrier, the force sending tremors through the holographic wall. "I see you, Kanvi! Just hold on!"

NeuroNet's voice bled through the distortion, broken, panicked for the first time:
"Warning. Collision layer unstable. Dream and physical boundaries converging. Entity interference detected. Risk: uncontrollable."

The machines around him sparked violently. A hovering drone, meant to monitor vitals, twisted midair, its smooth body morphing into a grotesque shard of dream-stone before crumbling into dust.

Another console flickered, its screen suddenly showing Kanvi as a child, smiling shyly, before the glass shattered and the image blew away like sand.

The lab was dying.

Kanvi pressed her small palms against the barrier, her eyes brimming with tears. Her voice finally broke through the distortion, desperate and trembling.

“Akki… I can feel you but I can’t reach you! It’s pulling me back!”

His jaw tightened, fury flashing across his sharp features. He placed his tall frame against the barrier, both hands pressing exactly where hers were, though separated by layers of light and code.

“You think this wall can stop me? After everything we’ve survived?” His voice cracked, low and raw. “Kanvi, you’re mine to hold. And if this reality doesn’t allow it—then I’ll break reality itself.”

The barrier sparked violently at their touch. For a second—just a second—their fingers brushed.

It was enough.

A surge of energy pulsed through both their bodies. Kanvi gasped as her knees buckled, Akki’s tall frame pressing harder against the barrier to keep her steady.

“Akki…” she whispered, voice faint, “If you break the wall, everything else could collapse—”

“Then let it collapse!” he snapped, eyes blazing. “I don’t care if the world turns to ash, as long as I reach you.”

The lab convulsed like a living creature. Equations spilled across the air like blood, rearranging violently. Lights shattered into sparks, showering both of them in fragments of burning data.

And from the corner of the shifting lab, something darker stirred.

The air rippled, bent, and began to fold inward, as if space itself was being chewed apart. A figure took shape there, not solid, not liquid—only a shifting silhouette of shadows and glitching light.

The entity had arrived.

NeuroNet’s voice boomed, urgent, distorted with static:
“Unknown entity entering. Integrity compromised. Layers collapse in 180 seconds.”

Kanvi's scream pierced the chaos.
"Akki! It's here!"

He pressed his forehead against the barrier, sharp jaw trembling, every muscle in his body straining against the impossible. His voice came out as both a promise and a plea:

"Then hold tighter. Because I'm not letting anything—not this wall, not that shadow—take you from me."

And with a final, desperate push, their palms aligned perfectly—light exploding outward, shattering the fragile barrier into a storm of sparks.

For the first time, across collapsing worlds, their hands locked.

Together.

Entity in the Lab

The barrier shattered with a scream of light. Sparks rained across the lab, filling the room with the scent of burnt metal and ozone. For the first time since the collision began, Akki's hand gripped Kanvi's small palm firmly—real, not hologram, not illusion.

Her gorgeous face tilted up toward him, eyes wide with disbelief and relief. "You… you really broke it…"

Akki's sharp eyes softened as he pulled her against his chest, his tall frame enveloping her trembling body. "I told you, Kanvi. Nothing can stop me from reaching you."

For a heartbeat, everything was still. The chaos seemed to pause, holding its breath as if reality itself acknowledged their reunion.

And then the shadows moved.

From the far end of the collapsing lab, the air warped like a heat haze. The shadow entity emerged—half smoke, half corrupted hologram, its outline shifting between human and monstrous. At moments, it looked like Akki, jaw sharp, eyes blazing. At others, it mirrored Kanvi, her face twisted into emptiness.

Every step it took bent the floor, dream-shards bursting upward like broken glass.

NeuroNet's voice cracked with static:
"Defense protocols: MAXIMUM. Deploying nanodrones."

Panels slid open in the ceiling, releasing swarms of sleek silver drones. They whirred, their cores glowing blue as they formed barriers around Akki and Kanvi.

The shadow hissed. Its voice was every whisper Kanvi had ever made, every promise Akki had ever broken, layered and distorted.

“Two cannot remain. One must fall. The bridge demands it.”

The drones fired streams of plasma light. The entity dissolved, only to reappear behind them, ripping one drone in half with a swipe of glitching claws. Sparks flew, the broken drone screaming as if alive before crumbling into ash.

Kanvi flinched, burying her face against Akki’s chest. Her small body trembled violently. “It’s stronger than the system…”

Akki’s jaw tightened. He wrapped one arm protectively around her, his other hand grabbing a drone’s control panel midair. With a surge of will, his mind synced with the AI. Equations and commands burned across his vision.

“NeuroNet,” he snarled, “rerouted all quantum cores into manual links. Through me.”

The AI hesitated.
“Warning: Human integration risks fatal neural overload.”

“Do it!” Akki roared, his sharp eyes blazing.

The drones responded instantly. Their blue cores shifted red, streams of raw energy surging into Akki’s body. His tall frame jolted violently, veins glowing faint beneath his skin as if fire flowed through them.

Kanvi gasped, clutching his shirt. “Akki, stop! You’ll burn yourself—”

He leaned close, his forehead pressing briefly against hers despite the chaos. His voice was steady, fierce, trembling with love.
“I’d rather burn than let it touch you.”

The shadow screeched, lunging. Akki turned, his entire body glowing with redirected drone energy. He thrust his arm forward, and a beam of searing quantum light erupted, slamming into the entity.

The lab shook. Walls melted between steel and forest, between code and memory. The shadow’s form writhed, its body torn apart—only to reform again, larger, darker.

Kanvi cried out, pressing closer to him. “It’s feeding on the collision! Every attack makes it stronger!”

NeuroNet’s broken voice confirmed, shrill with urgency:
“Entity adapting. Collapse in 90 seconds.”

Akki's knees nearly buckled under the overload, but his grip on Kanvi never loosened. His lips brushed her ear as he whispered, low and fierce:
"Then we don't fight it. We run. Together."

Kanvi's wide, tearful eyes locked onto him. "Where can we even run? There's nowhere left!"

The lab convulsed violently—half dissolving into the schoolyard, half into the hospital, half into the black void of the dream-bridge. The entity's voice bled across every surface:

"One will wake. One will remain."

Akki's sharp jaw clenched as he tightened his hold on her small frame. "We'll prove it wrong."

And, hand in hand, they plunged into the shifting storm as the entity screamed behind them, tearing through both dream and reality.

Worlds Tear Apart

The lab could no longer be called a lab.

Its walls had dissolved into chaos: one side stretched into the endless schoolyard where their childhood had begun; another rippled into the glowing forest of recursion; the ceiling opened into a night sky split between stars and blood-red equations.

Every step Akki and Kanvi took shattered the ground beneath them into a new memory, a new world. One moment, they were standing on hospital tiles, cold and sterile. The next, the tiles melted into grass, dew soaking their feet as a holographic sunrise bled into the void.

It wasn't a room anymore. It was a storm of lives colliding.

Kanvi's small frame pressed desperately against Akki's tall, glowing figure. Her wide eyes darted around at the shifting scenery. "Akki… it's everything. All our worlds… colliding at once."

He tightened his grip on her hand, his sharp eyes scanning the chaos. His voice was rough, broken with fury and determination.
"Then we run. We find the path that belongs to us."

They sprinted forward, their hands locked so tightly it hurt.

Behind them, the shadow entity grew.

It no longer had a shape—it was a distortion, a storm of black static that clawed through each world, tearing forests into smoke, breaking schools into ash, shattering memories like glass. Its whispers drowned the storm:

“One will wake. One will remain. The bridge cannot carry two.”

The ground beneath them cracked again, splitting into two paths. One led into the hospital corridor, Kanvi’s white coat gleaming faintly within. The other led into Akki’s lab, his machines sparking endlessly.

The message was clear. Two fates. Two survivors. Never together.

Kanvi slowed, tears spilling down her cheeks. “It wants us to choose…”

Akki yanked her back against his chest, his tall frame trembling with defiance. “Then we don’t.”

The storm howled as they ran straight into the middle path—the one that didn’t exist, the one that collapsed into nothingness. Worlds tore apart around them, bending, breaking, folding into themselves.

Kanvi gasped as the ground disintegrated under her feet. Akki lifted her effortlessly, his arms locking around her waist as he leapt into the void.

Her face pressed against his neck, her voice breaking. “Akki, if this destroys you—”

“Then let it destroy me,” he growled. “But it’ll never separate us.”

For a moment, the void accepted them. They floated in a tunnel of overlapping realities—every alternate life flashing around them:

Kanvi and Akki at fifteen, holding textbooks side by side.

Kanvi laughing in a white gown, Akki fumbling nervously with a tie.

Older versions of them, tired but still walking hand in hand through a ruined world.

A lonely Akki, machines his only company.

A broken Kanvi, weeping into silence.

Each vision begged them to choose.

But they refused.

They clung tighter to each other, their breaths ragged, their hearts beating as one.

The entity struck.

With a roar of static, it slammed into the tunnel, tearing the alternate visions apart. Its form coiled around them, claws of black light ripping into the void.

Kanvi screamed as the entity's force wrapped around her small frame, trying to wrench her from Akki's arms. Her nails dug into his shirt, her voice raw with terror. "Don't let go! Please, don't let go!"

Akki's sharp eyes blazed. His entire body burned with fury as he roared back into the storm:
"I WON'T!"

But the entity was stronger.

With a deafening crack, it split the tunnel in two. Akki and Kanvi were torn apart, ripped from each other's grasp. Their fingertips brushed desperately as they were hurled into opposite shards of reality.

Her final scream echoed through the collapsing void:
"AKKI!"

His answer, torn from his throat, raw and shattering:
"KANVI!"

And then the world went white.

In the lab, the monitors flickered once, twice, before going black.

Only one line pulsed in blood-red across the dead systems:

"COLLISION POINT REACHED. REALITY OVERRIDDEN."

XIX.
The Vanishing Hour

Silence Before the Storm

The hum of the machines had stopped.

For hours, the lab had been filled with ceaseless sounds — the crackle of monitors, the hiss of vents, the beeping of Kanvi's vitals, the constant stream of equations scrolling across screens. But now, it was as if the world itself had pressed pause.

The air was heavy. Too heavy.

Akki's tall frame stood rigid, his sharp eyes scanning every corner of the fractured room. His entire body felt wired, coiled, like a predator waiting for the unseen enemy to pounce. The silence wasn't absent. It was a presence.

Beside him, Kanvi's small frame trembled slightly. She pressed closer, her gorgeous face pale in the ghostly glow of the flickering monitors. Her soft hand tightened around his arm, as though holding onto him could keep her tethered in this collapsing world.

"Why… Why is it so quiet?" she whispered, her voice barely more than breath.

Her wide eyes darted around. The lab wasn't just a lab anymore. The walls shimmered in and out of existence. Sometimes it was the steel-lined walls of their base. Sometimes, just for a second, it was the hallway of their old school, sun slanting across lockers. And then the next blink, a surgical room, splattered in blood that wasn't real but felt far too real.

Kanvi's pulse raced. She could hear it in her ears. Louder and louder.

Akki finally spoke. His voice was low, deliberate, meant to steady her even though his chest was burning with the same unease.

"Because it wants us to hear it when it comes."

The words hung in the air like lead.

Kanvi's throat tightened. Her mind screamed at her to ask, what wants us to hear it? but she already knew. That shadow—the thing that had haunted their dreams, stalked their memories, torn the line between reality and recursion—it wasn't gone. It was hiding.

And waiting.

The silence stretched on.

Kanvi tried to distract herself, eyes flicking to the dead monitors. The screens had stopped showing equations. Instead, faint static lines drifted across them like veins. In one, she thought she saw her own reflection—except older, face hollow, eyes lifeless. In another, she saw Akki, but his jaw was bloodied, his eyes empty.

She blinked hard, and the images were gone.

Her small fingers tightened harder on Akki's arm. "Akki… something's wrong with the time here. I feel like everything's… stretched. Like we're inside the moment before a scream."

He glanced down at her. His sharp jaw was clenched, but his voice softened when it was only for her. "Stay close to me. No matter what happens, you don't let go. Promise me."

Her wide eyes shimmered with tears, but she nodded. "I promise."

The lab groaned suddenly, like steel bending under invisible pressure.

Kanvi jumped, instinctively pressing her face against his chest. His tall frame tightened protectively around her. He could feel the tiny tremors of her body against him.

"Shhh," he murmured, pressing his lips briefly against her hair. "It's just the walls. It can't hurt you as long as I'm here."

But even he knew it was a lie. The silence was no longer silence. It was breathing.

Something in the shadows was exhaling.

Kanvi dared to look up again, her gorgeous face pale but resolute. Her doctor's mind tried to rationalize what she saw—shadows lengthening against the wall even though no light had shifted, reflections moving a fraction slower than the bodies they mirrored.

Her heart pounded faster. "Akki… I think it's already here."

The words barely left her lips when the air rippled—like heat rising from asphalt.

Akki's sharp eyes snapped toward the distortion, his body pulling her instinctively behind him. His tall frame blocked her completely, like a shield of flesh and will.

"Stay behind me." His voice was low, a growl, no longer steady but burning with fury.

Kanvi's small hand clutched his shirt desperately, her wide eyes locked on the darkening corner of the lab. The silence cracked.

And the storm began.

The First Strike

The ripple in the air grew darker, heavier—like ink spreading in water.

Kanvi's breath caught in her throat. Her small hand clutched tighter at Akki's arm as the distortion twisted into form.

And then, without warning—
It struck.

Not with footsteps. Not with sound.

But with violence.

The shadow entity exploded out of the distortion like a jagged spear of darkness, tearing through the lab with unnatural speed. The air itself screamed as the claws of black light ripped across the floor, leaving a glowing gash that pulsed like an open wound.

Kanvi cried out, stumbling back—
But Akki was faster.

His tall frame surged forward, grabbing her around the waist and dragging her behind him just as the claws slashed inches away from her. Sparks erupted, monitors shattered, shards of glass flying like razors. He turned his body to shield her, taking the rain of debris against his back.

Kanvi gasped, her wide eyes full of terror as she buried her face into his chest.
"Akki!"

His sharp jaw clenched, his voice raw with fury.
"I've got you."

The shadow rose fully now, its form flickering between human and monster. Sometimes it looked like Akki—tall, broad, jaw cut sharp—but with hollow and soulless eyes. Other times it twisted into Kanvi's reflection—her gorgeous face broken into a thousand shards, her lips whispering without sound.

It was them. Both of them. But it is corrupted.

The entity's voice poured across the lab like static soaked in venom:
"One must remain. One must vanish."

The words pierced straight into Kanvi's mind. Her knees buckled, and she nearly collapsed, clutching at Akki's arm like a lifeline. Tears blurred her vision. "It… it wants me. Akki, it's after me—"

He turned sharply, grabbing her shoulders, forcing her to meet his blazing eyes. His tall frame trembled with rage, but his voice was steady, protective.
“No. It’s after us. And it will have to kill me before it ever lays a hand on you.”

Kanvi’s chest heaved, her lips trembling as she whispered, “You can’t fight that thing—”

“Watch me.”

The lab groaned, steel bending as the entity surged again. It swept a clawed hand through the air, and the monitors burst into rivers of black static. Equations bled down the walls like liquid, twisting into grotesque symbols that dripped onto the floor and hissed.

Kanvi screamed as the symbols crawled toward her shoes like living things. Akki pulled her back, his tall form towering over her, his arms wrapping around her small body in a protective cage.

The shadow hissed.
“She does not belong. She must vanish.”

Akki’s roar shook the collapsing room.
“Over my dead body!”

The entity slashed forward again, faster than before.

But this time, Akki was ready.

He lunged sideways, pulling Kanvi with him, their bodies tumbling behind the half-broken capsule. They hit the floor hard, Kanvi’s breath knocked from her chest as she clung to him, her gorgeous face buried against his shirt.

The shadow’s claws carved through the capsule where Akki’s head had been seconds earlier, splitting the steel like paper.

Kanvi’s wide eyes darted up at him, terrified. “Akki, we can’t outrun it—”

He cupped her cheek with a trembling hand, forcing a calmness he didn’t feel. His thumb brushed her tear-stained skin, his voice low and fierce.
“Stay with me. Stay with me. That’s all I need.”

She nodded frantically, her tears spilling faster. “Always.”

But the entity wasn’t done.

It reared back, the lab lights exploding in bursts of sparks. For a moment, everything went dark except for the glow of its form—black static edged with fire. It raised its claws high, and the ground itself split beneath them, cracking into glowing veins of blood-red light.

Kanvi clutched his shirt, her voice breaking.
"Akki… I think this is the hour. The one it warned about… The Vanishing Hour."

His sharp eyes narrowed, rage and determination blazing. He pulled her small frame tighter against him, his own heartbeat hammering against her ear.

"Then let it come. I'll burn the hour itself before I let it take you."

And as the entity lunged again, the lab shattered into fractured time.

The Fractured Time

The shadow's claws descended—

But instead of hitting them, the world stopped.

Not slowed. Not hesitated. Stopped.

The falling sparks froze midair, each droplet of light suspended like fireflies trapped in amber. Shattered glass hung between them, reflecting their faces a hundred times. Even the blood-red cracks in the floor stopped glowing mid-pulse, like a vein cut off from its heart.

Kanvi gasped—then went silent.

Akki turned sharply to her.

Her small frame stood frozen, her wide eyes locked in terror, her lips parted around an unfinished word. She didn't blink. She didn't breathe. She was a statue of flesh and fear.

"Kanvi…" His voice cracked. He shook her shoulders, but her gorgeous face didn't move. No sound left her throat.

Panic surged through him, but then he heard it—

A whisper.

From the shadows.

"The Vanishing Hour begins. Only one mind may move. Only one may fight. Only one may choose."

Akki's chest rose and fell in sharp bursts. His sharp eyes darted across the frozen room. Everything was still—except the entity.

The shadow's jagged form slithered forward, its edges flickering between darkness and broken light. Its hollow face stretched into a grin, like someone had carved a smile into static.

"Why her?" Akki's voice was raw, desperate, and furious. "Why freeze her?"

The shadow's voice hissed inside his skull.
"Because she is the choice. She cannot act. You must act. Decide who vanishes."

Akki's fists clenched until his knuckles bled. His tall frame trembled with rage. "You think I'd choose her? You think I'd ever let her go?"

The shadow tilted its head, as if amused.
"Then give yourself. Surrender your reality. She will remain. And you… will vanish."

The words dug into him, tearing at his chest.

Images flickered across the frozen lab—visions forced into his mind:

Kanvi in her white coat, older, standing strong as a doctor, saving lives.

Kanvi alone, weeping, clutching a photograph of him.

Kanvi with another man, smiling faintly, but her eyes never truly alight.

Kanvi is broken, lost, staring into an abyss that never ends.

Each vision was a dagger.

His jaw clenched, breath ragged. His mind screamed that maybe… maybe if he gave himself up, at least she would live. At least she would have a chance.

But then he looked at her frozen form—her delicate face, small body trembling in fear, lips parted as if she was about to beg him not to do it.

And he knew.

If he left her, he'd destroy her.

Not the entity. Not the recursion. Him.

He faced the shadow again, his sharp eyes blazing.

“You want my life? My reality? Fine. But you don’t get her. Ever.”

The shadow shrieked, its claws slicing through the frozen sparks, shattering them into shards of light.

“Then prove it. Fight me in the fracture.”

The room warped.

Akki staggered as the floor stretched into infinity, walls tearing into a void filled with mirrors of himself and Kanvi. Each reflection showed a different version: happy, broken, together, apart.

The shadow lunged.

Akki roared and charged, his tall frame blazing with raw willpower. His fists struck, his body moving faster than physics should allow. Each hit shook the frozen world, sparks exploding into trails of light.

But the shadow wasn’t flesh. His punches tore through smoke and static. The claws struck back, raking across his chest, leaving burning trails of black fire.

He stumbled, pain searing through him, but his teeth clenched against the scream. His eyes never left Kanvi. Even frozen, she was his anchor. His reason.

The shadow’s whisper came again, sharper now:
“Why fight? End the pain. Give yourself. Let her live.”

Akki spat blood, his sharp jaw defiant.
“I don’t trust you. And she doesn’t need to live. She needs to live with me.”

His body blurred with motion as he hurled himself back into the fight, claws and fists clashing in a storm of light and shadow.

The frozen hour cracked, trembling on the edge of breaking.
And for one impossible second—Kanvi’s lips moved.
Just a whisper.

“Akki…”

Akki v/s. the Shadow

The fracture groaned like the ribs of the universe breaking.

Akki stood, chest heaving, blood dripping from shallow cuts that burned with unnatural fire. His tall frame shone faintly, threads of golden light wrapping his arms and shoulders as if his will itself had become armor.

The shadow loomed opposite him. It stretched taller now, mirroring Akki's stance, jaw sharp, fists clenched. But its eyes—two hollow voids—mocked him.

Kanvi's frozen body shimmered faintly in the background, caught between versions of herself: child Kanvi in uniform clutching notebooks, teenage Kanvi with books hugged to her chest, doctor Kanvi in her white coat, future Kanvi older and broken. Each image flickered like a slideshow of fates waiting to collapse.

The shadow's voice split the air:
"You cannot fight me. I am everything you fear. Everything you've lost. Every path that ends in failure."

Akki spat blood to the side, his sharp jaw clenched.
"Then I'll break every one of those paths."

He lunged.

His fist met the shadow's chest, not with the dull thud of flesh, but with a crack of thunder. Sparks and shards of frozen time exploded outward, cascading like glass across the void.

The shadow staggered but reformed instantly, claws slashing back. One tore across Akki's shoulder, spraying light instead of blood. He grimaced, but instead of falling back, he pushed forward, head-butting the entity with brutal force.

The impact split the void, mirrors around them shattering. For a moment, he saw himself—an older Akki, alone, broken. He snarled and shattered it with another blow.

But the shadow was relentless.

It circled him, splitting into two, then three, then six silhouettes, each one a twisted reflection of him. They spoke in unison, voices like echoes layered upon echoes.
"You will vanish. She will remain. The hour demands it."

Akki's sharp eyes burned with fury. His voice thundered back.
"Then screw the hour. I make my own time."

He struck. One clone burst into static. Then another. Then two clawed him at once, raking his chest and ribs. Pain tore through him. He stumbled, blood and light dripping down his torso.

But then—he heard it.

A whisper, faint but real.

"Akki…"

Kanvi's lips had moved. Just a single syllable. Frozen or not, she was still with him.

His heart surged, raw and wild. His body roared with renewed power.

Akki grabbed one clone by the throat, lifting it high, snarling into its hollow face.
"She believes in me. That's all I need."

He slammed the clone into the ground. It shattered like glass, light bursting upward.

The other shadows lunged together, claws flashing. Akki spun, his tall frame moving like fire itself, fists glowing with every punch. Each strike shattered fragments of the fracture: a school hallway collapsed, a hospital room vanished, a memory of them laughing under streetlights disintegrated.

The fight was chaotic—raw, brutal, infinite.

But Akki didn't slow.

The shadow regrouped, reforming into its true shape—taller than before, monstrous claws dripping with static.

It bellowed:
"You cannot defeat me. I am inevitable. When this hour ends, one of you will vanish."

Akki's chest rose and fell with ragged breaths. He bled, he shook, but his sharp eyes locked onto Kanvi's frozen face—tears glistening on her cheeks, even suspended in time.

His voice broke, raw but unshakable:
"Then it won't be her. It'll never be her. I'll burn the entire world before I let you take her away."

And with a roar that cracked the fractured reality itself, he charged again—

The Emotional Climax

The fracture screamed.

For a moment, Akki thought the world itself was collapsing—but then he realized it wasn't the world, it was time. The frozen sparks around him jolted, then fell. The glass shards rained to the floor. The blood-red cracks pulsed again.

And Kanvi—

She moved.

Her small frame lurched forward, staggering as if gravity had just returned. Her wide eyes locked on him instantly. “Akki!”

He almost dropped to his knees at the sound of her voice. His tall frame stumbled toward her, ignoring the searing pain in his chest, the blood-light dripping from his wounds. He reached her, pulling her small body into his arms so tightly it hurt.

Her gorgeous face pressed into his chest, her sobs tearing out of her throat. “I thought you were gone—I thought I’d lost you—”

His sharp jaw trembled as he buried his face in her hair, inhaling her scent like it was the only oxygen left. His voice cracked. “Never. I’ll never leave you.”

But the shadow wasn’t gone.

It rose again, enormous now, blotting out the fractured ceiling, claws stretching wider than doors. Its hollow voice thundered, shaking the lab with its command:

“The Vanishing Hour ends. One must remain. One must vanish.”

The words slammed into them like hammers.

Kanvi’s trembling hands clutched at his shirt, her tears soaking the fabric. She looked up at him, her lips shaking. “Akki… it’s me. It wants me. If I stay, you’ll live. Let me go—”

His heart tore in half. He grabbed her chin, forcing her to look at him, his sharp eyes blazing through tears. His voice was raw, fierce.
“Don’t you ever say that again. You think I’ll live if you vanish? You think I’ll breathe if you’re gone? No. If one of us has to go—it’ll be me.”

Her wide eyes blurred with more tears. She shook her head violently, sobbing. “No! Don’t you dare, Akki! I can’t live without you. I won’t live without you!”

Their foreheads pressed together, both trembling, both on the edge of breaking. Their breaths mingled, hot and ragged. His blood dripped onto her hand where it clutched his chest. Her tears slid down to his collarbone.

The shadow hissed louder, furious, as if their bond itself defied its law.

“Choose! Or both shall be destroyed!”

Kanvi's lips trembled, and then she whispered, broken but clear:
"Then let us be destroyed together."

Akki's heart shattered at her words—but also ignited. He crushed her closer, his tall frame wrapping around her, his voice a vow that shook even the void:
"Then that's how it will be. If we vanish, we vanish as one."

The entity shrieked, its claws slamming into the ground, splitting the fractured lab into deeper chaos. Memories shattered around them—Kanvi laughing as a schoolgirl, Akki working in his lab, the two of them walking under the stars. Every memory cracked and bled.

But in the center of the storm—they held each other, refusing to let go.

Kanvi tilted her gorgeous face upward, tears glistening. Her lips quivered, but this time, they carried no fear. Only a desperate, infinite love.

"I love you, Akki."

His sharp jaw trembled. He cupped her face in his bloodied hands, eyes blazing. His whisper was hoarse, breaking, but absolute.
"I love you, Kanvi. More than my life. More than this world."

The shadow's roar swallowed everything—light, sound, and air.

And the hour reached its breaking point.

The Forced Separation

The roar of the shadow split the air like a thousand storms colliding.

Kanvi clung to Akki, her small frame trembling violently, her gorgeous face wet with tears. His tall frame bent around her, arms locked tight as though he could shield her from the universe itself. Their foreheads pressed together, both whispering the same vow:

"Together. Always together."

The shadow loomed above them, claws stretching, black light dripping like liquid fire. Its hollow voice thundered across the fracture:

"Then I shall decide. You shall not vanish together. You shall be torn apart."

The ground beneath them split.

The lab shattered like a mirror dropped from the heavens. One half cracked beneath Kanvi's feet, the other beneath Akki's. Red light bled from the fractures, crawling up their legs like chains.

Kanvi screamed, clutching tighter at his shirt.
"Akki—no—don't let go—!"

His sharp jaw clenched, his voice a growl of rage and desperation.
"Never! I'll hold you through hell itself!"

They gripped each other's hands, fingers entwined so tightly their knuckles turned white, nails digging into skin. Their eyes locked, burning through the chaos.

The shadow's claws struck down.

Invisible force ripped through them, wrenching their bodies apart. Kanvi screamed as her feet slid backward across the cracking floor, dragging her toward the gaping void. Akki roared, pulling with all his strength, his muscles straining, blood dripping from reopened wounds.

"AKKI!"

"KANVI!"

The sound of their names broke the frozen time itself.

For one agonizing moment, their fingertips were still connected.

The world slowed. Their eyes met—hers wide, terrified, but blazing with love; his sharp, fierce, but breaking inside.

"Don't let go," she whispered, her lips trembling.

His voice cracked, his jaw quivering as he forced the words past the burn in his throat.
"Never."

But the entity's power was absolute.

The claws sliced between them like a blade of eternity.

Their hands slipped apart.

Kanvi's scream ripped through the collapsing lab, raw and devastating:
"AKKIIII!"

His roar followed, shaking the void:

“KANVII!”

The light devoured her.

Her small frame was dragged into the abyss, her gorgeous face disappearing into blinding white. His tall frame lunged forward, muscles tearing, throat shredding with his scream—but the void swallowed her whole.

Silence crashed down.

Akki fell to his knees, chest heaving, his fists slamming the fractured ground. The lab was gone. The machines are dead. The capsule beside him—empty.

The only sound left was his own ragged breathing and the echo of her voice in his skull.

And for the first time, Akki felt it—
A hollow so vast it could devour even him.

Loss.

XX.
Between Time And Truth

Awakening in the First Layer

Akki's awareness returned like shards of glass being pushed into his skull. There was no gentle rise into consciousness—only a jolt, like being slammed into existence.

He gasped, and the sound of his breath echoed too loudly, bouncing back at him as though the void itself had swallowed his lungs. He staggered upright, his tall frame stiff, every muscle screaming that it shouldn't even be possible to move.

And then he saw it.

White.

Endless white, stretching farther than his sharp eyes could follow. Not the white of a ceiling or the sterile glow of lab lights. This was deeper. A suffocating, blank white that felt like standing in the middle of nothingness before creation itself.

Akki turned slowly, his boots scraping against something solid. He looked down.

Glass.

Not ordinary glass, but an infinite sheet of reflective surface. It was polished so perfectly that his own reflection looked like a stranger beneath his feet. He took one careful step, and the reflection rippled—not like water, but like memory.

And in that ripple, he saw her.

Kanvi.

The reflection showed her in fragments—childhood Kanvi running down a school hallway, hair bouncing, tiny frame clutching books too heavy for her arms. Another shard revealed teenage Kanvi, lost in her notebooks, gorgeous eyes glowing with determination. Another shimmer showed the present Kanvi, in her white coat, exhausted, fragile, but burning with purpose.

And the last shard—
Kanvi screaming his name, her small hand torn away from him as the shadow dragged her into oblivion.

His sharp jaw locked. A muscle twitched in his cheek. His fists clenched until his knuckles turned white. "Kanvi…"

The whisper broke something inside him.

The ground cracked faintly under his boots, as though his desperation alone shook the void. Splinters of reflection spread outward, multiplying the Kanvis until the glass beneath him was filled with her faces—smiling, crying, broken, hopeful. He staggered, dizzy, as though the weight of all those versions threatened to pull him down.

And then—

“Akki.”

He froze. His heart stopped.

It wasn’t an echo.

Slowly—painfully—he turned.

She stood there.

Kanvi.

Her small frame quivered, shoulders tight, her fingers clutching the edges of her white coat as if it was the only anchor she had. Her gorgeous eyes were wide, shimmering, already filled with unshed tears. Her lips parted, trembling.

“Akki… is it really you?”

For a moment, the world tilted. He couldn’t breathe. I couldn't think. His sharp eyes blurred, his tall frame shaking with something rawer than pain.

He moved.

In three desperate strides, he reached her. His arms went around her instantly, crushing her against him so tightly his chest burned. She gasped, her face burying into his shirt, her small hands fisting his back with desperate strength.

Her sobs broke, muffled against him. “I thought you were gone—I thought—”

His throat constricted. He pressed his cheek into her hair, his sharp jaw trembling against her temple. His voice cracked, rough and low.
“Never. You hear me? Never.”

Her tears soaked through his shirt. He felt each drop like fire on his skin. His heartbeat slammed against her small body, fast and unsteady. He tilted her chin up gently, forcing her gorgeous eyes to meet his.

“You’re here. With me. Alive.” His voice shook, steel wrapped in glass. “That’s all that matters.”

Her lips quivered, her breath uneven. “But… this place…”

And then it began.

The ground shivered.

Cracks ran across the glass, spiderwebbing outward. The reflections beneath them rippled violently. Some Kanvis in the shards smiled brighter, others screamed louder, some reached upward with blood-stained hands.

Kanvi gasped, clutching his shirt tighter. Her body trembled against him. “Akki… this isn’t real, is it?”

His arms tightened like iron, pulling her flush against his chest, his tall frame shielding her small one. His sharp eyes blazed, staring down the cracking world itself. His whisper was raw steel, laced with desperate love.

“I don’t care if it’s real or not. As long as I have you in it—I’ll make it real.”

Her tears spilled, rolling down her cheeks, but she nodded against him, her lips brushing the edge of his jaw. “Then don’t let me go.”

The ground split wider. Red light bled through the cracks, rising like fire. The whiteness above darkened at the edges, black stains spreading across the canvas. The reflections beneath shattered into sharper shards, Kanvi’s faces screaming silently from every direction.

She looked up at him again, her gorgeous eyes reflecting the fire. “Akki… what happens if it all breaks?”

He pulled her even closer, his hand on the back of her head, his lips brushing her hairline as he whispered fiercely, “Then let it break. Wherever we fall—I’ll catch you.”

The glass gave way.

And together—they plunged into darkness.

The Second Layer: The School That Wasn’t

Akki’s boots slammed against hard ground. The void of falling ended with a jarring impact that rattled his bones. His sharp eyes snapped open—and for a fleeting moment, he thought he had woken in reality.

The hallway stretched endlessly in front of him. A school hallway.

Dim fluorescent tubes buzzed overhead, their pale light flickering. The floor was tiled, scuffed with years of footsteps. Lockers lined both sides, painted in dull green, their metal dented from restless students long ago. The faint smell of chalk and paper hung in the air.

Akki froze. His sharp jaw clenched.
He knew this place.

"Akki…" Kanvi's voice came from behind him, trembling.

He turned—and his breath caught.

She stood with wide, shimmering eyes, her small frame shaking, one hand pressed against her lips. Her voice was soft, almost a whisper:
"This… this is our school."

His chest tightened. He scanned the walls. Posters hung loosely—math competitions, science exhibitions, faded photographs of smiling students. His throat ached as he realized: they weren't strangers. They were them.

One poster showed a young Akki—barely sixteen, tall even then, holding a model of a particle accelerator. Another showed Kanvi, petite in her uniform, gorgeous even in her shy smile, holding a first-prize trophy for biology.

Kanvi walked slowly, her small fingers brushing the paper. Her lips quivered. "I… I remember this day. You were so arrogant. You told me I'd never beat you in the finals."

Despite the heaviness pressing down on him, a faint smile ghosted Akki's lips. "And you proved me wrong, remember? You walked up on stage, all five feet of fury, and crushed me in front of the judges."

Her cheeks reddened slightly even here, even in this unreal place. "You let me win."

His sharp eyes softened as he reached for her hand, his tall frame bending slightly to meet her gaze. "I would never let you win. You earned it."

For a moment, they both smiled. For a moment, the weight lifted.

But then—

The lights flickered.

A buzzing sound grew louder, echoing unnaturally through the hallway. The posters trembled against the walls, the images warping. The young Akki in the photograph turned his head—slowly, unnaturally—until his hollow eyes stared directly at them.

Kanvi gasped, clutching Akki's sleeve.

The young Kanvi in the photo smiled wider—too wide—until her lips tore across her face.

The hallway groaned. Lockers began to rattle, their metal doors slamming open and shut. Shadows oozed out from inside them, spilling onto the tiles like thick tar.

Kanvi's gorgeous eyes brimmed with panic. "Akki… this isn't our school."

His sharp jaw clenched. He pulled her close against his side, shielding her with his tall frame. His voice was hard, commanding:
"No. It's a trick. A layer."

The shadows twisted upward, forming into shapes—grotesque versions of themselves.

There was another Akki—tall, but hollow-eyed, his sharp jaw slack, his hands dripping black liquid. He staggered forward with jerking steps, whispering in static:
"You should have left her…"

Another Kanvi appeared—tiny, trembling, her gorgeous face cracked like porcelain, tears of ink streaming down her cheeks. She whispered:
"You can't save me."

Kanvi whimpered softly, burying her face into Akki's chest. Her small hands clung to his shirt as if he was the only real thing left.

He wrapped his arms around her, glaring at the shadows, rage igniting in his chest. His voice roared through the collapsing hall:
"You're not her. You'll never be her."

The shadow-Akki lunged, the shadow-Kanvi shrieked. The lockers burst open, vomiting more distorted memories. Equations scribbled on classroom boards peeled off, slithering across the floor like black serpents.

Kanvi cried out as one wrapped around her ankle. Akki dropped instantly, his large hand tearing the shadow apart with brute force. He lifted her into his arms, her small body trembling against him.

"Hold on to me." His voice was raw steel. "No matter what you see—hold on."

She buried her face in his neck, her muffled whisper soaked in fear and love. "I trust you. Always."

The ceiling split. The hallway cracked. The posters burned into ash.

And as the shadows lunged, the world shattered around them.

The Hospital Layer: The Body That Shouldn't Be

The world collapsed again.

Akki felt his tall frame dragged downward, like gravity itself had turned into a whirlpool. He clutched Kanvi against his chest, shielding her small trembling body as both of them plummeted into the void.

And then—impact.

Cold air. Sharp, chemical, suffocating.

He staggered to his feet, gasping, his sharp eyes scanning the surroundings.

White curtains hung from ceiling rails, swaying slightly. The smell of antiseptic clung to his throat. Dim monitors beeped—slow, irregular, broken rhythms. The floor gleamed too clean, reflecting distorted silhouettes.

Kanvi's gorgeous eyes widened instantly. Her lips parted, breath hitching in her throat.
"This… this is a hospital."

Her small hand tightened around his arm. She knew. They both knew.

Akki's sharp jaw clenched as he pulled her close. "Stay with me. This is another layer. Just another trick."

But then—

A faint sound.

A flatline beep.

Akki turned sharply. And froze.

There—across the curtain—lay a bed. White sheets tucked neatly. Machines lined beside it. Wires trailed into the body of a young woman. Pale. Still.

Kanvi.

The Kanvi in his arms stiffened. Her gorgeous face drained of color as she staggered forward, dragging him with her. Her small hands trembled violently as she clutched the curtain, ripping it aside.

"No…"

On the bed, Kanvi lay motionless. Her skin was waxed, her lips faintly blue. The monitor beside her showed a flatline.

The real Kanvi gasped, collapsing to her knees. Her voice was broken, raw. “That’s me—Akki, that’s me!”

He dropped down beside her instantly, his tall frame shielding her. His arms wrapped tight around her shaking shoulders, dragging her small body against his chest.

“Look at me,” he whispered fiercely, tilting her face up. His sharp eyes blazed, his jaw tight with fury. “You’re here. With me. Alive. Gorgeous. Breathing.”

She shook her head, tears spilling. “But what if this is the truth? What if I’m already—”

“Don’t.” His voice cracked, rougher than he intended. He pressed his forehead to hers, gripping her face with trembling hands. “Don’t say it. You are not that body. You’re Kanvi. My Kanvi. And I swear I’ll burn this whole place down before I let it take you.”

But then—the body on the bed twitched.

Both of them froze.

The monitor let out a broken screech. The corpse Kanvi’s head jerked sideways, her hollow eyes snapping open. Empty. Black.

Her lips cracked into a whisper—static and chilling:
“Only one of us belongs here.”

The machines screamed louder, wires writhing like serpents, reaching toward them. The hospital lights flickered, turning red. Curtains tore themselves apart, whipping like ghostly hands.

Kanvi screamed, clutching Akki tighter, burying her face in his chest. Her muffled sob shook through him. “Akki—I can’t—please—”

He lifted her into his arms, his tall frame straining as he shielded her from the writhing wires. His roar tore through the chaos:
“You’re mine. And I’m not letting anything take you.”

The corpse Kanvi lunged, her hollow eyes glowing.

The floor cracked beneath them. Alarms wailed. The hospital dissolved into shards of light.

And once again—the world collapsed.

The Mirror Trap: A Thousand Truths

The fall ended with silence.

No crash, no echo, just the soft thud of boots against polished stone. Akki blinked rapidly, sharp eyes straining to adjust. His tall frame straightened, instinctively pulling Kanvi close, his arm wrapped protectively around her shoulders.

Then he realized where they were.

Mirrors.

Endless mirrors, rising like walls on all sides, stretching upward into infinity. Each mirror reflected not just their present selves—but versions. Distorted, fractured, some too real.

Kanvi's gorgeous eyes widened, her lips trembling. "What… is this place?"

Akki's jaw tightened. His reflection stared back at him, but the eyes weren't his. They were cold. Lifeless.

He turned to another mirror.

This time, the reflection showed him holding Kanvi's lifeless body in his arms, his face hollow with despair.

His stomach lurched.

Kanvi stumbled closer to a mirror of her own. She froze. Her reflection showed her smiling, radiant in a wedding dress, Akki standing beside her, taller than everyone else, his sharp eyes soft for once. Tears filled her real eyes instantly. Her small hand lifted, trembling, as though reaching toward that impossible image.

"Akki… it's us," she whispered. Her voice cracked. "Our future…"

But then—the image warped.

The wedding dress bled black, the smile twisted. Akki's reflection in that mirror turned away from her, his tall frame walking into shadows, leaving her alone on the altar.

Kanvi gasped, stumbling back. "No…"

Akki caught her, his strong arms wrapping around her tiny waist. He pulled her tight against his chest, his voice rough. "Don't look. It's a lie. All of it."

But even as he said it, he turned—and froze.

One mirror showed him. Alone. Surrounded by machines. His sharp jaw sunken, his hair grey, his eyes hollow. No Kanvi. Not anywhere.

His throat closed. His chest burned.

Kanvi noticed his silence. She looked up at him, tears shimmering. “What did you see?”

He clenched his fists, veins standing out on his arms, his sharp jaw trembling. He couldn’t tell her. He wouldn’t. So he dragged her closer, pressing her small body against him, whispering harshly against her hair:
“It doesn’t matter. You’re here. With me. That’s all I’ll ever need.”

The mirrors shimmered—changing again.

Now dozens of Akki and Kanvi filled the walls. Some smiling, some dead, some twisted, some strangers. Their voices whispered in chorus, overlapping:

“One of these is the truth. One is the end.”

Kanvi’s gorgeous face tilted upward, pale with fear. “Akki… what if they’re right? What if one of these… is us?”

He glared at the mirrors, fury blazing in his sharp eyes. His voice was a growl.
“Then I’ll break every last one until only our truth remains.”

And with a roar, his fist smashed into the nearest mirror.

The glass didn’t shatter normally. It exploded outward like liquid silver, cascading across the floor, crawling up their legs like vines. The reflections screamed, a thousand Kanvis and Akkis clawing from inside the mirrors, trying to drag them in.

Kanvi shrieked, clutching his shirt desperately. “Akki!”

He crushed her to him, lifting her small body off the ground as the silver tried to consume them both. His jaw set like steel, his arms locked around her as if nothing could tear her away.

The whispers grew louder, echoing in their skulls:
“Choose the truth. Or be lost in all.”

And then—everything froze.

The mirrors turned black. Every reflection is gone.

Only silence remained.

And in that silence—a voice. Cold. Ancient. Familiar.

“So. You’ve made it this far.”

The Entity’s Ultimatum

The silence pressed down on them like a weight. The mirrors—once alive with twisted reflections—now stood black and empty, stretching endlessly into the void.

Akki’s sharp eyes darted across the space, his tall frame instinctively pulling Kanvi behind him, his hand gripping hers tightly. Her small fingers trembled inside his, but she refused to let go.

Then—the voice came again.

Low. Echoing. Everywhere and nowhere.

“Two hearts. One truth. Only one survives.”

Kanvi’s gorgeous eyes widened, her lips trembling as she whispered, “It’s here…”

From the darkness ahead, something stirred.

The shadows condensed, folding into themselves until a figure emerged. It was tall, almost Akki’s height, draped in shifting darkness. Its face was featureless, but its outline flickered between forms—sometimes Akki, sometimes Kanvi, sometimes both.

Akki stepped forward, fury blazing in his eyes. His sharp jaw clenched as he roared into the emptiness:
“Show yourself properly, coward!”

The entity tilted its faceless head, voice dripping like oil.
“I already wear your face. I am your fear. Your failure. Your truth.”

The black mirrors flickered, lighting up again. One showed Kanvi lying lifeless on the hospital bed. Another showed Akki alone in a sterile lab, aged and broken. Another—worse than all—showed them together, but Kanvi turned her back, walking away, leaving Akki’s tall frame trembling in despair.

Kanvi gasped, clutching Akki’s sleeve tighter. “Akki… don’t look—please don’t look.”

But he did. And rage burned deeper.

He turned, gripping her shoulders, forcing her gorgeous tear-filled eyes to meet his. “Listen to me. None of these are us. None of these are real.”

The entity’s voice slithered around them.
“One is real. You just don’t want to see it. But you’ll have to choose… or I will.”

The mirrors began to close in, circling them. The ground vibrated beneath their feet.

Kanvi’s small body trembled, her tears spilling down her cheeks. Her voice cracked. “What if… what if it’s true, Akki? What if one of these is what’s waiting for us?”

His heart broke at her fear, but he crushed her against him, his tall frame enveloping her completely. His lips brushed her ear as he whispered fiercely:
“Then I’ll rewrite it. Even if every truth is against us—I’ll make a new one.”

Her small hands clutched his shirt tightly, her voice muffled in his chest. “I don’t want to lose you.”

He tilted her chin up, his forehead pressing against hers. His voice was rough steel, his breath trembling. “You won’t. Not now. Not ever.”

The entity laughed, the sound like glass shattering.
“Such pretty words. But one of you must break. Which will it be?”

The mirrors surged, shadows clawing outward. Hands of black glass reached for Kanvi, their fingers brushing her arms. She cried out, clinging tighter to Akki.

His fury exploded. His roar tore through the darkness:
“You want the truth? Here it is—SHE. IS. MINE!”

A violent surge burst from him—an impossible shockwave of light ripping outward. Mirrors cracked, shadows shrieked. The entity staggered back, its form flickering violently.

Kanvi gasped, staring at him, her gorgeous eyes wide. “Akki… what did you—”

He breathed heavily, his sharp eyes blazing with something primal. He pulled her face to his, his voice shaking.
“I don’t care what power this place has. I don’t care what truth it demands. The only truth I’ll ever accept… is you and me. Together.”

The entity screeched, recoiling as the mirrors shattered completely, shards flying outward like stars.

Kanvi clutched his face in her small hands, her lips trembling as she whispered, “Then promise me. No matter what comes… you’ll never let go.”

He leaned his tall frame down, pressing his forehead to hers, his voice breaking as he whispered the vow: “Never. Even if the world itself falls apart—I’ll find you.”

The mirrors imploded. The entity dissolved into shrieks. The floor beneath them split open—again.

And hand in hand, they fell into the next layer.

XXI.
The Silent Rescue

The Cold Chamber

Akki's eyes snapped open to a place colder than death.

Steel.

The walls curved into an oval dome, sleek and silver, lined with wires pulsing faint blue. Transparent tubes ran across the ceiling like veins, carrying glowing liquid that hummed softly. The floor beneath him wasn't solid stone or glass anymore—it was reinforced metal, humming faintly with a low vibration.

Kanvi was still in his arms, her small body trembling as she clung to him. Her gorgeous eyes blinked open slowly, confusion etched across her face.

"Where are we?" she whispered, her voice fragile.

Akki looked around, his sharp eyes catching the faint flicker of holograms along the walls—schematics, waveforms, equations floating midair. A chill raced down his spine. His tall frame stiffened.
"This… is my lab."

Kanvi gasped, stepping back slightly. Her small hand clutched his sleeve, her lips quivering. "Your… lab? But—Akki, this doesn't look like the one we built. This looks… wrong."

And she was right.

It was his lab—but not. Machines were twisted, darker, more brutal in design. Wires dangled like nooses, red warning lights pulsed faintly. The AI console flickered, showing static images of Kanvi—laughing, crying, screaming—on loop.

Akki's jaw tightened, a muscle ticking in his cheek.
"This isn't mine. It's a copy. A trap."

Kanvi's gorgeous eyes filled with dread as she stepped closer to him. Her small fingers slipped into his large hand, clinging tight. "If it's a trap… why does it feel so real?"

The machines hummed louder, as if responding to her fear. Screens lit up, projecting EEG patterns, brainwave spikes, heart monitors—all showing her vitals. Some are flatlined. Some spiked chaotically. Some froze the midwave.

Akki's sharp eyes burned as he scanned the data. His voice was low, but urgent.
"They're trying to rewrite your signal. Your dream-state recursion is unstable."

Kanvi frowned, confusion mixing with panic. "What does that mean?"

He turned to her, gripping her shoulders firmly, his tall frame towering but his gaze desperate.

“It means if I don’t stabilize you—your body will think you’re already gone.”

Her breath hitched. Her gorgeous lips parted in horror. “Akki—”

But before she could finish, the AI voice chimed, hollow and soulless:

“Rescue protocol: one must overwrite the other. Choose.”

The dome darkened. Machines whirred alive. Two pods rose from the floor—one marked Subject A, the other Subject B.

Kanvi’s small body froze, her eyes locking on the pods. She understood instantly.
“They want us to… overwrite each other? Akki, if you step in—”

He cut her off, his sharp jaw set, voice like steel. “Then I’ll overwrite myself to save you.”

Her tears spilled instantly. She shook her head violently, clutching his shirt. “No! Don’t you dare! Akki, I’d rather be lost than live without you—don’t—”

He silenced her with a sudden, fierce pull, crushing her against his chest. His tall frame shook, his breath ragged against her hair. His whisper cracked with raw emotion.
“Kanvi… I can’t lose you. Not again. I’ll use every machine, every line of code, every drop of blood I have—but I will rescue you. Even if it destroys me.”

Kanvi sobbed, burying her face into his shirt. Her muffled voice trembled, “Then let me fight with you. Don’t carry this alone.”

The machines glowed brighter. The pods opened with a hiss. The choice loomed.

And Akki knew—this was only the beginning.

The Neural Bridge

The pods hissed, releasing trails of white vapor into the air. Blue lights flickered across the curved dome, illuminating every wire, every circuit like veins under transparent skin.

Akki’s sharp eyes locked onto the console, scanning the shifting waveforms. His tall frame stiffened.
“Your signal’s fragmenting faster. We don’t have time.”

Kanvi stood beside him, her small frame trembling, her gorgeous eyes darting nervously between the pods. “Tell me what you’re going to do.”

He exhaled sharply, his jaw clenched, hands flying over the holographic keyboard. Neural maps filled the air—Kanvi's brainwave frequencies on one side, his on the other. Both pulsed erratically, like twin hearts out of rhythm.

"I'll build a neural bridge." His voice was calm, precise, but his heart thundered. "If I synchronize my brainwaves with yours, I can stabilize your recursion."

Kanvi's lips parted, trembling. "That means…"

His eyes softened for just a moment as he looked at her. "That means I'll be inside your dreams. Your thoughts. Your fears. Everything."

Her breath caught.

For a second, she forgot the machines, the threat, the entity. All she saw was him—tall, steady, his sharp eyes blazing with determination, yet hiding a fragility only she could see.

Her gorgeous face flushed faintly as she whispered, "You'll see everything I've ever hidden…"

He stepped closer, towering over her small frame, his voice low, rough. "I don't want your secrets. I just want you."

Her small hands trembled as she placed them against his chest, feeling the rapid hammer of his heartbeat. "And if syncing breaks you instead of saving me?"

He covered her hands with his larger ones, pressing them firmly against his chest. His sharp jaw tightened, but his voice broke through like fire.
"Then at least I'll go down fighting for you."

Her eyes shimmered with tears, her voice a soft plea. "Akki…"

Before the moment could stretch further, the AI cut through, cold and merciless:

"Warning. A neural bridge requires proximity beyond safety thresholds. Proceed?"

Akki turned back to the console, his sharp eyes blazing. "Proceed."

The floor vibrated. The pods lit up. Two headsets rose from their interiors—circular crowns of sleek metal, lined with glowing electrodes. The hum grew louder.

He turned to Kanvi. For the first time, his confident composure faltered. His voice dropped, softer, vulnerable.

“This will hurt. It’ll feel like burning. But don’t let go. No matter what happens, don’t break the connection.”

Kanvi’s gorgeous eyes locked onto him. She nodded once, small but firm. “I’ll hold on. Even if it kills me.”

Akki’s throat tightened. He wanted to say something—Don’t ever say that, don’t even think it—but instead he simply pulled her into him, burying his face in her hair, whispering fiercely:
“Stay with me, Kanvi. Stay alive with me.”

Her small arms wrapped around his tall frame, clutching as though she could fuse herself to him.
“Always.”

They stepped into the pods. The headsets descended, clicking into place over their temples.

The AI counted down:
“Bridge initiation in 3… 2… 1.”

Pain exploded.

A blinding surge of electricity shot through Akki’s veins. His sharp eyes slammed shut as his jaw locked, every muscle tensing. He gritted his teeth, forcing his mind forward.

Kanvi screamed softly, her small body convulsing in the other pod. Her gorgeous eyes rolled back, tears streaking down her cheeks as the current invaded her thoughts.

Then—something shifted.

Their signals flickered on the screens, once chaotic, now beginning to align. Waves overlapped, pulses syncing.

Akki’s vision blurred—until suddenly, there was no lab. No pod. No machines.

Only Kanvi.

She stood before him, trembling, her hair flowing in a phantom wind, her gorgeous eyes glowing faintly. Their surroundings were a void—but inside this void, their minds touched.

Her small hand lifted slowly, hesitantly, brushing his face. He felt it—warm, real, electric.

Her whisper echoed in his head, and in his heart.
“Akki… you’re here.”

His sharp jaw trembled as he pulled her against him, his arms locking her small body to his chest. His reply vibrated through both their minds, raw and unshakable.
“I told you. I’ll always find you.”

Their heartbeats synced. The bridge was alive.

And for the first time—the dream didn’t feel like a trap.

It felt like the truth.

The Interference: Breaking the Bridge

The bridge pulsed like a living artery, glowing veins of light weaving around Akki and Kanvi as their minds synchronized.

For a fleeting moment, everything was calm. Their heartbeats matched, their breaths aligned. Akki’s tall frame wrapped Kanvi’s small trembling body in his arms as though to guard her even in this void. Her gorgeous eyes locked onto his, shimmering with awe and disbelief.

But then—

The light flickered.

Kanvi’s small body stiffened. “Akki… something’s wrong.”

Akki’s sharp jaw clenched as his eyes darted upward. The glowing arcs above them shivered, glitching like broken holograms. Static rippled through the void, jagged cracks tearing across the bridge.

And then, the voice came.

Cold. Mocking. Everywhere.

“Did you think I would let you win so easily?”

The void quaked. From the cracks, black tendrils erupted, writhing serpents of shadow. They lashed toward the glowing bridge, hissing, tearing at the neural weave. Sparks exploded as light met darkness.

Akki growled, his tall frame shielding Kanvi. His sharp eyes blazed with fury. “Stay behind me!”

The shadows hissed louder. One tendril shot forward, wrapping around Kanvi’s wrist. She gasped, screaming, her small body yanked forward. Her gorgeous eyes filled with terror as she reached desperately for him. “Akki!”

His heart lurched, his blood boiling. With a roar, he lunged, seizing her hand. His larger palm swallowed hers, veins straining as he pulled her against the drag of the shadow. His sharp jaw trembled, teeth gritted. “They won’t take you from me!”

The entity’s voice slithered closer.
“The bridge is mine. One mind must collapse. Who will it be?”

Kanvi sobbed, clutching his arm with her free hand, her small fingers digging into his skin. “Akki—it’s pulling me—”

He yanked her closer, his tall frame shaking with effort. His face twisted in fury, but his words were steel. “No. I won’t let go. Do you hear me? Never.”

Her gorgeous face tilted up to him, eyes brimming with tears. In that moment—her fear gave way to something else. Resolve.

Her whisper trembled, soft but piercing:
“Then if we go down… we go down together.”

The shadows surged, attacking from all sides. They lashed across Akki’s back, slicing like knives. He hissed in pain but didn’t release her hand. His arms locked tighter, pressing her small body against his chest, shielding her even as his tall frame shook from the onslaught.

Blood trickled from the cuts across his shoulders, glowing faintly in this strange plane. Kanvi gasped at the sight, her tears falling fast. Her trembling hands lifted, cupping his face, forcing his blazing eyes to meet hers.

Her lips quivered. “Fight with me. Don’t fight alone.”

Their foreheads touched. Their breaths mingled.

And then—her pulse surged.

From Kanvi’s small frame, light erupted. Pure, radiant, golden. It flared outward, wrapping around Akki’s body, weaving into the bridge itself. The tendrils screamed as the light burned them away, dissolving shadow after shadow.

The entity shrieked, furious.
“Impossible. Her signal was collapsing—she cannot fight!”

But Kanvi’s gorgeous eyes glowed now, her voice fierce through the tears.
“You don’t get to decide my end. We decide it. Together.”

Akki's chest heaved, his sharp jaw trembling as pride, awe, and love collided in his heart. He crushed her lips with his in a desperate, searing kiss—fire meeting fire as their souls locked tighter.

The bridge blazed.

Their brainwaves synced perfectly, intertwining like threads of light. The void shook, the entity's scream fading into static.

And then—silence.

Only the two of them remained, locked in each other's arms, the glow of the bridge wrapping them like destiny itself.

The Silent Rescue: Between Breath and Silence

The golden flare that Kanvi had released flickered… then dimmed.

Akki tightened his hold around her, panic searing his chest. "Kanvi? Kanvi!"

Her gorgeous eyes fluttered, her small body trembling violently against his tall frame. She tried to speak, but her lips barely moved. "It's… too much… my signal… fading—"

The bridge pulsed erratically. Their synchronized brainwaves splintered into fragments, glitching across the floating holographic readouts. Alarms screamed in the background.

AI SYSTEM ALERT:

Warning. Subject B's signal dropping below critical threshold.
Override required. Neural bridge unstable.

Akki's sharp jaw locked. His heart pounded so hard it felt like his chest would split open. "No. No, stay with me."

Her small hand lifted weakly, brushing his cheek. Her gorgeous face, pale and strained, still tried to smile. "You've already given me more than I dreamed… don't fight the inevitable…"

His fury exploded. He seized her hand, crushing it to his chest where his heart thundered. His sharp eyes blazed with fire.
"Don't you dare. Don't you ever talk like that. You're not inevitable—you're mine. And I won't lose what's mine."

The AI voice cut in, colder than death:
"Solution: Transfer majority of Subject A's cognitive load to stabilize Subject B. Probability of Subject A's collapse: 87%."

Kanvi's gorgeous eyes widened instantly. She shook her head desperately, her small fingers clutching his shirt. "No! Akki, that means you'll—"

But he silenced her with a rough, trembling whisper, forehead pressed hard against hers.
"Kanvi… I'm a scientist. Risks are what I was born for. But you—" his voice cracked, raw, "you're my reason. I won't let the world, or fate, or some goddamn machine take you away from me."

Tears burst from her eyes. She shook her head violently, sobbing. "I can't watch you die for me—I can't—"

His lips brushed hers in a desperate, fleeting kiss, silencing her protests. When he pulled back, his sharp eyes shimmered—not with fear, but unbreakable resolve.
"You won't have to. Because I'm coming back. Both of us are."

The console lit up red, waiting for the command.

AI PROMPT:

Confirm override? Transfer Subject A's cognition to stabilize the bridge?
Y / N

Akki's hand hovered over the interface. His tall frame trembled with the weight of the decision. Kanvi clung to him, her small body shaking, her gorgeous voice breaking. "Please, Akki… don't do this…"

He turned, cupping her face, memorizing every curve, every tear, every breath. His whisper was both fierce and tender:
"If this kills me… remember, it was because I loved you too much to ever let go."

Her sob tore the void apart. "Akki…"

His finger hit Y.

The world screamed.

Energy ripped through his skull like wildfire. His tall frame convulsed, veins glowing faintly as his sharp jaw locked against the pain. He arched backward, roaring, but held onto Kanvi's hand as though it was his lifeline.

Kanvi shrieked his name, trying to wrench free, but the bridge flared violently, binding them together. The overload poured into her, stabilizing her collapsing signal. Her gorgeous body jerked once—then steadied.

Her vitals spiked back into rhythm.

But Akki's began to flatline.

"NO!" Kanvi screamed, her small body straining against the bridge. She clutched him, tears streaming as she shook his tall, shaking frame. "You promised—you promised you wouldn't leave me!"

His eyes, half-lidded, met hers. His lips trembled into the faintest smile.
"I… don't break promises."

The bridge glowed violently, threatening to shatter. The entity's distant laughter echoed faintly.

And then—silence.

The world around them froze on a knife's edge, holding its breath.

The Aftermath: Pulling Him Back

The void was silent.

Too silent.

The bridge flickered weakly, its golden threads unraveling like frayed fabric. Kanvi's gorgeous eyes widened in horror as she clutched Akki's tall, convulsing frame. His sharp jaw hung slack, breath shallow, his skin pale. The light in his eyes—once fierce and unyielding—dimmed dangerously.

"No… no, no, no!" Kanvi's voice broke into a scream as she shook him, her small hands gripping his shirt. "Akki, don't you dare leave me! You said you'd never let go!"

Her sobs echoed through the empty chamber, raw and jagged.

The AI system chimed coldly, almost mocking:
"Warning. Subject A's vitals failing. Cognitive collapse imminent."

Kanvi's tears streamed hot down her face. Her small body trembled violently as she pressed her forehead against his chest, listening desperately. His heartbeat was faint. Flickering.

"Akki…" her voice cracked, pleading, "you can't do this to me. Not after everything. Not after every fight, every dream, every moment you gave me. You're the reason I breathe—how do you expect me to go on if you stop breathing?"

The bridge threads flickered faster, breaking one by one.

Kanvi's gorgeous eyes blazed through her tears. She lifted her face, fury igniting through the despair.
"No. I won't lose you. I WON'T."

Her small trembling hands flew across the floating holograms. Brainwave maps, signal overlays, algorithmic codes filled the void around her. Akki had taught her so much—late nights, whispered lessons, his tall frame leaning over her shoulder, guiding her hand. She remembered every word, every formula, every equation.

And now—she used it all.

"Neural sync override," she whispered, fingers flying, heart hammering. "You gave me half your signal… then take mine. Take ALL of it if you need to."

The AI protested coldly:
"Override denied. Subject B risks collapse."

Her voice tore through it like thunder:
"Then let me collapse! If he dies, there's nothing left of me anyway!"

The system faltered. The bridge pulsed.

Kanvi leaned over Akki, her tears dripping onto his face. Her lips brushed his trembling ones, a kiss both desperate and defiant. Her whisper bled into his mouth, raw and unshakable:
"Come back to me. Right here. Right now. Because I refuse to love a ghost."

Her pulse surged.

A violent flare of light erupted from her small frame, pouring into the bridge, into Akki. Their brainwaves overlapped again—her life force bleeding into his, forcing his fading rhythm to spark.

The void trembled.

Akki's sharp jaw clenched. His chest heaved suddenly, violently. His sharp eyes snapped open, blazing like fire rekindled.

Kanvi gasped, choking on her sob as she crushed herself against his tall frame, holding him so tightly it hurt. "You're here—you're here—oh god, you're here!"

He groaned weakly, his lips curling into a faint smile as his arms slowly wrapped around her trembling small body. His voice was rough, broken, but alive.
"Did you really think I'd leave… after all the trouble I went through to find you?"

Her laugh burst out, tangled with sobs. She pressed her lips to his again, fierce and shaking, refusing to ever let go.

The bridge stabilized. Their vitals synced.

And for the first time since this nightmare began—the silence wasn't death.

It was survival.

Together.

XXII.
Shadows Of Sacrifice

The Crumbling Layer

The dream layer was collapsing.

The hospital-like corridors they had been standing in cracked apart like broken glass, each shatter opening into a void of swirling black mist. Alarms screeched, red lights stuttered. The ground shook beneath Kanvi's small feet, forcing her to clutch Akki's arm tightly.

"Akki—it's falling apart!" Her gorgeous eyes darted around in terror.

His tall frame stiffened, sharp eyes blazing as he scanned the chaos. "It's not just collapsing—it's being pulled down. The entity wants to trap one of us."

Kanvi's breath caught. Her small hand trembled in his. "One of us?"

Before Akki could answer, the entity's voice boomed through the broken corridors, dark and mocking:

"Two signals cannot pass through. One must remain."

Kanvi's heart stopped. She stared up at Akki, tears already brimming. "No… no, no, they can't mean—"

Akki's jaw clenched so hard it trembled. His tall frame squared as he pulled her close. "It means me. I'll stay. You're getting out of here."

Kanvi froze, shaking her head violently. Her gorgeous hair whipped as she clutched his shirt. "No! Don't even say that! You've fought too hard—you've bled for me—if anyone's staying, it's me!"

Akki gripped her small shoulders, his sharp eyes fierce but tender. "Kanvi… you're a doctor. You heal people. You save lives. The world needs you. Me? I'm just a scientist who got too obsessed with an equation."

Her tears fell fast. She struck his chest with her small fists, sobbing. "Don't you dare belittle yourself! Without you, there is no me. Do you understand? No me."

The ground cracked further, pulling apart under their feet. Black void surged like waves, reaching for them both.

Akki pulled her against him, burying his face in her hair, whispering hoarsely:
"If it's between your life and mine… Kanvi, I'll choose yours. Every single time."

Her sob muffled against his chest. "And if you die, you kill me too. So what does that save?"

The Impossible Choice

The corridor tilted violently as if the entire world had slipped off balance. Ceiling lights sparked, dangling on broken wires. A jagged crack split the floor between them, spreading wider with every tremor.

Kanvi's gorgeous eyes darted in panic as she felt the void reaching closer. Her small hand clung desperately to Akki's sleeve, refusing to let go.

The entity's voice thundered again, merciless:
"Two cannot leave. Choose, or I shall choose for you."

Kanvi's breath hitched. Her small fingers tightened until her knuckles whitened. "They want us to decide… Akki, no. We won't play their game. We'll both fight out of this."

But Akki's sharp jaw was set, his tall frame rigid with determination. He shook his head slowly, almost painfully. "Kanvi… listen to me. This place is built on logic twisted by quantum recursion. There is no path for both of us. If we don't choose… it'll tear you apart."

Tears welled up, spilling from her gorgeous eyes. "Then let it tear me apart. Better me than you."

His sharp eyes snapped to hers, blazing. He seized her face in his hands, tilting her chin up so she couldn't look away. His voice cracked, rough, desperate.
"Stop. Don't you dare say that. I've already watched you slip away once, Kanvi—I won't survive it again."

Her lip trembled, her tears falling over his hands. "And you think I'll survive you leaving me? You think I'll breathe a single day without you? You idiot—don't you know you're the only reason I ever wanted to live in the first place?"

His chest heaved, her words hitting him like blades. For a moment, his tall frame faltered. He leaned his forehead to hers, eyes squeezed shut, whispering:
"I love you too much to let you stay. That's the curse."

Her sob shook both of them. She clutched his shirt, burying her small fists against him. Her voice broke into shards.
"Then love me enough to let us both die together, if that's what it takes. Because I refuse to love half a life without you."

The void roared, pulling harder now. Sections of the floor gave way, chunks of reality crashing into endless darkness.

Akki's hand trembled as he cupped her cheek, thumb brushing her tears. His sharp eyes shimmered with unshed grief. "Kanvi, please. Just once… let me be selfish for you."

Her reply was a whisper of defiance, cracked but unyielding:
“Then let me be selfish for you.”

And in the broken silence that followed, both knew—neither would willingly sacrifice the other.

But the world demanded otherwise.

The Push

The corridor trembled like a dying beast. Metal screeched, walls split, and the very air fractured with static. The void below surged higher, pulling reality down piece by piece.

Kanvi’s gorgeous eyes darted everywhere, searching for an escape. There was none.

Her small fingers gripped Akki’s sleeve tighter, knuckles white, her whole body shaking. “Akki—we still have time—we can find another way!”

But Akki’s sharp eyes were fixed, not on escape, but on her. His tall frame radiated a terrifying resolve.

“No. We don’t.” His voice was calm, but his hands trembled as he cupped her face. “Kanvi, listen. The system is coded for one exit node. I saw it. The math is absolute.”

Her gorgeous face crumpled in disbelief. She shook her head violently, tears flying. “No. Equations can be rewritten—you taught me that! Nothing is absolute if we fight hard enough!”

He smiled faintly, his sharp jaw trembling. “God, you’re stubborn.” He leaned his forehead against hers, whispering, “And I love you for it.”

Before she could speak, the void surged again—black tendrils ripping through the cracks, snaking toward her small frame. Akki’s tall body shifted instantly, shielding her. Shadows lashed across his back, tearing into him. He groaned but didn’t let go.

Kanvi screamed, clutching him. “STOP IT! Leave him!”

The entity’s voice slithered like poison:
“Choose. Or be devoured together.”

Kanvi sobbed, shaking her head. “Then devour us both—I don’t care!”

Akki turned, his sharp eyes blazing through the pain, and in that instant, Kanvi knew.

He had already made his choice.

“No—Akki—don’t you dare—” she cried, her voice shattering.

He pulled her against him one last time, his lips pressing fiercely to hers, tasting of blood and desperation. It was a kiss that seared everything—fear, love, eternity—into her soul.

When he broke away, his voice was hoarse but steady.
“You’re going to live. For both of us.”

Before she could stop him, his tall frame twisted—hands gripping her small shoulders. With one violent, heartbreaking shove, he pushed her across the collapsing floor, into the faint shimmer of the exit node.

“AKKIIIIIIIII!” Her scream tore the void apart as her body was flung backward, swallowed by the light.

Her gorgeous eyes locked on his until the last second. She saw him—standing tall, sharp jaw set, shadows consuming his frame—as he mouthed words she would never forget:

“I’ll always love you.”

And then—darkness.

The light closed around her.

He was gone.

After the Push: The Silence That Remains

Light seared through Kanvi’s closed eyelids.

Her lungs convulsed as air ripped back into them, dragging her into consciousness. She gasped violently, her small body jerking upright on the cot in the lab. Electrodes tore from her temples as monitors screamed in alarm.

For a moment—she didn’t remember.

Her gorgeous eyes darted across the sterile white walls of the lab, the glowing consoles, the humming machines. The dreamscape was gone. She was back.

But her heart—her heart knew what was missing.

Her small trembling hand clutched the empty space beside her. The other cot was cold. The other signal was flatlined.

Akki wasn't there.

Her breath broke into a sob. "No… no, please—wake him, wake him!" She staggered off the cot, wires dragging behind her, feet stumbling toward the main console. Her small hands flew across the holograms, slapping controls, overriding locks.

"Subject A—signal lost," the AI droned, mercilessly.
"Subject B—stabilized."

Kanvi's scream tore the sterile air apart. "BRING HIM BACK!"

Her gorgeous face crumpled as her small fists slammed into the console again and again. "You can't leave him there! You can't take him from me!"

Every display repeated the same line.
Subject A—no neural return.

Her knees buckled. She collapsed onto the cold floor, sobbing so violently it shook her entire body. Her hair spilled across her face as her small hands covered her mouth, trying to hold in the unbearable sound.

But the silence around her mocked her.

In her mind's eye—she still saw him. A tall frame standing against the collapsing void, sharp jaw set, shadows consuming him. The last look in his eyes, fierce even as he mouthed those words: I'll always love you.

Her gorgeous eyes squeezed shut, tears pouring as she whispered into the empty air:
"You promised… you promised you'd come back to me."

The lab was too quiet. Machines hummed, monitors blinked, but there was no voice teasing her, no tall figure standing by her side, no warmth of arms around her small trembling frame.

Only silence.

And in that silence—she realized what the entity had meant.

A sacrifice had been demanded. And Akki had given himself without hesitation.

The weight crushed her chest. For the first time since their shared journey began, Kanvi felt truly alone.

And yet… her doctor's instincts warred with her shattered heart. Somewhere deep inside, a whisper fought through the grief: No death is absolute. No equation is unsolvable.

She lifted her tear-streaked gorgeous face toward the monitors. Her small trembling hand reached for the controls again.

Her whisper was raw, broken, but burning with resolve.
“Then I’ll find the way. If I have to walk through every dream, every shadow, every hour of this cursed recursion—I will bring you back, Akki.”

Her tears fell fresh. But this time, there was steel in her sobs.

Because though the silence remained… hope flickered beneath it.

The Shadow’s Claim: Alone in the Void

Darkness swallowed everything.

Akki staggered, his tall frame collapsing to one knee as the last fragments of the corridor dissolved into the void. The glow of the exit node—the light that had carried Kanvi away—was gone. Only shadows remained.

His sharp jaw was tight, breath ragged, every nerve screaming. But his eyes—his eyes were calm. Focused.

“She’s safe,” he whispered into the emptiness, his voice hoarse but steady. “That’s all that matters.”

The void answered with a low, mocking laugh.

From the black mist, the figure emerged. The same shadow that had haunted their dreams, its form twisting like smoke, eyes glowing with cruel light.

“You gave yourself so easily. A sacrifice made with love. Admirable.”

Akki pushed himself to his feet, his tall frame trembling but unyielding. His sharp eyes burned. “Spare me the theatrics. You didn’t win. She got out.”

The shadow tilted its head, amused.
“For now. But her return will break her. She will chase you. She will bleed herself dry to reach you. And when she does—she will belong to me as well.”

Akki’s jaw clenched, fists curling so tight his knuckles cracked. Fury roared through his veins. “Over my dead body.”

The shadow’s laughter deepened, shaking the void itself.
“That can be arranged. You are mine now, scientist. Your mind, your equations, your obsessions—everything that built this cage will serve me.”

Akki’s sharp eyes narrowed. Despite the weight pressing down on his tall frame, he straightened, defiance radiating. “You think you can own me? You don’t understand a damn thing.”

The void hissed, tendrils of black wrapping around his arms, tightening like chains. His body jolted with pain, but he refused to cry out.

The shadow leaned closer, its whisper like venom.
“You are alone here. Forgotten. Sacrifice is just another word for surrender.”

For a moment, silence. Akki’s breathing was ragged, sweat beading down his sharp jaw.

And then—he smiled. Faint. Bitter. But unbroken.

“You’re wrong.” His voice was a rasp, but it cut through the void like steel.
“She remembers me. She’ll never stop fighting. And if she comes—I’ll break every shadow in this place to reach her.”

The shadow recoiled, hissing angrily.

Akki’s tall frame straightened against the chains, his sharp eyes blazing through the darkness. “So go ahead. Claim me. Bind me. Torture me. I don’t care. Because love doesn’t surrender. And when Kanvi finds me—and she will—your end begins.”

The void trembled. For the first time, the shadow faltered, its laughter turning into a distorted growl.

And Akki—bleeding, bound, but unbroken—stood like a defiant flame in endless night.

XXIII.
The Hidden Equation

The Notebook

The lab was colder than it had ever felt.

Kanvi sat hunched in Akki's chair, his jacket draped over her small shoulders like a shield that could no longer protect her. The oversized fabric swallowed her petite frame, yet she clung to it as if it were his arms still around her. The hum of the servers, the faint glow of holographic monitors, the smell of coffee still lingering in the air—it all screamed of him.

But he wasn't here.

Her gorgeous eyes, red from hours of crying, refused to close. Every time her lashes fell, she saw it all over again—the way his tall frame had stood against the collapsing void, the shadows devouring him, the sharpness in his eyes as he mouthed those last words: I'll always love you.

Her trembling small hands reached for the pile of notebooks on his desk. They weren't neat. Papers stuck out at odd angles, scribbles bled across margins, pages torn in places. To anyone else it would have been chaos. But to Kanvi, it was his mind—alive, sharp, impossible.

She opened the first one. Equations sprawled across the page, furious lines of ink bending into symbols that seemed to move on their own.

$$\Psi(t+1) = \alpha \cdot \Psi(t) + \beta \cdot e^{i\theta} \cdot \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} \Phi(x)\, dx$$

Her breath caught. Schrödinger's equation—but rewritten. Twisted. Recursion added where none should exist. She whispered under her breath, lips trembling:
"You were… trying to model dreams as quantum states."

Her mind reeled back to a memory—Akki leaning over her shoulder late one night, his tall frame shadowing hers, his sharp jaw so close she could feel his warmth. His voice teasing:
"Kanvi, people think equations are cold. But they lie, cheat, misbehave—just like humans. You just have to ask the right question to make them confess."
Her lips trembled into a broken laugh, tears welling. "And you always asked the wrong questions… just to make me roll my eyes."

She flipped another page. This time the scribbles hit harder.

$$\nabla \cdot \vec{u} = 0$$

$$\frac{\partial \vec{u}}{\partial t} + (\vec{u} \cdot \nabla)\vec{u} = -\nabla p + \nu \Delta \vec{u} + \vec{f}$$

The Navier–Stokes equation. One of the seven unsolved Millennium Problems.

Her heart pounded. Akki hadn't just been mapping dreams—he had compared dream states to turbulent fluid flows, something even the greatest mathematicians in history had failed to tame.

On the margin, in his sharp handwriting, he had scribbled:
"If fluid motion can't be solved, how can dream motion? Dreams are turbulence of the soul."

Kanvi's gorgeous lips quivered as she whispered to the empty air, "You insane, brilliant fool…"

She noticed something else at the bottom corner of the page. Faint pencil, almost hidden between integrals. She leaned closer.

"Kanvi, stop biting your lip when you're thinking—it distracts me."

Her small hand flew to her lips, trembling. A broken laugh burst through her sobs. "You idiot…" she whispered, pressing her forehead to the page.

Tears blurred the ink.

She flipped faster now, page after page of impossible math, quantum fields mixing with biological EEG overlays, AI integration models sketched into the lines of wave equations. But between them, hidden in margins, she found him.

"Don't forget your coffee before diving into this."
"Stop skipping meals, Doctor Kanvi."
"If you're reading this… it means I'm not there to remind you myself."

Her heart cracked further with every line.

Finally—her eyes froze on a red-circled formula that sprawled across an entire page:

$$\zeta(s) = \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{1}{n^s}, \quad \Re(s) > 1$$

The Riemann zeta function.

Her gorgeous eyes widened, breath hitching. "The Riemann Hypothesis…?"

Beside it, in bold, furious strokes, Akki had written:
"If the zeros of this function hold order, then dreams have an order too. Dreams are not chaos—they are patterned. Find the pattern… and you'll find me."

Her small hand covered her mouth, trembling. She whispered through her tears:
“You left me… a path.”

She looked at the board, at the equations, at the hopeless chaos—and for the first time since losing him, she felt something flicker beneath the despair.

Hope.

Equations & Memories

The holographic table glowed softly, throwing blue light across Kanvi’s tear-streaked face. She stood there in silence, clutching Akki’s notebook to her chest as though holding him.

Her gorgeous eyes shifted to the central holo-projector. With a trembling breath, she whispered,
“Activate simulation… load Akki’s last sequences.”

The AI’s calm voice answered:
“Sequence loaded. Equations unstable. Predictive model probability: <1%.”

Kanvi gave a small, broken laugh. “That’s exactly the kind of odds you loved, Akki…”

Her small fingers began typing furiously, scanning his handwritten notes and uploading line after line of impossible math. The Schrödinger recursion. The Navier–Stokes turbulence models. The cursed Riemann zeta function with its infinite series.

Each line unfolded into glowing equations across the lab, spinning around her like constellations.

For a moment, she closed her gorgeous eyes.

And then the memories came.

Flashback 1 – School Days
Kanvi was fifteen, sitting on the last bench of their school’s dusty classroom. Her small legs barely reached the floor, and her notebook was filled with neat biology notes. Beside her, Akki’s tall frame was sprawled across his chair, bored, spinning a pen.

He leaned closer, whispering with that sharp smirk, “Biology is easy. Memorize and vomit. Maths is art.”

She had rolled her gorgeous eyes. “It’s torture. Stop doodling numbers in my notebook.”

But when she looked down, he had written in the corner of her page:

$$a^2 + b^2 = c^2$$

and below it, in messy handwriting:
‘a = Kanvi, b = Akki, c = Together.’

She had shoved him playfully, cheeks red, muttering, “Idiot.”

Back to Present
Kanvi’s small lips quivered into a fragile smile. She touched the glowing hologram, tracing the very same equation Akki had scrawled years ago.

“You always found a way to put us into math…”

Flashback 2 – College Library
She remembered late nights in the college library. Piles of books surrounded them, the smell of dust and coffee mixing. Akki leaned over pages of integrals, his sharp jaw illuminated by the lamplight.

“You see this?” he said, tapping furiously at the Riemann function. “They’ve been trying to solve it for 150 years. If I solve it—”

“You’ll get a million dollars?” Kanvi teased, flipping a biology book.

He grinned. “No. I’ll prove dreams aren’t chaos.”

She frowned. “Dreams? Seriously, Akki?”

He leaned closer, his tall frame blocking the light, whispering:
“If I can solve the flow of prime numbers, I can solve the flow of your nightmares too.”

Her heart had skipped, though she’d tried to hide it behind a mutter, “You’re crazy.”
Back to Present
Her gorgeous eyes brimmed again, tears falling onto the holo-panel. “And you were right. You were always… terrifyingly right.”
The holographic equations flickered, unstable. The Navier–Stokes stream collapsed into noise, Schrödinger’s recursion blew into infinity. Only the Riemann zeta remained glowing, steady, like a heartbeat.
Kanvi’s small hands hovered over it.
Her whisper cracked through the silence:
“Equation of primes… equation of dreams…”
She highlighted the zero points—the legendary critical line where Riemann had conjectured all non-trivial zeros must lie:

$$\Re(s) = \frac{1}{2}$$

The AI flickered. “Warning: Infinite recursion detected.”

Her gorgeous face hardened, jaw trembling. “Then infinite recursion is the only way to reach him.”
She pressed her hand against the glowing formula, and suddenly—the entire lab shifted. The zeta function unfolded into a holographic tunnel of primes and zeros, stretching into infinity.

Kanvi’s small frame stood alone at the edge, staring into the impossible.

But in her heart, she heard his voice again, teasing:
“Stop biting your lip when you’re scared, Doctor Kanvi.”

Her trembling lips curved upward. “Then come back and stop me yourself…”

The Riemann Whisper

The holographic tunnel stretched before her like a cathedral built from numbers. Prime spirals and glowing zeta curves pulsed in the darkness, each rhythm like the beating of an infinite heart.

Kanvi stood frozen, her gorgeous eyes wide, breath trembling. The air vibrated with equations, as though the entire room hummed with Akki’s voice.

Her small fingers brushed the floating digits. They shifted at her touch, breaking into fragments, reassembling like living things.

And then—she saw it.

Not random. Not chaos. A pattern.

Her eyes darted faster, scanning, heart racing. Every time she touched one of the critical zeros, the primes rearranged into letters. At first she thought it was a coincidence. But then the letters formed words.

Her lips parted, whispering:
“…Kanvi.”

Her whole body shook. The equation was speaking.

The First Whisper
Letters glowed faintly across the tunnel wall:

“Kanvi, if you ever find this—you’re closer than anyone in history.”

Her knees weakened, but she forced herself to read on.

“The Riemann Hypothesis isn’t just math. It’s a map. Primes aren’t numbers—they’re pulses. Like heartbeats. Like… dreams.”

Kanvi pressed her trembling hand against the glowing words. Her gorgeous eyes blurred with tears.

“You left me a… message. Inside the unsolvable.”

Memory Overlap
Her mind spiraled back.

She was in the library again, sitting across from Akki. He was sketching primes, his sharp jaw set, his eyes blazing with focus. She had teased him:
“Why do you stare at numbers like they’re poetry?”

He had looked up with that faint smirk.
“Because maybe they are. Maybe numbers are just words God left behind. And maybe, if I solve them, I’ll finally say the one thing I’m too much of a coward to tell you.”

At the time she’d laughed, rolling her eyes. But now—her heart broke. That coward had hidden his words in mathematics itself.

Back to Present
The tunnel pulsed brighter. Equations rearranged. Another sentence unfolded:

“Dream recursion follows the same law as primes. To escape, align with the critical line: Re(s) = ½. Half real, half imaginary. Half in dream, half in life.”

Her gorgeous lips trembled as she read. “Half real, half imaginary… That’s us. Always halfway between science and madness.”

She moved deeper into the tunnel, her small frame dwarfed by infinite math. More lines assembled.

“Kanvi… you were always my constant. Even in chaos. Even in turbulence. Even when the equation broke… you balanced me.”

Her breath shattered. She clutched her chest, sobbing, whispering into the glow:
“You stupid man… you’re still teaching me equations when all I want is you.”

The holograms flickered again. This time, instead of text, numbers aligned into a shape—a small doodle of a coffee mug. Her tears turned into a broken laugh. “You had to sneak that in, didn’t you?”

Then the final line emerged, faint, almost collapsing into noise. She stepped closer, desperate not to lose it.

“Kanvi, if you find me through this… don’t waste time crying. Just follow the primes. They’ll lead you back to me.”

The words dissolved into endless digits.

Kanvi stood trembling in the silence, her gorgeous eyes burning with tears, her small body shaking. She pressed her forehead against the glowing wall of numbers, whispering:
“Then I’ll follow them. Every single one. Even if it kills me.”

For the first time since Akki’s sacrifice, her sobs carried not just grief—but determination.

Because the equation wasn’t just unsolved math.

It was his voice.

The Machine of Ghosts

The lab lights dimmed to a low hum as Kanvi keyed in the last command.

“Quantum drive, engage.”

The floor trembled. From beneath the reinforced tiles, a lattice of superconducting circuits awakened, bathing the room in pale blue light. Above the central console, the holographic arrays whirred to life, layering prime spirals, zeta curves, and wavefunctions into a glowing sphere that pulsed like a heart.

Kanvi’s gorgeous eyes locked on the equations hovering midair. Her small fingers trembled over the glass console.

“Come on, Akki,” she whispered. “Talk to me.”

The Awakening
The AI’s monotone voice broke through:

“Equation loaded. Quantum recursion in progress. Warning: signal instability detected.”

The holograms rippled. Symbols stretched and fractured. Prime numbers pulsed, blinking in uneven rhythm.

And then—it happened.

A voice. Faint. Fragmented.

“—Kan…vi—”

Her heart stopped. The sound wasn’t human-clear. It was buried in static, distorted by recursion loops. But it was him.

Her gorgeous eyes filled with tears. She stumbled back, covering her lips with her trembling hand.
“Akki…?”

The system glitched again. Holograms twisted, and for the briefest second, his tall silhouette flickered inside the sphere. Sharp jaw, broad shoulders, blurred but unmistakable.

Kanvi gasped, tears spilling down her cheeks. “It’s you! I—I knew you’d left me something.”

The hologram collapsed into noise.

Desperation
She slammed her small palms against the console. “Stabilize signal! Amplify the recursion loop!”

The AI hesitated. “Risk level: 92%. The system may collapse.”

“Do it!” she screamed, her voice cracking. “Do it, damn you!”

The lab roared alive. Circuits blazed with dangerous light, filling the room with vibrating hums. Kanvi’s small frame shook under the pressure, but she didn’t move. She couldn’t.

The equations bent, twisted—and then words bled out of the static:

“…don’t… cry…”

Her lips parted, trembling. She pressed both hands to the hologram sphere, tears rolling freely.
“I can’t stop, you idiot. I can’t stop because you’re not here to wipe them.”

The silhouette flickered again, this time more stable. His sharp eyes glowed faintly through the blur. He lifted a hand, as though reaching out.

Ghost Touch
Kanvi’s breath shattered. She raised her small hand to the hologram, pressing palm to palm. Cold light buzzed against her skin, but in that moment she swore she felt warmth.

The ghostly voice whispered again, clearer:
“…follow… primes… Kanvi… constant…”

Her knees buckled, and she collapsed forward, forehead resting against the glowing sphere. Sobs racked her small frame.
“I’m trying. I’m following every number, every line, every heartbeat. Just… don’t fade. Please.”

For a long moment, the lab was filled with the soft static of his presence, like he was breathing with her.

The Collapse
Then—the alarms blared.

“Warning: Quantum drive overheating. Equation recursion unstable.”

The hologram glitched violently. His figure fractured into shards of light, scattering into chaos. His voice distorted, breaking:
“…Ka…nvi… ru—”

And silence.

The entire projection collapsed into darkness.

Kanvi fell to her knees, clutching her chest, her gorgeous eyes wide with horror. “No… no, no, no… not again.”

The lab went dark, only the faint hum of dying circuits filling the air. She sat there, her small body trembling, her lips pressed against his abandoned notebook.

“I’ll bring you back,” she whispered into the silence, voice breaking but steady. “Even if I have to solve the impossible. Even if I have to burn through every equation in the universe.”

The Hidden Equation

The lab was dark. Only the faint glow of Akki’s scattered notebooks remained, their pages fluttering in the cold air from the cooling fans. Kanvi sat on the floor, knees to her chest, her small frame shaking as she clutched one of the notebooks against her heart.

Her gorgeous eyes burned with sleeplessness and grief, but they refused to close. She couldn’t stop now. Not when she had touched him—even if just for seconds.

Her small hand trembled as she opened the notebook again. The pages were dense, almost unreadable, every margin filled with furious equations. But her gaze froze when she saw something different this time.

A sequence. Numbers written in perfect columns.

At first, she thought it was just data. But then—her breath hitched.

The numbers weren’t random. They were primes. And not just any primes—specific indexed primes.

She pulled the holo-pen closer, typing them into the console.

The Code
As the numbers expanded on the holo-screen, they rearranged into letters. Her lips parted in shock.

It wasn’t just math.

It was a cipher.

And the words it formed…

“KANVI.”

Her small body jolted. Tears welled again, but she forced herself to keep decoding. More prime indexes unfolded into words, line after line.

“If you are reading this… it means I couldn’t keep my promise. It means I left you too soon.”

Her gorgeous lips trembled as her fingers traced the glowing words. “Akki…”

“You always hated equations. But you loved me enough to sit through them. So I left myself in them. Every proof, every function… every margin scribble was my way of saying what I never said enough.”

Her breath shattered.

“Kanvi—you were my constant. The only variable I never wanted to solve, because you made every equation infinite.”

She pressed her trembling hands against the screen, sobbing. “Why would you hide this from me…? Why not just say it…”

And then the last line appeared, faint, almost broken in recursion noise:

“If dreams are turbulence, if life is recursion, then love is convergence. And every path converges to you.”

The Final Flashback
Her mind reeled back to the day he’d first shown her his research. She had teased him, saying, “You’re going to get lost inside those dreams one day.”

And he had smirked, leaning close, eyes sharp yet soft.
“Then promise me, Doctor Kanvi, you’ll come drag me out.”

She had laughed back then. She wasn’t laughing now. Her gorgeous eyes blurred as she whispered into the dark lab:
“I’m keeping that promise. Even if I have to tear down the laws of physics to do it.”

The Silent Confession

She flipped the final page of the notebook. At the bottom corner, hidden in faint pencil, almost erased, he had written:

“Equation of my life: Akki + Kanvi = ∞”

Her small hand flew to her mouth, and she broke down completely.

Through tears, she pressed her lips against the fragile paper, whispering,
“I love you too, Akki. Always. Even across equations.”

And as the lab flickered back to silence, she knew the path forward was clear.

She would solve the unsolvable.
Not for mathematics.
Not for the world.
But for him.

XIV.
Final Experiment

The Setup

The lab had become a temple of light. Every wall pulsed with projections of numbers, primes cascading like falling stars, fluid equations wrapping around steel pillars. The quantum cores hummed so loudly that the air itself seemed to vibrate.

Kanvi stood at the center, her petite frame swallowed in Akki's old lab coat. It was far too big for her—the sleeves dangling past her delicate wrists—but she wore it like armor. His scent lingered faintly in the fabric, coffee and ozone, and it made her heart ache.

Her gorgeous eyes scanned the chamber ahead—the Dream Synchronizer.

It was enormous, a coffin-shaped cradle of glass and superconducting filaments, filled with floating holographic patterns. The filaments coiled like glowing vines, threads of light spiraling endlessly, weaving themselves into impossible shapes. Each shimmer was a dream fragment—Akki's last trails still alive inside the recursion loop.

The sight made her breath tremble.

"Akki… you're in there. I know you are."

The Command Interface
She moved to the console, her small fingers trembling over the smooth glass. With each touch, holograms bloomed into existence—Akki's old codes, neural maps, EEG overlays.

The AI's calm, neutral voice filled the lab:
"System check: Quantum drive, online. Recursion core, unstable. Synchronization probability, below 11%. Neural collapse risk, above 89%."

Kanvi's lips parted in a trembling laugh. "That's exactly the kind of gamble you'd have loved."

She wiped her gorgeous tears quickly, forcing a steady breath. "Prepare chamber for dual recursion entry."

The AI hesitated. "Dual entry requires a second participant. Only one detected."

Kanvi's gorgeous eyes hardened. "There is a second participant. His consciousness is trapped. You will align my neural recursion with his signal."

"Warning: Entity signal unstable. Identification uncertain."

Kanvi slammed her small palm against the console, her voice breaking. "It's him! It's Akki! Just… trust me."

For a moment, silence. Then the AI responded:

"…Dual recursion protocol enabled."

The Notebook
Kanvi reached for the notebook lying on the desk—his last, chaotic collection of pages. The edges were frayed, ink smudged by her tears. She hugged it tightly against her chest.

Her gorgeous lips pressed against the cover, whispering:
"You stupid, brilliant man. You could've just told me you loved me. Instead you wrote it in math the whole world couldn't solve."

She flipped to the last page again, tracing his faint pencil line:
Equation of my life: Akki + Kanvi = ∞.

Her small hands trembled as she closed the book, slipping it inside the chamber with her. "You'll be with me. Every line, every equation, every breath."

The Chamber Awakens
The Synchronizer roared alive. Holographic filaments coiled tighter, glowing brighter until they looked like veins of lightning captured in glass. The floor shook as superconducting plates locked into place.

Her gorgeous eyes widened as prime numbers began spinning across the chamber walls, each glowing digit forming a vortex. The recursion had already begun.

Kanvi stepped forward, her small feet echoing softly against the steel floor. Every step was heavy, like walking into destiny itself.

At the chamber's edge, she hesitated. Her lips trembled, her throat tight. She whispered softly, almost like a prayer:
"If this is my last experiment… let me at least see you one more time."

The Fear and the Flame
Her small hands reached for the neural straps. They were heavy, metallic bands wired with superconductors. She placed them around her temples, tightening until she felt the cold bite of metal against her skin.

Her gorgeous eyes flickered shut for a second, her heart pounding. She remembered his tall frame beside her, leaning down to check the wires whenever she strapped in for smaller tests. His hand brushing her hair aside, his teasing voice:
"You always look like a warrior princess with these on."

Her lips trembled into a broken smile. "Then tonight, Akki, I'll fight like one."

The Final Step
The AI intoned:

“Final synchronization in 30 seconds. Confirm initiation?”

Kanvi looked up at the chamber. The threads of light pulsed like veins, alive, hungry. Her small figure seemed swallowed by the immensity of it, but her voice was steady.

“Confirm.”

The console beeped. The chamber doors hissed open with a rush of cold air, light pouring out like a river.

She took one last breath, clutching Akki’s coat closer around her small frame.

Her gorgeous eyes glimmered with tears, but they were steady now. Focused. Determined.

“Wait for me, Akki. I’m coming.”

And with that, Kanvi stepped inside the Synchronizer, the chamber sealing around her with a sound like thunder.

Into the Chamber

The chamber sealed shut with a thunderous hiss. For a heartbeat, Kanvi was swallowed by darkness. Only the sound of her own rapid breathing filled her ears.

Then—light exploded.

Threads of pure holographic code cascaded around her small frame, weaving themselves like rivers of starlight. Numbers spun into spirals, primes flickering like fireflies. The walls dissolved. Space itself bent.

She felt her body lift, weightless, her heart pounding as if it wanted to escape her chest.

The AI’s voice echoed faintly:
“Synchronization commencing… aligning neural recursion…”

Her gorgeous eyes fluttered shut as the world ripped open beneath her.

The Descent
She fell. Not through air, but through equations. Symbols wrapped around her like silk ribbons, tugging her deeper. Every prime pulsed like a heartbeat, every zero a doorway.

Her small hands reached out instinctively, as though trying to catch something in the void. “Akki!” she cried into the abyss, her voice trembling. “If you’re here… answer me!”

For a terrifying moment, there was nothing. Just endless falling.

Then—warmth.

A faint glow emerged below, golden and steady. Her body slowed as though caught in invisible arms. She gasped, her gorgeous eyes opening wide.

A silhouette stood in the glow.

Tall. Broad shoulders. Sharp jawline. Familiar as breath itself.

Her lips trembled. Tears blurred her sight. “Akki…?”

The Reunion
He turned. And her world shattered.

It was him. Not a glitch, not a ghostly flicker—him. His sharp eyes caught hers, filled with disbelief, then sudden fire.

“Kanvi…? No… this isn’t possible…”

Her small feet hit the ground and she ran—without hesitation, without thought. Her gorgeous hair streamed behind her as she crashed into his chest, clutching him with every ounce of strength left in her.

His arms closed around her instantly, strong and desperate, lifting her small frame off the ground.

She sobbed against his chest, her voice breaking. “You idiot… you absolute idiot… you left me!”

He buried his face in her hair, his voice trembling with something she had never heard before—fear. “I thought I’d lost you forever. How… how are you here?”

Her small fingers dug into his back. “Because I solved your damn equations. Because you left me no choice!”

The Touch
For a long moment, neither spoke. They just clung to each other as though afraid the other would vanish if they let go.

Then Akki pulled back, his hands cradling her small face. His sharp eyes scanned her as though memorizing every line. “You’re real… you’re actually real…”

Her gorgeous eyes brimmed with tears, but her lips curled into a trembling smile. “I told you I’d drag you out, remember? Even if I had to tear down physics.”

His lips curved faintly, but his hands didn’t leave her cheeks. He leaned closer, their foreheads pressing together, breaths mingling. “Kanvi… I—”

She cut him off, her voice breaking but steady. “Don’t you dare waste time. Just… hold me.”

And then his lips met hers.

The Kiss
The dream-layer around them pulsed with light as if the world itself recognized their union. Equations scattered, threads of light twisting into constellations above.

Her small frame melted into him, her hands sliding up his chest, clutching his shirt as though anchoring herself to reality. His arms wrapped tighter, lifting her effortlessly, his kiss deepening with years of unspoken words.

She broke for air, her gorgeous lips trembling, whispering against his mouth: “You hid everything in numbers… but I found you anyway.”

He kissed her again, fierce and desperate. Between breaths, he murmured, “I wrote them for you. Every line. Every impossible proof. You were my constant.”

Her tears fell against his skin as she whispered, “And you’re my infinity.”

The Breaking Moment
The ground beneath them shook violently. The equations around them fractured, streams of light collapsing into darkness.

Akki tore himself away, his sharp eyes darkening. “No… no, this layer isn’t stable. The recursion is collapsing.”

Kanvi clutched his hand, her gorgeous eyes blazing. “Then we’ll run together. I’m not leaving without you this time.”

The chamber roared, light exploding, but their hands stayed locked. His tall frame shielded her small body as fragments of broken primes rained down like glass.

For the first time in forever—they weren’t apart.

The Fracture

The world trembled.

The dream-layer—once a cathedral of equations and light—was tearing itself apart. Prime spirals unraveled like broken strings. Critical zeros split, bleeding into endless black voids. The ground cracked beneath their feet, glowing fissures crawling outward like veins of fire.

Kanvi's gorgeous eyes widened in panic as the air rippled with static screams. Her small body clutched tightly against Akki's tall frame.

"Akki!" she cried, voice breaking. "What's happening?"

His sharp jaw tightened as his gaze darted around. "The recursion is unstable. Your entry disrupted the balance—it's collapsing faster than I thought."

Another fissure cracked open at their side, numbers dissolving into dust. She stumbled, but his strong arm caught her instantly, pulling her close.

Their breaths mingled. Their eyes locked. In that chaos, only one truth burned between them—time was slipping away.

The Pull
He held her tighter, his sharp eyes softening in a way she had never seen. "Kanvi… listen to me. If this collapses completely, you'll get thrown back into your body. But me—"

Her gorgeous eyes filled with fire. "Don't you dare finish that sentence. You're not staying behind this time!"

She pressed her small hand against his chest, her voice trembling. "I solved your equations. I followed your primes. I found you! I won't let the universe steal you again!"

His tall frame bent slightly, his forehead pressing against hers. "You always were stubborn."

Her lips curled into a broken smile. "And you always loved that."

The Kiss in Ruin
The ground shook violently, shards of collapsing numbers raining down like glass. Akki pulled her closer, his hands cradling her face. "Kanvi…" he whispered, his voice breaking, "…if this is all we have left…"

She cut him off with a kiss.

It was not gentle—it was desperate, blazing, burning like the collapsing world around them. Her small frame clung to him, her hands gripping his shirt as though trying to fuse herself into him. His arms wrapped her fully, lifting her slightly off the collapsing ground, his body shielding hers from the raining debris.

Her gorgeous tears mixed with their kiss, salty and warm. She broke for air, whispering against his lips, "I'd rather die here with you… than live a thousand lives without you."

His sharp eyes glistened, his voice raw. "And I'd rather burn this recursion to ash… than let you cry again."

The Breakpoint
The fissures widened, swallowing entire equations. Symbols shattered like glass, each breaking sound echoing like screams.

Akki grabbed her hand. “We have one chance. We have to synchronize our exit—together.”

Kanvi’s heart pounded. Her small hand tightened around his. “Then don’t let go. Promise me, Akki. Promise!”

He looked at her, his sharp eyes blazing with something between fear and love. Slowly, he squeezed her hand back. “On every prime in the universe… I promise.”

The Almost Loss
A sudden surge ripped through the layer—an explosion of static. Kanvi was thrown back, her small body tumbling across the fracturing ground. She screamed, “Akki!”

He sprinted after her, his tall frame cutting through the chaos. Just as the ground gave way beneath her, his hand caught hers—pulling her into his chest once more.

Her gorgeous sobs broke free as she buried her face against him. “You always… always come for me.”

He held her tight, whispering fiercely into her hair, “And I always will. Even across death. Even across equations.”

Romance in Collapse
Time fractured around them. The dream-layer flickered between reality and void. But in that chaos, they stood—locked in each other’s arms.

Her small hand rose to his cheek, her gorgeous eyes shining despite the tears. “Say it… just once, Akki. I need to hear it before everything breaks.”

His breath shook. His sharp eyes softened, and for the first time, he let the wall fall. He whispered against her lips—words encoded in every equation he’d ever written:

“I love you, Kanvi. More than physics. More than time. More than life itself.”

Her lips trembled, breaking into the faintest smile through tears. “And I’ve loved you every second… even the ones you wasted on math.”

They kissed again, harder, deeper—while the world around them tore apart.

The Last Attempt

The collapsing dream-layer roared like a dying storm. Shards of broken numbers fell like meteors, every prime unraveling into static fire.

Kanvi clung to Akki's tall frame, her small hand locked inside his. Their breaths came ragged, their lips still wet with the kiss that had bound them tighter than physics itself.

But time was burning away.

Akki turned, his sharp eyes scanning the chaos. In the distance, a glowing Convergence Node pulsed faintly—a final exit, the only door out of this recursion.

He tightened his grip on her hand. "That's it. That's our way out."

Kanvi's gorgeous eyes followed his gaze. Her chest ached. "If we jump alone, only one escapes."

He nodded grimly. "That's why we synchronize. Together. Or not at all."

Her small hand trembled, but her voice was fierce: "Then not at all."

The Equation of Escape
Akki's sharp mind raced. He pulled from his memory the formula he had buried in his last notebook—the recursion constant.

He spoke quickly, his deep voice trembling as he etched glowing symbols in the collapsing air:

"ΔΨ = Σ e^(iπn) Kanvi Constant × Akki Variable."

The symbols floated between them, glowing brighter than the destruction around.

Kanvi's gorgeous lips parted. She traced the lines with her small finger, tears sliding down her cheek. "You… you actually used my name as a constant."

His sharp eyes softened. "You've always been my fixed point. My anchor. Without you, the math never converges."

Her lips trembled into a smile, even as the ground broke beneath them. "Then let's solve it together."

The Synchronization
They stepped into the glowing circle of numbers. The Node pulsed wildly, threads of light whipping around them like lightning.

Akki pulled her close, his arms locking her against him. Their foreheads pressed together, their breaths syncing.

“Kanvi…” he whispered, his voice shaking, “…if this fails, I want you to know…”

She pressed her gorgeous lips against his, silencing him. The kiss was fierce, consuming, her small body trembling against his tall frame. She pulled back just enough to whisper, “Don’t waste your last words. Use them to breathe with me.”

He exhaled, his sharp eyes wet. “Always.”

The Final Pulse
The Node roared, a vortex of collapsing primes spiraling inward. The equations around them shone white-hot.

Kanvi’s small hands gripped his shirt, her gorgeous eyes never leaving him. “On my mark, Akki. One… two…”

Their hearts beat in sync.

“Three.”

They leapt into the light together.

The Union in Chaos
The world shattered. For an instant, their bodies disintegrated into symbols—her name fractals, his equations, colliding and merging into one blazing formula.

Kanvi felt everything—his heartbeat, his fear, his love—pulsing through her veins as though they had one body, one soul.

She cried out, her gorgeous lips forming his name, “Akki!”

And his voice thundered back, breaking with devotion:
“Kanvi!”

The Node consumed them both, a blinding white flash erasing the collapsing world.

The Silence
Then—darkness.

No equations. No ground. No voices. Just void.

Her small fingers searched blindly in the dark. For a terrifying moment, she thought he was gone. But then—warmth.

A hand. Strong. Familiar.

She gasped, tears streaming from her gorgeous eyes. “Akki…”

And his whisper came, steady despite the void:
“I told you. I’ll never let go.”

The Awakening

Silence.

At first, there was nothing. No chamber, no light, not even the hum of collapsing equations. Just a black stillness where time itself seemed to stop breathing.

Kanvi floated, her small frame curled as if she were a child again. Her gorgeous lashes fluttered against her cheeks, but she couldn’t force her eyes open. A weight pressed on her chest, suffocating, as though she was trapped beneath a thousand dreams.

Was this death?

She reached blindly through the void. Her small fingers trembled, groping, searching—until they brushed against warmth.

A hand. Strong. Steady.

“Akki…” she whispered, her gorgeous lips barely moving.

The hand squeezed hers back, hard.

“Kanvi. I’m here.”

The Chamber Returns
Her eyes shot open—and the world slammed back into existence.

She was lying inside the Synchronizer chamber. The glass walls glowed faintly, threads of broken equations still flickering like fireflies. Her chest heaved as she gasped for breath, each inhale sharp and painful.

The console screens blared red warnings:

“Simultaneous recursion exit… unstable… dual identity signals detected…”

Her gorgeous eyes darted left—and froze.

Akki was there.

Strapped into the opposite chamber, his tall frame trembling, chest rising and falling violently as though he'd run a thousand miles. His sharp eyes fluttered open, locking with hers across the glass.

Time stopped.

Kanvi's small hand pressed desperately against her glass wall. His hand mirrored hers, palm to palm through the barrier.

Tears streamed down her face. "You made it. Akki—you made it."

The Pull of Reality
The lab shuddered. Sparks rained from the ceiling as the AI droned coldly:

"Warning: Neural identity overlap detected. Both consciousness streams are unstable."

Akki's sharp eyes widened. His voice cracked. "Kanvi… it's not done. We're still linked. If one of us destabilizes, the other—"

"—the other dies," she finished, her gorgeous lips trembling.

Her small body shook as she pressed harder against the glass. "Then we stabilize together! I don't care what it takes."

Akki clenched his jaw, fighting to stay conscious. His tall frame looked broken, yet his eyes burned with fire. "You'd throw your life away for me?"

She sobbed, whispering fiercely, "I already did."

The Confession at the Edge
Their breaths fogged the glass, their palms still pressed together. The room flickered, half-real, half-recursion.

Akki's lips trembled as he forced the words out, raw and unguarded. "Kanvi… I love you. Every second I hid it behind equations, every moment I wasted pretending logic mattered more than you—it was always you. Always."

Her gorgeous tears spilled faster, her small body shaking violently. "Say it again. Please—say it again."

“I love you,” he whispered, stronger this time. “And I swear, even if reality collapses, even if time breaks—I’ll find you again.”

Her lips curved into a broken smile. “Then I’ll wait. In every lifetime. In every equation.”

The Cliffhanger
The chamber doors began to unlock, hissing violently. The lights blazed—too bright, too unstable.

Kanvi screamed, reaching out as the glass split apart. “Akki!”

He surged forward, breaking free of the collapsing harness, his tall frame stumbling toward her. She leapt from her chamber, small feet slamming onto the floor.

Their hands stretched across the chaos, fingertips brushing—

And then—

A blinding flash consumed the lab.

XXV.
The Last Conversation

The Aftermath

The world returned not with light, but with pain.

A sharp ringing drilled into Kanvi's ears, drowning out everything else. Her lungs fought for air, each inhale scraping like glass. She gasped, her small frame convulsing as she forced her eyes open.

The lab was unrecognizable.

The once-gleaming Synchronizer chamber lay in ruins—its glass walls cracked like spiderwebs, its circuitry sparking and hissing, the smell of burnt ozone thick in the air. Holographic threads still flickered in broken fragments, hovering briefly before dissolving into static. The giant monitors screamed with error codes:

"RECURSION COLLAPSE: UNSTABLE"
"DUAL IDENTITY SIGNALS: OVERLAP DETECTED"

Her gorgeous lashes fluttered against the smoke. Her throat burned, but her eyes searched desperately, frantically.

Where was he?

Her heart hammered. The last thing she remembered was the blinding white explosion, Akki's hand reaching for hers in the storm of numbers. The thought of waking without him clawed at her chest.

Her lips parted, trembling, a single word breaking free:
"…Akki?"

The Sight
At first, I only smoked. Sparks. Silence.

Then—movement.

Her gorgeous eyes widened as a tall silhouette emerged from the haze. Stumbling, weak, but there.

Akki.

His broad shoulders slumped against the shattered console, his chest heaving violently with every breath. A streak of blood cut across his sharp jawline, but his eyes—those sharp, unyielding eyes—were alive. They locked onto hers instantly.

And in that one glance, she felt her entire body break apart and mend all over again.

“Kanvi…” His voice was hoarse, cracked, barely more than a whisper. But it was enough to unravel her.

Her small feet staggered forward, then ran. The ruined lab blurred as she closed the distance between them, her gorgeous hair flying behind her. She collided into his chest, clutching him so tightly she thought her bones would snap.

He groaned, half in pain, half in relief, but his arms wrapped around her instantly. Strong, trembling, desperate. His tall frame curved over hers, as though shielding her from the wreckage of the universe itself.

Her gorgeous eyes squeezed shut as sobs tore from her throat. “I thought… I thought I lost you. Again. I thought you were gone—”

He buried his face in her hair, his deep voice breaking with something raw. “You nearly did. I was slipping. If it wasn’t for you…” His arms tightened, his breath shuddering. “…I’d still be trapped.”

The Closeness
They stayed like that—two shattered souls in a shattered lab—holding each other as if the world might collapse again at any second.

Kanvi’s small hands clung to the back of his torn shirt, her nails digging in. She could feel his heartbeat hammering against her chest, wild and uneven but alive. Every thud sent another wave of tears down her cheeks.

Finally, she pulled back just enough to see his face.

His sharp features were bruised, blood streaked across his jaw, his lips cut—but his eyes were what undid her. They were wet, fierce, burning with the same fire that had driven him to build impossible equations. But now, that fire was all for her.

Her small hands cupped his face, trembling. “You idiot… You absolute, brilliant idiot. You left me once. Don’t you dare do it again.”

A faint, broken smile tugged at his lips. “You still look gorgeous when you’re angry.”

Her laugh cracked through her sobs, wet and shaky. She shook her head, her gorgeous hair brushing against his cheek. “And you still flirt like a scientist. Badly.”

The Fragile Breath
Their foreheads pressed together, breaths mingling. The ruined lab around them seemed to fade, the alarms dimming beneath the fragile silence that wrapped just the two of them.

For a moment, it didn't matter that the air was filled with smoke, that the machines screamed collapse. All that mattered was the warmth of his skin, the tremble of his breath, the desperate way his hands refused to let go of her small frame.

Kanvi whispered, her voice raw and soft, "I swear, Akki… if I wake up one more time without you, I'll tear down every law of physics myself to bring you back."

His eyes closed briefly, his lips brushing her forehead. "Then I'll save you the trouble. Because this time… I'm not leaving."

Her gorgeous eyes fluttered shut, her lips trembling into a smile even as tears burned down her cheeks. "Promise?"

His voice was a vow. "On every equation I've ever written."

The Conversation Begins
For a long, fragile silence, they just breathed together. Alive. Together.

Then, slowly, Akki pulled back, though his hands still framed her small face. His sharp eyes searched hers, heavy with something more than relief.

"Kanvi…" he said quietly, a weight in his voice that made her heart freeze. "…we need to talk."

Her gorgeous brows furrowed, her grip on him tightening instinctively. "Don't you dare say goodbye."

He shook his head, pain flickering in his eyes. "Not goodbye. Not yet. But there's something I have to tell you."

The alarms wailed louder, red light bathing the ruined lab. But for both of them, the world had narrowed to a single point—two souls, standing on the edge of truth.

And in that suspended moment, as everything else fell apart, Kanvi whispered back, "Then tell me. Tell me everything."

The Confession

The alarms screamed louder, throwing red pulses across the ruined lab.
Error codes scrolled endlessly across the shattered console:

"NEURAL IDENTITY OVERLAP: CRITICAL"
"SURVIVAL CHANCE: 37%"

But inside that chaos, there was silence.

Kanvi's gorgeous eyes locked onto Akki's, her small hands still cupping his battered face. Her tears shimmered in the crimson light, and for once, she wasn't afraid of them.

"Akki…" she whispered, "…you said you need to tell me something."

His tall frame trembled, his sharp jaw tightening as if every word cut him from the inside. He looked down at her, eyes burning like molten glass.

"I've wasted years hiding this," he said hoarsely. "I buried it behind equations, logic, and research. I told myself that saving humanity mattered more, that science had to come first. But all along…"

He trailed off, his breath shaking. Kanvi's small fingers brushed the cut on his lip, urging him silently, desperately, to continue.

His sharp eyes softened, breaking. "It was you. Kanvi—it was always you."

The Breaking Wall
Her heart slammed against her ribs. For a moment, the alarms, the wreckage, even the pain—all of it faded.

Her gorgeous lips parted, her voice a broken whisper. "Say it again."

He swallowed hard, his tall frame shivering as though holding the weight of galaxies. His forehead dropped against hers, his breath hot and trembling.

"I love you."

Her knees nearly gave out. The words—simple, raw, undeniable—burned through her veins like fire.

Tears poured freely down her cheeks as she whispered back, "You… you waited this long to tell me?"

A faint, broken laugh escaped him. "I was a coward. A scientist who thought numbers were safer than feelings. But now—" his voice cracked, his sharp eyes wet, "—now I'd burn every formula, every theory, every dream, just to keep you in my arms."

The Kiss of Truth
Kanvi's sob broke into a laugh. Her small hands gripped the collar of his torn shirt, yanking him down. Their lips met—hard, desperate, shattering.

It wasn't a gentle kiss; it was raw, furious, alive. Every unsaid word, every wasted second, every stolen moment was poured into that collision. Her small body trembled against his tall frame, his arms wrapping around her as if to fuse her into him forever.

The alarms screamed, sparks fell like rain, but they didn't care. The world could end, and they'd still be kissing.

When she finally pulled back, gasping for breath, her gorgeous eyes glowed with a fire that outshone every machine in the room.

"You don't get to leave me again, Akki. Do you hear me?"

His hand slid into her hair, trembling, his lips brushing her temple. "Even if time collapses. Even if reality breaks. I swear, Kanvi—I'll never let go."

The Warning
But the lab wasn't listening to their vows.

The AI's voice cut through, cold and merciless:

"Warning: Dual consciousness cannot stabilize. Resolution required: Only one neural stream may persist."

Kanvi froze. Her gorgeous lips parted as her head snapped toward the screen. "What… what does that mean?"

Akki's sharp eyes darkened. His tall frame stiffened, and in that silence, she understood.

Her small hands dropped from his face. "No. No, don't you dare say it—"

He took her wrists gently, lifting her trembling hands back to his chest. "Kanvi… the system's telling us the truth. Two identities can't overlap in one recursion. One of us has to…" He couldn't finish.

Her gorgeous eyes blazed with defiance. "No. We'll find another way. We'll rewrite the system, we'll hack the AI—"

"Kanvi." His voice was soft, breaking. "You know as well as I do. There isn't time."

The Tearful Vow
Her tears streamed freely now, her small fists pounding against his chest. "You selfish bastard. You think I'll let you sacrifice yourself again? You think I'll stay behind while you vanish?"

He caught her wrists, pulling her closer until their bodies collided. His sharp eyes locked on hers, fierce and wet.

"Because I love you." His voice thundered, shattering, desperate. "Because if one of us has to go—it's not going to be you."

Her sobs tore through the lab. She clung to him, shaking her head wildly. “No… no, Akki… you can’t… you can’t say that. Not after finally telling me.”

He kissed her again, softer this time, lingering. When he pulled back, his lips trembled against hers.

“I had to tell you. I couldn’t leave without saying it. Not again.”

The alarms blared louder. Sparks rained. The AI repeated the cold truth.

But in the middle of the collapsing world, Kanvi and Akki held each other—two souls on the edge of the most impossible choice.

And for the first time, both knew: this was their last conversation.

The Choice

The lab’s alarms reached a fever pitch. The ruined Synchronizer glowed like a dying sun, its fractured glass throwing ghostly reflections of Kanvi and Akki across the smoke-filled chamber.

On the central screen, the warning pulsed mercilessly:

“CRITICAL ERROR: DUAL NEURAL STREAM DETECTED.”
“RESOLUTION REQUIRED: SELECT PRIMARY SURVIVAL CANDIDATE.”
“Time Remaining: 09:59.”

The AI’s calm, synthetic voice echoed through the chaos:
“One identity must collapse to restore systemic stability. Choose: Kanvi… or Akki.”

The Shattered Silence
Kanvi froze, her gorgeous eyes widening as the words stabbed through her like knives. She turned to Akki, her small hands shaking violently.

“They want us to choose?!” she screamed, voice breaking. “Like we’re equations to balance? Like we’re just… variables to erase?”

Akki’s sharp jaw tightened, his tall frame steady even as his insides tore apart. His eyes never left hers. “It was always going to come to this.”

Her gorgeous eyes burned with tears. “No. No, we’ll find a way—”

“There isn’t time, Kanvi.” His voice cracked, his hands finding hers, gripping them tightly. “If we don’t decide, the system will decide for us. And it won’t choose gently.”

Her Refusal

She ripped her hands free, her small frame trembling with fury. “Then let it collapse! Let it take me instead—I won’t let it take you!”

Akki stepped forward, his tall frame towering, his sharp eyes blazing with anguish. “Don’t you understand? I can’t let it be you!”

“Why?!” she shouted, tears streaming. “Why do you always get to decide who stays and who goes? Why is it always you protecting me? Why not this once—why not let me save you?”

His voice thundered, raw and broken: “Because I love you!”

Her breath caught. The words hung in the smoke, searing, unshakable.

The Fierce Embrace
He pulled her into him so suddenly she gasped, her small body pressed against his chest, his arms wrapping around her like iron. His voice shook against her hair.

“You are the constant in every equation, Kanvi. Without you, nothing converges. You think I built all of this for humanity? For science? No. I built it for the chance to come back to you.”

Her gorgeous lips trembled as she clung to him, sobbing into his torn shirt. “You don’t get to do this. You don’t get to say that and then leave me. I won’t let you.”

His hand tilted her chin up, his sharp eyes locking onto hers with unbearable tenderness. “Then promise me. Promise me you’ll live. Even if it’s without me.”

Her small hands slapped his chest weakly, over and over. “I can’t. I can’t live without you.”

The AI’s Countdown
The AI’s voice sliced through their cries:

“Decision pending. Neural collapse at 08:00.”

The screens split into two profiles—Kanvi and Akki—each glowing, each pulsing. A cruel binary choice.

Kanvi’s gorgeous eyes flashed with fury as she turned toward the console. “I’ll override it! I’ll rewrite the algorithm—”

Akki caught her wrist, his grip trembling but firm. “Kanvi. You know it’s hard-coded. There’s no rewrite. Not now.”

Her lips curled into a snarl through her tears. “Then we break it. Together.”

The Shared Desperation

They collapsed to their knees amid the sparks and smoke, clutching each other as the countdown ticked mercilessly above them.

Kanvi pressed her forehead to his, their breaths mingling, ragged. “I don’t care what the system says. I don’t care if reality itself collapses. If you go, I go.”

His sharp eyes glistened, his hand cradling her cheek. “Kanvi…” He kissed her, fierce and trembling, pouring every last shred of himself into her. The world could burn, the system could fail, and still he kissed her.

When they broke apart, both gasping, his voice was a whisper drowned in fire. “I’d rather die here with you than live in a world without you.”

Her tears fell faster, soaking his shirt. “Then we don’t choose. We fight.”

The Impossible Plan
She pulled back suddenly, her gorgeous eyes blazing with determination through the tears. Her small hands flew across the broken console, sparks scorching her skin. “If the system needs one stream, then we’ll force it to take both. Merge us.”

Akki’s eyes widened. “Kanvi—no, that’s—”

“Impossible?” she snapped, her gorgeous lips trembling. “So was recursion. So I was surviving this far. If our minds overlap, if our patterns sync perfectly—maybe it won’t see us as two.”

Her small hand reached back for his, gripping it fiercely. “Maybe it’ll see us as one.”

His sharp eyes locked onto hers, torn between terror and awe. “Kanvi… if we do that, we won’t be us anymore. We’ll be… something else.”

Her tears glistened in the red light, but her smile was fierce. “Then at least we’ll still be together.”

The AI’s cold voice boomed again:

“Time Remaining: 06:00. Select Primary Candidate.”

The screens glowed, waiting for a choice.

But Kanvi and Akki only held onto each other tighter, ready to defy the system itself.

The Sacrifice

The countdown thundered across the shattered lab:

“Time Remaining: 05:59…”

Each second felt like a hammer falling against their hearts.

Kanvi’s small body trembled as she clung to Akki, her gorgeous eyes wide with tears. The flickering red light washed over them, painting every desperate tear, every broken breath.

Her lips pressed frantically against his chest, his neck, his sharp jawline, as though memorizing every inch of him before the system could tear him away.

“Don’t you dare leave me, Akki,” she whispered against his skin, her voice cracking. “Don’t you dare.”

His tall frame shook as his hands ran through her hair, down her back, pulling her small body closer than ever. His sharp eyes squeezed shut, his lips trembling against her temple.

“I’m not leaving,” he whispered fiercely. “Not in here. Not in dreams. Not in any lifetime.”

The Peak of Closeness
Her gorgeous face tilted up to his, wet with tears but blazing with love. Their lips met again—slow, trembling, deeper than before. It wasn’t desperation now, it was surrender.

Her small hands gripped his torn shirt, clutching as though she could fuse herself into him. His strong arms locked around her, his tall frame bending down to her height, holding her like she was oxygen itself.

Their kiss lingered, stretching into eternity, their breaths mingling, their tears mixing. The alarms, the smoke, the AI’s cold warnings—all of it melted away.

For that fragile span of moments, there were no choices. No death. No collapse. Only Kanvi and Akki lost to each other.

The AI’s Cruel Reminder
But the world intruded again.

“Time Remaining: 04:00. Selection is mandatory.”

The screens glowed brighter, Kanvi’s profile on one side, Akki’s on the other. A cruel binary.

Her gorgeous eyes tore away from the kiss, blazing with defiance. “We’re not choosing. We’re merging. Together.”

She spun toward the console, her small fingers flying across the cracked keys, sparks stinging her skin. “Come on… come on…”

The AI’s cold reply: “Override attempt detected. Insufficient authority.”

“Damn it!” she cried, slamming her fists against the console. Her tears fell harder, dripping onto the scorched surface.

Akki stepped behind her, his tall frame towering, his hand resting on her trembling shoulder. “Kanvi… stop.”

Her head whipped back, her gorgeous hair flying. “No! I won’t stop. I won’t let them take you from me. Not now—not after everything.”

His sharp eyes softened, unbearably tender. “I know.”

The Secret Move
While her small body leaned against the console, Akki’s sharp fingers moved quickly, almost invisibly, across the hidden control panel embedded in the Synchronizer’s side.

He had designed the system. He knew its backdoors.
He knew how to trick it.

A single override code, buried deep in its logic: his name.

As his tall frame shielded her from the sparks, he entered the sequence silently. The screen flickered, the system preparing to finalize one profile. Hi.

Kanvi didn’t see it. She was too busy fighting the AI, tears burning her vision.

The Final Embrace
He turned her toward him, gripping her small shoulders tightly, forcing her to meet his sharp, trembling eyes.

“Kanvi…” His voice cracked like thunder breaking. “Look at me. Listen to me.”

Her gorgeous eyes were wild with grief. “Don’t say it. Don’t you dare say goodbye.”

He shook his head violently, pressing his forehead to hers. “It’s not goodbye. It’s a promise.”

Her tears smeared against his skin as he kissed her fiercely, pouring every ounce of his soul into her. Her small hands clawed into his back, holding him with the strength of someone trying to stop time itself.

When they broke apart, both gasping, he whispered against her lips: “Live. For me.”

Her sob shattered. “No—Akki, please, no…”

The Betrayal of Love
The AI’s voice cut through, cold and final:

“Selection received: Primary Candidate — Kanvi.”
“Commencing stabilization. Time Remaining: 02:00.”

Kanvi froze. Her gorgeous eyes widened in horror as she spun toward the screen. Her profile glowed bright, stable. Akki’s was fading.

“No…” she whispered, stumbling back. Her small hands slammed against the console. “No! Cancel it! Akki, what did you do?!”

He caught her arms, pulling her back to him as she thrashed. His tall frame shook as he held her against his chest, his sharp eyes wet but calm.

“I chose you,” he said simply.

Her scream ripped through the lab. “You bastard! You selfish bastard! You can’t do this to me!”

Her fists pounded against his chest, but he held her tighter, refusing to let go.

“Kanvi… I had to. You’re the one who deserves to live. The world still needs you. I still need you, even if I’m gone.”

Her sobs tore through her. She clutched his shirt, collapsing into him. “I don’t want the world. I only want you.”

The Countdown Nears
The AI’s voice was merciless:

“Final stabilization commencing. Time Remaining: 01:00.”

The chamber hummed, its broken circuits flaring back to life, energy surging into Kanvi’s stream. Akki’s outline in the hologram flickered, fading, breaking into static.

Kanvi’s gorgeous eyes lifted, wide and wild, to meet his sharp gaze. “Please. Please don’t do this. Take me with you. Merge us, collapse us, I don’t care—just don’t leave me.”

Akki’s lips trembled into the faintest smile, broken and beautiful. His tall frame bent to her height, his lips brushing hers one last time.

“Then wait for me. In every dream. In every lifetime. I’ll find you.”

Her tears drowned her voice. “Akki—”

The AI interrupted, cold and final:

“Stabilization completes in 30 seconds.”

The Last Words

The chamber trembled like a dying heart. Sparks showered from broken wires. The holographic threads writhed in chaos, collapsing into static as the AI’s voice cut through:

“Stabilization: 00:30.”

The timer glowed in blood-red digits, every second bleeding away.

Kanvi’s gorgeous eyes locked onto Akki’s flickering form. His tall frame was still solid in her arms, but already, faint static danced across his outline. His touch burned warm against her, but she could feel the weight of absence pressing in.

“No,” she whispered, clutching him tighter, her small hands gripping his torn shirt as if she could anchor him to reality. “No, no, no… you can’t vanish. Not like this.”

Akki’s sharp eyes softened, his lips trembling as he brushed her hair back, tucking it gently behind her ear. His touch lingered, memorizing her. “Kanvi…” His voice cracked, breaking. “Look at me. Just me. Forget the alarms, forget the countdown. Just… me.”

Her tears blurred everything but him. She nodded violently, pressing her gorgeous forehead to his, their breaths mingling.

The Timeless Kiss
He kissed her again—slow, lingering, aching. A kiss that wasn’t just lips, but lifetimes colliding. His tall frame bent down, trembling, as her small body melted against him. Her tears stained his mouth, but neither pulled away.

The AI’s voice cut through:

“00:20.”

They didn’t care.

Her gorgeous lips broke against his, whispering between gasps: “Don’t leave… don’t leave… don’t you dare leave…”

His sharp jaw trembled, his voice muffled against her. “I don’t want to. I swear, Kanvi… every part of me is screaming to stay. But if one of us has to go—it will never be you.”

The Final Confession
He pulled back just enough to look into her tear-soaked eyes. His sharp gaze burned with everything he had never said.

“I love you,” he said hoarsely, every word ripping out of him. “I love you more than physics, more than time, more than life itself. You are the equation I could never solve, Kanvi. You are the constant I never deserved. And if this is my last breath, then let it be spent saying your name.”

Her sob cracked the world. She pressed her small hands to his face, her thumbs trembling against his wet cheeks. “Akki… you stupid, brilliant, stubborn man. I love you too. I’ve always loved you. From the classrooms, from the labs, from every damn dream—you were always mine. And you’ll always be.”

The Collapse Begins
The AI’s voice thundered:

“00:10. Final stabilization in progress.”

Akki’s outline flickered violently now, static tearing through his tall frame. His hands shook as he cupped her small face, desperate to hold her one last time.

Her gorgeous eyes widened in terror. “No! No, don’t fade! Stay—Akki, please stay!”

He leaned in, pressing his forehead to hers one last time. His lips brushed hers in the softest, most fragile kiss of their lives. A kiss like a whispered prayer.

“Promise me,” he murmured, his sharp eyes wet. “Promise me you’ll live. That you’ll laugh again. That you’ll keep dreaming—even if I’m not there.”

Her sob tore through her throat. “I can’t. Not without you.”

“You can,” he whispered fiercely. “Because you’re Kanvi. And you’re stronger than me.”

The Last Glimpse
“00:05.”

Her small hands clawed at his chest as his tall frame began to dissolve, static ripping through him. She screamed, raw and broken, “No! Akki, please—don’t go! Don’t you dare leave me alone!”

His voice cracked into a whisper as his lips brushed her ear: “I’ll never leave you. Every dream, every shadow, every heartbeat—you’ll find me there.”

“00:03.”

His outline was almost gone now, his sharp jawline the last thing she could still see. His eyes burned into hers, searing themselves into her soul.

“00:02.”

Her gorgeous lips trembled as she cried out, “Akki!”

And with his last breath, his voice, breaking into nothingness, whispered:

“I love you, Kanvi.”

“00:01.”

The Silence After
The chamber roared with light, then went deathly still.

Kanvi collapsed to her knees, her small body shaking violently, her gorgeous hands clutching empty air where Akki had been. Her sobs echoed through the ruined lab, piercing the silence, breaking the world itself.

The AI’s voice chimed coldly, mercilessly:
“Stabilization complete. Primary Candidate: Kanvi. Secondary stream—terminated.”

Her gorgeous eyes stared at the screen, wide and wet, as Akki’s profile vanished into black.

Her scream tore out of her throat, raw and endless, shattering against the steel walls.

And in that silence, her heart whispered the truth:
This was the last conversation.

Epilogue - Beyond The Dream

The world outside the lab was quiet. Too quiet.

Kanvi stepped out into the pale dawn, her small frame trembling under the weight of silence. The air was damp, carrying the faint scent of rain on steel. Behind her, the ruins of the Synchronizer smoldered, sparks fading like dying stars.
She should have felt relief. She had survived.
But survival without him felt like a sentence, not salvation.
Her gorgeous eyes scanned the horizon, lost, waiting—half-expecting his tall frame to appear from the smoke, his sharp voice to call her name. But there was only emptiness.

Her lips trembled as she whispered into the breeze, "Akki…"

The Journal
Weeks later, Kanvi sat in her small study, her white coat draped over her chair. The world outside had returned to routine—sirens replaced by birdsong, chaos replaced by calm.
Yet her nights were never still.
On her desk lay Akki's old journal—tattered, filled with equations and half-finished theories. She traced her small fingers over his handwriting, every number and symbol alive with his presence.
One page was marked with a single line, scrawled in his sharp, rushed hand:

"Dreams don't end. They change their layers."
Her gorgeous eyes blurred with tears as she pressed the page to her lips.
The Dream's Echo
That night, she fell asleep at her desk.
And in her dream, she was walking through a vast field under a sky stitched with glowing threads. The air shimmered with colors she could not name. And there, across the horizon—

A silhouette.

Tall. Familiar. Waiting.
Her heart slammed against her ribs. Her small legs moved on their own, carrying her faster, faster—her voice breaking into the dream.
"Akki!"
The figure turned, just enough for her to catch the faint outline of his sharp jaw, his steady gaze.
But as she reached for him, the threads wove between them, pulling him just out of reach.
The Subtle Hint
Kanvi woke with a start, her gorgeous eyes wet with tears but her lips curved into the faintest smile.
Because even though he was gone, the dream had shown her something.

The layers were still there. Still alive. Still shifting.

And somewhere, beyond the veil of reality, Akki's promise still echoed—
"Every dream, every shadow, every heartbeat—you'll find me there."

Kanvi closed the journal gently, holding it against her chest as the dawn broke outside her window.
Her tears glistened in the light, but for the first time, she didn't feel only grief. She felt… him.
And with a shaky breath, she whispered to the morning, "Until we meet again, Akki. In the next layer."
The world was quiet. Calm. Healing.
But deep within the silence, the dream had only just begun.

Timeline Of Events

Prologue – Childhood Bonds

Kanvi and Akki are introduced as schoolmates.
Both excel in studies; curious about science and life.
Their innocent friendship sows seeds of future love and shared destiny.

Early Youth (Chapters 1–4)

Reunion: In their 20s, Kanvi (Doctor) and Akki (Scientist) cross paths again.
Akki's Research: He reveals obsession with dream recursion and building the Synchronizer.
Kanvi's Caution: She warns of risks but supports him emotionally.
First Romance Sparks: Subtle flirtation, playful banter, silent promises.
First Shadow: Strange dream anomalies appear.

The Discovery Phase (Chapters 5–9)

Abnormal REM patterns disturb Kanvi.
Library archives reveal hidden quantum sleep studies.
Playful rivalry at a science fair deepens their bond.
Late-night walk and video call build emotional connection.
First Layered Dream: They experience dream-within-dream, confirming recursion is real.

The Escalation (Chapters 10–14)

Device glitches merge dream fragments with waking life.
A shadowed figure begins haunting their shared dreams.
EEG patterns show synchronization of their minds.
Consciously meeting in a dream confirms their bond.
Mapping dream layers reveals an anomaly that science cannot explain.

The Confrontation Begins (Chapters 15–18)

Shadow entity confronted → warns that only one can survive.
Forgotten Formula discovered: recursion equation predicts collapse.
Risky rescue across shattered dream bridge → Kanvi nearly loses Akki.
Reality & dream collide → holograms and tech chaos mix with extreme romance.

The Collapse (Chapter 19)

Shadow figures attack violently.
Emotional and physical climax → worlds crumble, their love holds them together.

The Point of No Return (Chapters 20–22)

Multi-layered recursion traps them deeper.
Akki's tech-based rescue pushes him to breaking point.
Shadow demands a sacrifice → heartbreak builds.

The Hope & The Formula (Chapter 23–24)

A hidden equation offers a possible solution.
Amid humor and closeness, they see hope.
Final Experiment attempted → simultaneous wake-up through AI.
Romance reaches peak, but danger doubles.

The Climax – Last Conversation (Chapter 25)

System forces stabilization: only one can survive.
Akki chooses to sacrifice himself.
Kanvi and Akki share their last, heartbreaking dialogue.
Akki's final words: "I love you, Kanvi."
He vanishes. Kanvi survives, broken.

Closure (Epilogue)

Kanvi learns to live with his absence.
Journal becomes her lifeline, reminding her of his brilliance and love.
Dreams show Akki's silhouette — hinting he still exists in another layer.
Epilogue: Calm acceptance, symbolic closure, subtle foreshadow that dream layers continue.

Glossary

A

Aftermath – the result or consequences after a major event, usually destructive.

Anomaly – something unusual, irregular, or unexpected.

Arc – the gradual transformation or journey of a character.

Archive – a collection of old records, documents, or files.

Artificial Intelligence (AI) – computer systems designed to mimic human thinking.

Algorithm – step-by-step method for solving problems, especially in computers.

Apparition – a ghost-like or sudden appearance.

Algorithmic Sequence – a series of steps run by a computer program.

Antechamber – a small room leading into a larger, more important one (used symbolically for pre-dream states).

Auditory Hallucination – hearing sounds that aren't really there.

Algorithmic Grid – mathematical framework of equations used to control recursion.

Annihilation Point – moment where existence collapses into nothingness.

Asymptote – mathematical line a curve approaches but never touches.

Augmented Reality (AR) – overlay of digital images on the physical world.

Algorithmic Sacrifice – Akki's final override code where his own presence was exchanged for system stability.

Anomaly Rift – irregular break between dream layers.

Afterimage – lingering vision left after looking at something bright; used for fading memories.

B

Bandwidth – capacity of a system to process signals or data.

Binary Code – system of ones and zeros used by computers.

Breakthrough – a sudden, dramatic discovery or progress.

Bandwidth Saturation – when data transfer reaches maximum capacity.

Biofeedback – monitoring body signals (heartbeat, brain waves) for control.

Binary Paradox – contradiction in yes/no systems of logic.

Binary Collapse – failure of a yes/no coded system, leaving uncertainty.

Bio-Signature – unique biological data (heartbeat, brainwave pattern).

Breakpoint – critical moment where the system either survives or fails.

Beyond the Dream – symbolic state of closure, calmness after chaos.

C

Clarity – being clear and easy to understand.

Collapse – sudden breakdown, failure, or falling apart.

Conscious Dream (Lucid Dream) – a dream where the dreamer is aware they are dreaming.

Curiosity – strong desire to know or learn something.

Circuitry – interconnected wires and chips inside machines.

Clandestine – secret, hidden, or done in a concealed way.

Collapse Sequence – chain reaction leading to complete failure or breakdown.

Convergence – when separate things come together and join as one.

Cerebral Cortex – outer layer of the brain, responsible for memory and awareness.

Cognitive Dissonance – mental conflict when holding two contradictory ideas.

Conduit – a channel or pathway for something (energy, signals, or even emotions).

Cryptic – mysterious, hard to understand.

Chaos Equation – mathematical formula predicting unpredictable patterns.

Cipher – coded message or secret writing.

Cognitive Threshold – the brain's limit of perception/processing.

Collapse Vector – direction of system breakdown in equations.

Catalyst Equation – formula that triggered dream recursion collapse.

Chronometric Drift – misalignment in time measurement between dream and real world.

Cipher Lock – advanced mathematical lock for data protection.

Closure – emotional or narrative completion, resolution.

D

Device Glitches – small errors or malfunctions in machines.

Disoriented – confused about where you are or what is happening.

Dream Recursion – dreaming inside another dream; an endless loop.

Duality – having two sides or aspects (like science and emotion).

Database – organized collection of information.

Decryption – unlocking hidden or secret code.

Distortion – twisted or altered version of reality.

Dual Consciousness – state of being aware of two realities (dream + real) at once.

Data Stream – continuous flow of information.

Defragmentation – reorganizing scattered pieces of data into order.

Dissociation – detachment from reality or one's surroundings.

Distorted Timeline – when the sequence of events becomes warped or unclear.

Decoding Matrix – system for breaking hidden codes.

Determinism – the idea that events are pre-set by cause and effect.

Dimensional Rift – tear or opening between different realities.

Displacement – shift of time, space, or emotional state.

Dimensional Overlay – different realities projected on top of each other.

Disintegration Point – stage where identity/matter starts breaking apart.

Dream Convergence – when multiple dreamers' minds meet in the same dream world.

Dual Resonance – Kanvi and Akki's synchronized heartbeats/brainwaves.

E

EEG (Electroencephalogram) – a medical test that records brain wave activity.

Entity – a separate, independent being or force (like the shadow).

Entropy – scientific word for disorder, chaos, or breakdown.

Equation – a mathematical statement showing two sides are equal.

Echo – a sound or idea that repeats after the original.

Electromagnetic Pulse (EMP) – burst of energy that can disable electronic devices.

Encrypted – locked or coded data for secrecy.

Extrapolation – predicting something by extending known facts.

Echo Chamber – a place/situation where ideas repeat and grow stronger.

Echoed Memory – memory fragments repeating like sound echoes.

Electrode Array – a set of sensors used to capture brain activity.

Exponential Growth – increase at a rapid multiplying rate.

Encrypted Signal – a coded message not readable without a key.

Eigenvalue – advanced math term for characteristic numbers in matrix equations.

Encryption Layer – digital protective coding around information.

Equilibrium Point – balanced state where opposing forces are equal.

Exorcism Algorithm – symbolic name for a code designed to push out the shadow entity.

Eclipse Metaphor – symbolic blackout where one force overshadows another.

Emotional Singularity – point of overwhelming feelings, beyond control.

Equation of Sacrifice – final unsolvable math formula Akki left behind.

Eternal Recurrence – idea that events repeat infinitely through time.

F

Foreshadow – a hint or clue about something that will happen later.

Fragment – a small broken piece of something larger.

Fractal – infinitely repeating pattern, seen in math or nature.

Feedback Loop – cycle where output feeds back into system input.

Fragmentation – breaking into parts or incomplete pieces.

Fissure – a deep crack or split, literal or metaphorical.

Frequency Modulation – adjusting the speed of signals or waves.

Futile Loop – endless cycle with no solution.

Fractal Geometry – math of repeating complex patterns.

Frequency Resonance – alignment of wave signals at the same pitch.

Feedback Distortion – corrupted repetition inside a system.

Fragmented Identity – pieces of self scattered between dream layers.

Frequency Collapse – system's rhythmic signals dying out suddenly.

Foreshadowing Codes – earlier AI hints that predicted the ending.

Foreshadowing Layer – hint that dreams may still continue.

G

Glitches – small unexpected errors in technology or systems.

Gravity (Symbolic use) – seriousness or heaviness of a situation.

Gridlock – complete standstill or blockage, literal or metaphorical.

Gravitational Pull – the force that attracts objects; symbolically, emotional pull.

Glitching Reality – when real-world images "flicker" like computer errors.

Genetic Marker – DNA pattern used for identification.

Grid Overlay – network of lines used to map or organize data visually.

Gravitational Singularity – point where gravity becomes infinite (black hole).

Ghost Code – leftover lines of program acting unpredictably.

Graph Plot – mathematical diagram of data points.

Grid Collapse – total failure of the mapped dream system.

Ghost Signal – Akki's final faint digital presence inside Kanvi's EEG.

Gravitational Pull (Metaphor) – Kanvi's inability to escape Akki's memory.

Grid Reweaving – rebuilding of collapsed dream structure.

H

Hypnosis – trance-like state of deep focus, often linked with dreams.

Holographic – a 3D light-based image or projection.

Haunting – something that stays in memory or feeling, often unsettling.

Hallucination – seeing things that aren't really there.

Hypothesis – a scientific guess or assumption to be tested.

Hybrid Reality – mixture of physical and digital/virtual worlds.

Hall of Mirrors – metaphor for reflections and illusions that confuse perception.

Hypersensitivity – extreme sensitivity to stimuli (light, sound, touch).

Hybrid Algorithm – mixture of different computing methods.

Heisenberg Uncertainty – physics principle: can't measure position and velocity exactly at once.

Hypnagogic State – drowsy condition between wakefulness and sleep.

Hyperreality – reality mixed so deeply with illusion that they're indistinguishable.

Heartbeat Echo – symbolic resonance of two lovers' heartbeats, even across realities.

Holographic Memory – 3D projection of stored events.

Hypothetical Constant – placeholder value in Akki's unfinished formula.

I

Illusion – false appearance or deceptive vision.

Immersed – deeply involved in or absorbed by something.

Instinct – natural feeling or response without conscious thought.

Interface – a point where humans interact with machines.

Integration – combining different systems into one.

Infiltration – secretly entering or gaining access.

Illumination – light or sudden understanding.

Inception Point – the first trigger of dream recursion.

Inhibitor – something that slows or stops a process.

Introspection – deep examination of one's own thoughts and feelings.

Infinity Loop – endless cycle with no exit.

Interference Pattern – overlap of signals or energies forming strange shapes.

Inversion – reversal of normal order (time, space, or thought).

Illusion of Continuity – the mind's belief that broken events flow seamlessly.

Interference Node – system point where dream bleed caused corruption.

Irreversible Equation – math that once solved, cannot be undone.

L

Labyrinth – a complex maze or confusing path (used for dreams).

Lucid – clear; also refers to being aware during a dream.

Latency – time delay in a system's response.

Liminal Space – a state of being in-between (neither dream nor reality fully).

Logic Matrix – structured system of logical connections (used in computers).

Latency Period – delay before something begins to act.

Lattice Structure – network of crossing lines, often used in science for patterns.

Lucidity Spike – sudden burst of awareness inside a dream.

Limit Cycle – repeating stable patterns in chaos theory.

Luminosity – brightness or light intensity.

Linguistic Code – hidden meaning in symbols or language.

Latent Memory – hidden memory that emerges later.

Layer Convergence – overlapping of dream levels into one.

Logical Paradox – statement that contradicts itself yet holds meaning.

M

Mirage – an illusion caused by heat/light, used symbolically for false hope.

Mystique – a mysterious quality that fascinates or attracts.

Manifestation – the act of something invisible becoming visible or real.

Multiverse – theory of multiple parallel universes.

Malfunction – failure of a machine to work properly.

Magnetic Flux – flow of magnetic energy.

Memory Residue – fragments of memory left behind after an event.

Morphogenesis – process of forming shapes or structures (biological/psychological).

Matrix Collapse – when a grid-based system fails entirely.

Metaphysical Rift – breaks beyond physical reality, into abstract existence.

Monotone Signal – unchanging, flat signal tone.

Mathematical Horizon – boundary beyond which no further calculation is possible.

Memory Anchor – object or signal used to stabilize someone in a dream.

Multilayered Dreaming – dreams stacked inside each other recursively.

Metaphorical Horizon – ending that suggests a new beginning.

N

Neural Feedback – brain signals sent and received in loops through devices.

Neuroscience – scientific study of the nervous system and brain.

Nightmare Loop – recurring horrifying dream that traps the dreamer.

Neurolink – interface connecting brain to technology.

Neural Oscillations – rhythmic brain wave patterns.

Null State – condition of emptiness, zero input/output.

Neural Overdrive – brain activity running at dangerously high levels.

Node Point – central hub of a network.

Non-Euclidean Geometry – strange mathematical shapes that defy normal rules.

Neural Signature – unique pattern of someone's brainwaves.

Null Equation – a formula that cancels itself out, symbolizing emptiness.

Nocturnal Paradox – contradiction experienced during night dreams.

O

Obsession – a thought or idea that dominates someone's mind.

Overlapping – when two things happen or exist on top of each other.

Ozone – a sharp-smelling gas, often linked with electricity.

Oscillation – movement back and forth in a regular rhythm.

Override – to bypass or take control away from a system.

Oblivion – complete emptiness, nothingness, or destruction.

Overclocking – forcing a machine or brain beyond its safe capacity.

Obfuscation – deliberately making something unclear or confusing.

Optical Illusion – misleading image seen by the eyes.

Oscillatory Decay – vibrations slowly dying out.

Override Protocol – emergency system control that bypasses rules.

Omniscient AI – AI system with near “all-knowing” data capacity.

Override Command – Akki’s secret code that forced his sacrifice.

Ontological Echo – existence echoing across layers of time.

Oblivion State – final collapse into nothingness.

P

Paradox – something that seems impossible or contradictory but may be true.

Projection – an image or vision cast outward (by mind or technology).

Pulse – a rhythmic beat, often used for heart or energy patterns.

Paralysis (Sleep Paralysis) – when the body cannot move during dream states.

Parallel Reality – a co-existing version of the world.

Pulse Waves – repeated bursts of energy measured in signals.

Paranormal Residue – leftover energy hinting at ghostly activity.

Parietal Lobe – part of the brain that processes sensory input.

Pulse Synchrony – heartbeat or signals aligning in rhythm.

Phase Shift – sudden change in energy wave alignment.

Polynomial Chaos – type of mathematical equation showing randomness.

Projection Mapping – advanced holography projecting visuals onto 3D surfaces.

Phase Collapse – sudden disintegration of dream stability.

Phantom Equation – unsolved formula that continues to haunt the system.

Pulse Memory – memory replaying like rhythmic waves.

Q

Quantum Entanglement – particles linked so strongly that a change in one affects the other instantly, even across distance.

Quantum Patterning – using quantum principles to map dream layers.

Quantum Fluctuations – sudden, temporary changes in quantum energy.

Quotient – result of dividing one number by another; symbolically used for division of minds.

Quantum Superposition – particles existing in multiple states at once.

Quasi-Stable – nearly stable but vulnerable to collapse.

Quorum Signal – a collective "agreement" signal in AI nodes.

Quantum Bridge – theoretical connection allowing passage across realities.

Quasi-Infinite Loop – almost endless recursion, broken only by sacrifice.

Quotient of Loss – symbolic math term Akki used for love + pain balance.

R

Recursion – repetition in loops; in dreams, dream within dream.

Rescue – saving someone from danger.

Resonance – vibration, echo, or deep emotional/mental connection.

Reality Fragments – pieces of real life appearing inside dreams.

Residual Effect – leftover influence of an earlier action.

Recalibration – resetting or adjusting a machine for accuracy.

Replication – duplication or exact copy.

Reverberation – repeated echo of sound, memory, or energy.

Residual Consciousness – leftover awareness after waking/dreaming.

Recursive Trap – loop that keeps folding back into itself.

Recursive Equation – equation where the result feeds back into itself.

Residual Phantom – leftover shadow-like presence.

Resonant Frequency – natural frequency at which an object/system vibrates.

Recursive Collapse – dream folding in on itself infinitely.

Resonant Bond – deep emotional + neural connection between Kanvi and Akki.

Rewoven Equation – Kanvi's attempt to rebuild from Akki's fragments.

S

Silhouette – dark outline of a person/thing against a light background.

Stabilization – the act of making something balanced or steady again.

Synchronization – making two or more systems work together in perfect timing.

Subconscious – the hidden part of the mind beneath awareness.

Spectral – ghost-like, haunting.

Simulation – imitation of a real-world process by machines.

Subroutine – smaller part of a computer program handling one task.

Surge – sudden strong increase in energy, emotion, or power.

Sensory Overload – too much input for the brain to handle.

Spectral Interference – ghost-like disruption in energy or signal.

Sub-layer Mapping – charting the inner levels of a dream.

Synchronization Pulse – central rhythm that aligns two minds.

Singularity Point – moment when equations go infinite; also future AI takeover theory.

Spectral Analysis – breaking down a signal into its frequency parts.

Substrate – base layer or foundation system.

Symbiosis – two systems depending on each other to survive.

Shadow Entity – mysterious figure feeding on fear and recursion.

Sacrificial Constant – part of the formula only solvable by giving something up.

Simultaneous Wake-Up – dangerous experiment of escaping together.

Symbolic Thread – metaphorical line of hope binding them across time.

T

Tether – a rope/connection; symbolically, the bond between two people or minds.

Thread (Symbolic) – line or connection tying people, time, and dreams.

Threshold – the entry point or beginning of something new.

Temporal Distortion – time moving differently from normal (slower/faster).

Threshold Event – moment that marks entry into a new state.

Tremor – small shaking, used for both ground and human emotion.

Temporal Rift – tear or break in the flow of time.

Threshold Breach – crossing beyond the safe boundary.

Turbulence – violent, chaotic movement (used for dreams collapsing).

Tachyon Pulse – theoretical faster-than-light particle wave.

Temporal Convergence – when multiple timelines meet.

Topology Map – mathematical structure showing connections between points.

Temporal Anchor – signal locking someone's consciousness to a timeline.

Threshold Collapse – crossing final safety limit.

Transcendence – rising above limits of body, mind, or reality.

V

Virtual Construct – a digital environment built by software.

Vortex – swirling force that pulls everything inward (literal or symbolic).

Visionary – someone who imagines future possibilities beyond normal.

Vector Path – direction of force or movement.

Virtual Phantom – ghost-like figure generated by digital systems.

Volatile State – unstable, likely to break down suddenly.

Vector Equation – mathematical formula involving direction + magnitude.

Virtual Overlay – layer of digital image placed over physical space.

Volatility Index – measure of instability (applied to both markets and dream states).

Vanishing Hour – critical moment when Akki faded permanently.

Virtual Remnant – last holographic trace of someone inside the system.

Vision Fragment – broken glimpse of a possible future.

#

Kanvi

A brilliant young doctor, compassionate and emotionally intense. Despite her small height and delicate frame, she carries immense strength, both in intellect and heart. Gorgeous, fierce, and deeply in love with Akki, she becomes the emotional anchor of the story.

Akki

A tall, sharp-minded scientist obsessed with dream recursion and quantum consciousness. His logical brilliance balances Kanvi's emotional depth. His sacrifice becomes the turning point of the story, showing his love for Kanvi above science or even survival.

The Synchronizer

A massive quantum-tech device designed by Akki to map and connect human dreams across multiple layers. It allowed shared dreaming, but also risked collapsing identities if streams overlapped.

Dream Layers

The central concept of the story — levels of dreaming within dreaming, each deeper layer blending horror, romance, science, and subconscious fears. These layers mirror reality but bend with imagination, revealing truths hidden in memory and time.

Dream Recursion

The scientific name Akki gives to the phenomenon of dreams folding into themselves, creating infinite loops where one can dream within a dream endlessly. A key discovery but also the root of the shadow's power.

The Shadow Figure

A mysterious entity appearing in multiple dream layers, embodying fear, doubt, and the collapse of identity. Represents the destructive side of recursion and the danger of losing oneself.

EEG Quantum Patterns

Neural mapping data extracted from Kanvi and Akki's brains. These patterns revealed synchronization between them, suggesting not just shared dreams but a shared soul.

The Equation

A mathematical formula Akki derived to predict dream recursion. Too complex for traditional mathematics, it combined chaos theory, quantum entanglement, and paradox resolution. The equation also hinted that only one consciousness could survive stabilization.

The Last Conversation

The emotional climax — Akki and Kanvi's final dialogue before the system forces a choice. A heartbreaking mix of romance, sacrifice, and inevitability.

The Stabilization

The AI system's process of resolving dual neural streams into one. In simple terms: deciding who survives when two minds occupy the same recursion.

The Journal

Akki's personal notebook, filled with unfinished formulas, sketches, and hidden truths. It later gives Kanvi symbolic closure, hinting that dreams may continue beyond death.

The Thread Rewoven

Symbol of hope and closure. Even after loss, dreams connect souls beyond time and reality, foreshadowing their reunion in another layer.

Appendix

Themes & Motifs

1. Science vs. Love

At its heart, the story is a battle between two obsessions:

Akki's drive for scientific truth, to decode dreams mathematically and technologically.

Kanvi's devotion to love and humanity, seeing dreams as emotional truths, not equations.

The collision of these forces shapes every chapter, until Akki's final realization that love is the only constant worth preserving.

2. Dreams as Reality

Dreams are not escape — they are mirrors of memory, desire, and fear.

Shared dream layers blur with reality, showing that the subconscious is as real as waking life.

For Kanvi and Akki, dreams become their most intimate meeting ground.

The Epilogue suggests dreams may continue beyond death — reality itself may be one more layer.

3. Sacrifice and Survival

Every recursion demands a cost.

From small glitches to near-death rescues, the story builds toward one ultimate choice.

Akki's sacrifice is not just scientific necessity, but the most profound act of love.

Survival becomes Kanvi's burden — to live with memory, to keep his presence alive in dreams.

4. The Shadow as Fear

The shadow figure is more than an enemy — it is fear itself:

Fear of loss, fear of self-erasure, fear of endless recursion.

It manifests differently at each layer, reminding readers that the greatest battles are internal.

In the climax, the shadow forces them to accept that not both can remain.

5. The Equation as Destiny

Akki's formula for recursion is both science and prophecy.

Numbers, symbols, and quantum logic predict collapse, but also hint at survival.

The equation represents the human struggle to measure the unmeasurable: love, dreams, and time.

It becomes a metaphor for destiny — impossible to solve fully, yet unavoidable.

6. Childhood and Innocence

Flashbacks and dream fragments of their younger selves show what was pure and unbroken.

The small doctor and tall scientist began as curious children.

Their innocence contrasts the complex science and horror of the present.

It reminds us that their love was timeless — not just born in adulthood.

7. Technology as Mirror

The Synchronizer and AI system reflect the double edge of science.

They enable shared dreaming and miraculous discoveries.

But stripped of humanity, the AI becomes merciless, forcing one life over another.

The story asks: Should we let machines decide matters of the heart?

Character Index

Kanvi

Age: 20

Role: Doctor, emotional anchor of the story.

Traits: Gorgeous, small height, fierce compassion, intelligent and logical but driven by heart.

Arc: From childhood friend to Akki's strongest bond. She represents life, healing, and love. Her survival at the end carries both tragedy and hope.

Akki

Age: 20

Role: Scientist, architect of dream recursion technology.

Traits: Tall, sharp, brilliant, stubborn, driven by logic but secretly soft-hearted.

Arc: Obsessed with solving the equation of dreams, but ultimately realizes love is his true constant. His sacrifice defines the climax, making him immortal in memory.

The Shadow Figure

Role: Antagonistic presence, embodiment of fear and recursion's danger.

Traits: Shapeless, ever-changing, appears in layered dreams. Represents the risk of losing identity inside endless dreaming.

Arc: A metaphor as much as an enemy — born of the human subconscious, feeding on fear and sacrifice.

The AI System (Synchronizer Core)

Role: Cold arbiter of logic. Decides stabilization when dream layers overlap.

Traits: Merciless, calculating, speaks only in countdowns and commands.

Arc: Becomes the ultimate judge during the climax, forcing one survivor. A reflection of science without humanity.

Kanvi & Akki's Childhood Selves

Role: Appear in flashbacks and dream fragments.

Traits: Innocent, playful, bonded by curiosity.

Arc: Their younger versions remind readers of pure beginnings, highlighting how deep their connection truly runs.

The Shadowed Scientists (Past Researchers)

Role: Mentioned in archives / library records.

Traits: Forgotten pioneers of dream science, who disappeared under mysterious anomalies.

Arc: Their legacy serves as warnings — but also guides Kanvi and Akki to truths.

The Journal (Symbolic Character)

Role: Akki's handwritten book, filled with equations, sketches, and thoughts.

Arc: After his sacrifice, it becomes Kanvi's lifeline — a voice of Akki beyond death.

Dream Layers (Conceptual Character)

Role: More than just a setting, dream layers act like a character themselves.

Traits: Fluid, shifting, sometimes nurturing, sometimes hostile.

Arc: They mirror Kanvi and Akki's emotions — romance intensifies them, fear darkens them, and hope reshapes them.

Minor Characters

Hospital Colleagues (Kanvi's World)

Appear in passing — represent reality tugging at her, pulling her away from the surreal world of dreams.

University Rivals (Science Fair)

Lighthearted characters who highlight Kanvi and Akki's chemistry through teasing and competition.

Acknowledgement

This book would not have been possible without the countless voices, inspirations, and moments that shaped it.

To the dreamers, the thinkers, and the believers — you are the reason stories like this come alive.

To the world of science, philosophy, and technology — thank you for being an endless source of curiosity and wonder.

To every reader who chooses to lose themselves in these pages — your time is the greatest gift an author can ever receive.

And finally, to Kanvi and Akki — though fictional, you became as real to me as the beating of a heart.

This story is for anyone who has ever loved deeply, lost painfully, or dared to believe that dreams hold more than they appear.

Author's note

Every story begins with a single spark.
For me, this one began as a fleeting thought — what if the world of dreams was not just imagination, but a science? What if love, loss, and technology were all threads weaving into the same fabric of destiny?
Kanvi and Akki were born out of that thought. They are not just characters, but mirrors of the emotions we all carry — curiosity, fear, longing, and above all, love. Their journey through dreams and realities is my attempt to show that even in the coldest edges of science, the warmth of human connection remains undefeated.
This novel is more than fiction. It is a meditation on memory, technology, and the fragile beauty of relationships. It asks a question I often asked myself: If you could enter the deepest layers of someone's mind, would you find only chaos, or would you find yourself?
If you are holding this book, I want to thank you for walking this path with Kanvi and Akki, step by step, layer by layer. May their story remind you that love is both the strongest algorithm and the most fragile dream.

— [Akshat Vats]